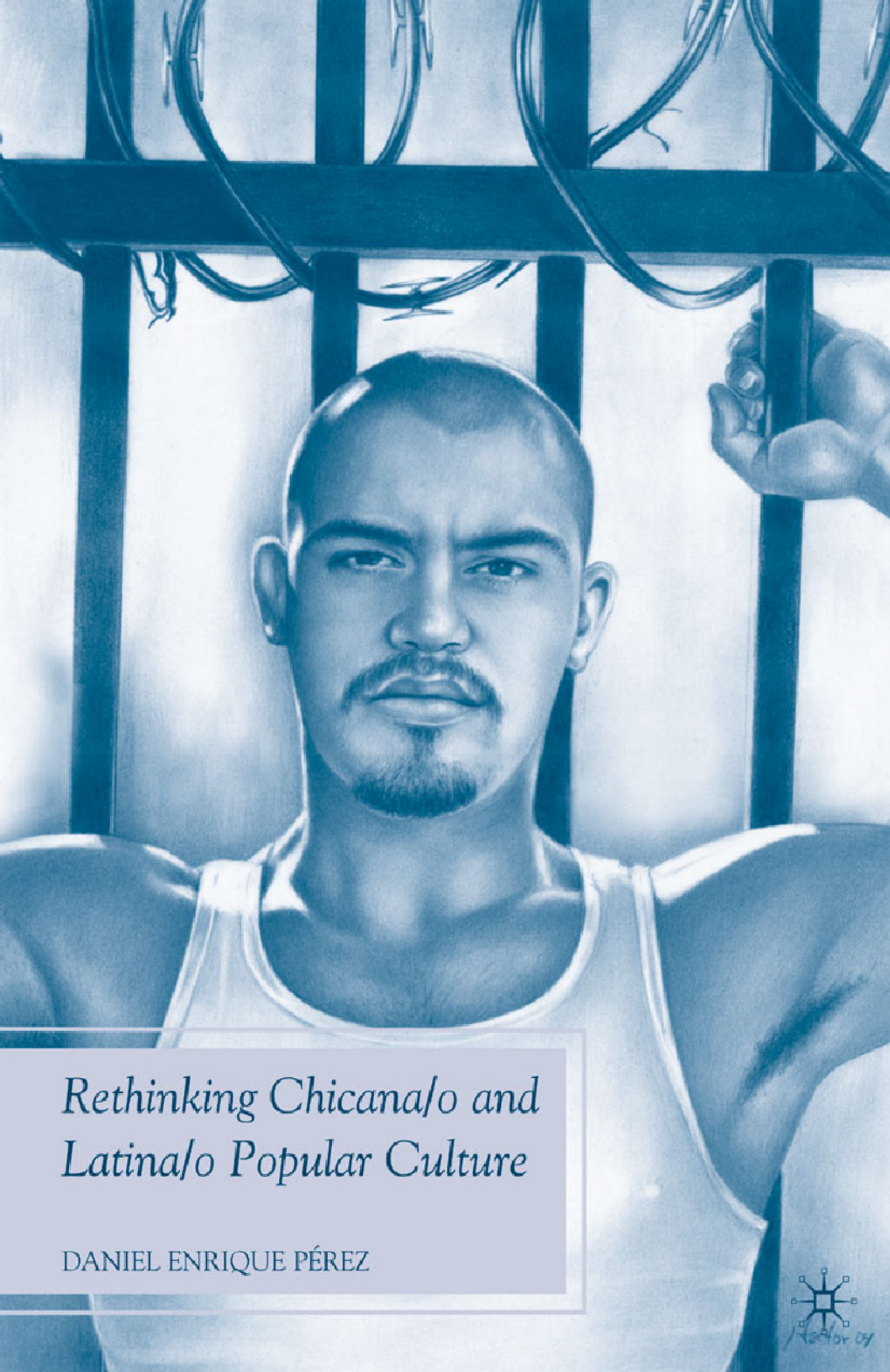


Rethinking Chicana/o and Latina/o Popular Culture

DANIEL ENRIQUE PÉREZ

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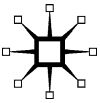
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To all of mi familia in Queer Aztlán
¡Qué viva la jotería!

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A portion of chapter 5, "Man(u)fractured Women: Violence and Queer Identities in Chicana Narratives" was published in *Chicano/Latino Homoerotic Identities*, edited by David William Foster (New York: Garland Publishing, 1999).

Introduction

I have never been all straight.
Everyone has their curveballs.

Chita Rivera[1]

In the years I have spent studying Chicana/o and Latina/o cultural production, I have been intrigued by how much our cultural texts have a tendency to veer from social, sexual, and cultural norms. I find such texts to be imbued with an array of characters and situations that are ultimately queer with respect to family constructs, gender roles, sexuality, aesthetics, and other issues related to identity.

My aim in this book is to demonstrate ways in which Chicana/o and Latina/o cultural texts represent queer identities. Through a gender, ethnicity, and sexuality lens, I examine several of our cultural texts to draw out the nonnormative characteristics innately present in them. I highlight areas where identities are particularly ambiguous and do not conform to normative gender, sexual, behavioral, and aesthetic codes. I show that queer Chicana/o and Latina/o identities are much more prevalent in our cultural production than most people think. Contrary to popular belief, the representation of queer identities in our cultural texts goes well beyond gay Chicana/o and Latina/o stereotypes: *maricones* and *marimachas*.

As identities are constantly evolving and fluctuating, they naturally resist fixed categories of identification. Human beings are rarely the same person from one day to the next exactly because our identities are intrinsically linked to our individual experiences. Experience shapes identity as identity shapes experience—making identities always complex, dynamic, and unique. This is why I choose to use the term *queer*—a term that allows ambiguities, contradictions, and fluctuations to coexist. As Alexander Doty contends, "'Queer' can now point to things that destabilize existing categories, while it is itself becoming a category—but a category that resists easy definition. That is, you can't tell just from the label 'queer' exactly what someone is referring to, except that it is something non-straight or non-normatively straight."[2]

Therefore, *queer* is not intended to be a synonym for *gay*, although some may choose to use it as such. For David William Foster, the term *gay* elicits "a set of sexual identities that refer to a preference for same-sex erotic relations and to whatever overall subjectivity and lifestyle is necessary to ensure the legitimation and realization of homoerotic acts," whereas *queer* can be used to "signify the critique of the heterosexist paradigm."[3] Evident in these theories concerning the definition of the term *queer* is that it is not a singular or static category. Eve Kosofsky Sedgwick points out that "queer is a continuing moment, movement, motive—recurrent, eddying, *troublant*. The word 'queer' itself means *across*—it comes from the Indo-European root—*twerkw*, which also yields the German *quer* (transverse), Latin *torquere* (to twist), English *athwart*."[4] As suggested by these definitions, the way we use the term *queer* is constantly changing, whether it be as a synonym for *gay* or to signify something odd, unusual, or twisted. Nevertheless, it has always had an antithetical relationship to things that are considered straight or normal. As I make clear, the identities I examine in these cultural texts are anything but normative.

As Doty suggests, "Queer readings aren't 'alternative' readings, wishful or willful misreadings, or 'reading too much into things' readings. They result from the recognition and articulation of the complex range of queerness *that has been in popular culture texts and their audiences all along*."[5] Thus, my interest here is not to do queer readings. Instead, I am interested in extrapolating and highlighting the queer characteristics already present in Chicana/o and Latina/o cultural texts. I focus on silences in texts that create ambiguities, examine details that are often overlooked, and analyze nonnormative social and sexual behavior in a variety of contexts.

Considering that *queer* can encompass all aspects of identity that challenge compulsory heterosexuality, heteronormativity, or any other hegemonic paradigms related to identity, it can include a wide range of sexualized subjects and erotic permutations. For example, eroticized homeboys, overweight bodies, or asexual characters can all be considered fruitful sites for mapping queer identities. This opens the door—or closet—to a compendium of queer Chicana/o and Latina/o identities.

To demonstrate the ways in which Chicana/o and Latina/o cultural texts represent queer identities, I offer analyses of an array of characters, images, and narratives. In each, I underscore aspects of identity that digress from hegemonic paradigms of gender, sexuality, and beauty. I argue that such texts represent multifaceted queer

identities as they record the ways Chicanas/os and Latinas/os respond to multiple forms of oppression.

Some popular culture theorists have suggested that popular culture is essentially queer because heteronormative texts are not entertaining, especially to heterosexuals. In other words, queer texts and narratives are economically viable due to the entertainment value that is engendered in them as a result of their disinterest in adhering to cultural norms. Doty explains that "in order to appeal to the largest audience possible it behooves the film and television industries to allow queerness some sort of expression much of the time." [6] Certainly, it makes economic sense to produce queer narratives. Although this may influence Chicana/o and Latina/o popular culture to some degree, I do not believe it is a primary objective, especially considering that our cultural texts are overwhelmingly invested in documenting the actual lives of real people. Chicana/o and Latina/o films, for example, emerged from a documentary tradition, where highlighting issues related to injustices, oppression, identity, and cultural heritage—themes mainstream filmmakers were not addressing—was a priority. Therefore, I am more interested in examining the way that oppression shapes Chicana/o and Latina/o identities in ways that are queer.

I title this book *Rethinking Chicana/o and Latina/o Popular Culture* because it proposes a paradigm shift in the way some have typically viewed Chicana/o and Latina/o identities in our cultural production. Whereas gay and lesbian identities in Chicana/o and Latina/o cultural texts have become increasingly visible, queer identities are not always as easy to discern. As Gloria Anzaldúa reminds us, we are a people shaped by contradictions and ambiguities.[7] These are the aspects of our identities that I am interested in exploring. What is queer about the Latin lover or macho man archetype? What role have Chicanas/os and Latinas/os played in shaping nonnormative aesthetics? What is it about Richard Rubio in *Pocho* that makes him so different? How does the portrayal of Selena in *Selena* disrupt normative gender and sexual roles? What role does the representation of violence play in formulating queer Chicana/o and Latina/o identities?

Many of the texts I examine have become staples of Chicana/o and Latina/o cultural production and some have moved into the realm of popular culture. I include novels, performance art, visual art, films, television shows, and music to demonstrate that what I am describing as a queer phenomenon is not merely speculative or limited in scope. Instead, I show that queerness has always been an integral part of Chicana/o and Latina/o cultural production.

Texts produced by artists who identify as gay or those containing characters who identify as gay are also included in this book. However, I examine them to show how the representation of gay Chicanos and Latinos is also queer in the way it digresses from normative gay codes. Gay Chicano/Latino artists overwhelmingly represent characters that do not adhere to gender or aesthetic norms of the dominant culture, gay or straight. I primarily examine texts and characters that are not traditionally considered gay or lesbian to highlight the manner in which they are queer. By including such a variety of texts, I erase the lines that tend to be drawn to separate gay-marked texts from what are often considered heterosexual ones. I contend that all of these texts share queer configurations that are engendered in Chicana/o and Latina/o cultural production.

Part 1 of the book, "Chicano/Latino Aesthetics," contains two chapters centering on the way the Chicano/Latino male body has been displayed in both popular and Chicano/Latino culture. Chapter 1, "Queer Machos: Gender, Sexuality, Beauty, and Chicano/Latino Men" is an analysis of the homoerotic Chicano/Latino body and the role it plays in shaping male beauty. In this chapter, I examine representations of the male body to demonstrate how gay artists create a queer mestizo identity that does not conform to norms associated with either gay or heteronormative codes. I focus on homoerotic Chicano/Latino aesthetics and show how hegemonic notions of male beauty and masculinity are reconfigured in the works of writers John Rechy and Michael Nava, performance artist Luis Alfaro, playwright Guillermo Reyes, and visual artists Alex Donis and Héctor Silva. These artists diverge from the stereotypical representation of Chicano/Latino men as well as from Western patriarchal heteronormative paradigms by portraying a figure that I argue has been prevalent in Chicano/Latino cultural production for decades: the *queer macho.*

In chapter 2, "(Re)Examining the Latin Lover: Screening Chicano/Latino Sexualities," I take a look at the Latin lover archetype. I trace the trajectory of the Latin lover while focusing on queer issues of the Latin lover identity as it has been portrayed in U.S. popular culture. I include an analysis of Ramón Novarro, Desi Arnaz, and Mario López to show the way the image of the Latin lover has evolved since the early twentieth century and to highlight the way this archetype has shaped discourses on sexuality and male aesthetics overall.

In part 2, "(In)Visible Queer Identities," I conduct queer analyses of a number of Chicana/o and Latina/o cultural texts that have not traditionally been viewed as queer. In chapter 3, "(Re)Reading the Chicano

Literary Canon," I show how three canonical Chicano texts, *Pocho* (1959), *. . . y no se lo tragó la tierra* (1971), and *Bless Me, Ultima* (1972), which have been historically read as heterosexual or heterosexist, can be considered queer. In each, I focus on the young male leading protagonist: Richard Rubio, the unnamed protagonist in *. . . y no se lo tragó la tierra*, and Antonio Márez, respectively. I point out the clues and silences present in these texts that shape a nonnormative social and sexual identity for each protagonist in order to show that all three are queer.

In chapter 4, "La Movie Rara: Viewing Queer Chicana/o and Latina/o Identities," I focus on films that have not traditionally been seen as queer: *My Family/Mi familia* (1995), *Selena* (1997), and *Real Women Have Curves* (2002). Each of the three essays, "*Mi Familia* Rara: Why Paco Isn't Married," "Creating Selena y los Dinos: Queer Mestiza/o Identities," and "Queer Women Have Curves: Legitimizing Nonnormative Chicana/Latina Aesthetics," centers on the way the children and young adults respond to authoritative figures and the dominant culture. In each, the older generation demonstrates a strong interest in replicating the family structure based on a traditional Mexican value system, where heteronormativity determines the role that each member should assume. Various attempts are made to impose such a value system on the lives of the younger generation. These young adults, however, refuse to assume the roles their parents did and the traditional family is never reproduced according to heteronormative standards. Instead, these characters and their bodies become quintessentially queer as they reject, in multiple ways, gender, sexual, and aesthetic norms.

Finally, in part 3: "Violence and Sexuality," I analyze the representation of violence in our cultural texts. Chapter 5, "Rape, Violence, and Chicana/o and Latina/o Identities," focuses on the role violence plays in constructing queer identities. In the first section, "Homeboys, Homegirls and Homoeroticism: Violent Sexual Imagery in *Locas*," I use Yxta Maya Murray's novel *Locas* (1997) to examine representations of violence in gangs. I explore the homosocial environments present in the novel and the nonnormative social and sexual behavior in which the gang members engage in order to form a gang nation. In "Rethinking *American Me*: Identity Politics and Rape Culture in Prisons," I take a look at the representation of rape and violence in the landmark film *American Me* (1992), with a focus on how bodies are queered in the prison system. I show how the body is converted to a docile one and used as a commodity of exchange, which leads to an assortment of queer identities. In the last section, "Man(u)fractured Women: Violence and Queer Identities in Chicana Narratives," I look

at representations of domestic violence in two Chicana texts, Ana Castillo's *So Far from God* (1994) and Alma Luz Villanueva's *Naked Ladies* (1994). These novels present prime examples of women who are subjected to various forms of violence. In each, Chicanas/Latinas form close bonds with other women in order to overcome various forms of oppression: poverty, patriarchy, and homophobia. After being subjected to nonheteronormative acts committed by men through violent means, these women develop intimate relationships with other women that are ultimately homoerotic. In all the texts analyzed in this section, I examine how attempts are made to break down the Chicana/o and Latina/o body and convert it to a docile one in order to be used as a disposable commodity. How characters respond to this process differs among the texts: at times they are forced into an abject state and relegated to a queer status, but other times they resist, regain their autonomy, and choose to engage in nonnormative social and sexual behavior, thereby developing queer identities through their own free will.

All the texts I discuss in this book reflect intimate aspects of the Chicana/o and Latina/o experience and body, and there is something innately queer about them. Through conducting this queer analysis, I show that Chicana/o and Latina/o identities—as they are represented in these cultural texts—are comprised of multifaceted queer configurations. In doing so, I hope to erase that dangerous forward slash that tends to be drawn between the terms *straight* and *gay*.

Designating all the identities that I examine as queer demonstrates how ubiquitous queer identities are in Chicana/o and Latina/o cultural production. Although one might question the degree to which an identity maintains its queerness in the midst of so many possible characteristics that may be deemed queer, the presence of heteronormative discourses automatically positions those who digress from heteronormativity in queer subject positions. Heteronormative discourses are almost always present in these texts, and they are often idealized and privileged. Although identities may reflect some of these traits on the surface, if one analyzes them more closely, one can almost always find queer markings. Things truly never are as they appear, and if one delves deep enough, out comes the queer.

1

Chicano/Latino Aesthetics

1

Queer Machos: Gender, Sexuality, Beauty, and Chicano/Latino Men

> The Hispanic macho goes out of his way to keep up appearances, to exalt his virility, but he often fails. Sooner or later, his glorious masculinity will be shared in bed with another man.
>
> Ilán Stavans [1]

Even though beauty is socially, culturally, and historically variable, it is clear that beauty standards have tended to develop in ways that privilege those who possess the physical attributes most valued in any given society at any given historical moment. As a result, hegemonic paradigms of beauty are established and they, in turn, regulate the visibility of bodies. Certain looks and body types are disproportionately displayed in the media, films, or art of any culture whereas others, especially those deemed abject, are not. The privileging of such bodies comes with real personal and socioeconomic consequences. For example, we now know that people who possess traits deemed beautiful, and especially those that are marked as ideal, are automatically granted several privileges: professional advancement, higher income, more friends, and more sex.[2]

Minoritized groups (women, people of color, queers, people with disabilities, and others) have historically had to contend with their positioning as marginalized subjects whose lives are also shaped by hegemonic paradigms of beauty, which—in the United States and most Western societies—can be classified as Anglo, heterocentric, and patriarchal. As Lesley Higgins argues in *The Modernist Cult of Ugliness*, the "aesthetic ideology within a Western patriarchal system produces a sexual-aesthetic discourse privileging masculinist [*sic*], heterosexual, class-inflected values—a dominant discourse wholly dependent on its constructed Others."[3] Thus, beauty standards in Western culture are primarily shaped by an Anglo, patriarchal, and heteronormative lens that determines what looks and body types are

valuable and merit public display while simultaneously marking Others as not being as valuable and, hence, abject. A beauty hierarchy is established and the aesthetic traits of members of minoritized ethnic groups are, more often than not, less valued than those of the members of the dominant culture.

The displays of bodies that make their way into forms of cultural production shape the everyday lives, experiences, and identities of people. For example, the consistent portrayal of women as erotic objects and of Black men as criminals in the media, as well as in other forms of cultural production, has played a role in maintaining these groups in subjugated positions. In the case of Chicano/Latino men, an array of stereotypes, overwhelmingly negative, abound: Latin lover, buffoon, clown, gang member, drug dealer, "dirty Mexican," and "lazy Mexican." These images have contributed to an aesthetic discourse that has vilified, dismissed, objectified, exoticized, and eroticized Chicano/Latino men. Hegemonic paradigms of beauty that are constructed solely around Anglo, patriarchal, and heteronormative values prevent minoritized people from becoming the beneficiaries of the privileges associated with possessing traits deemed aesthetically valuable by the dominant culture. Therefore, it is imperative to permit the articulation of alternative models of beauty and to recognize that, contrary to popular belief, the aesthetic values of Western culture are not solely constructed around Anglo, patriarchal, or heteronormative codes.

In this chapter, I examine representations of Chicano/Latino men that can and have contributed to a more inclusive paradigm of beauty—extending well beyond the archetypes mentioned above. I highlight queer artists and images of queer Chicano/Latino men that, I assert, have both shaped and shaken up Chicano/Latino aesthetics and male aesthetics overall. The works of writers John Rechy and Michael Nava, performance artist Luis Alfaro, playwright Guillermo Reyes, and visual artists Alex Donis and Héctor Silva reconfigure male aesthetics by diverging from the stereotypical representation of Chicano/Latino men as well as from Western patriarchal heteronormative paradigms of beauty. I focus on a figure that exists in their works and has been prevalent in U.S. cultural production for decades: the *queer macho*. I posit that the queer macho can be used to remove Chicano/Latino men from an abject state to one where they are recognized as valued human beings by allowing them to be portrayed in their full complexity, outside of rigid gender, sexual, and aesthetic codes. The queer macho permits Chicano/Latino men to be portrayed as courageous and heroic, masculine and feminine, (homo)

erotic and beautiful. The queer macho challenges both heteronormative and gay paradigms. His identity resists simple or rigid classification. He is not gay or straight, not masculine or feminine—he just is.

Conceptualizing the Queer Macho

As defined in my introduction, I am employing the term *queer* to describe a wide range of nonheteronormative social and sexual behaviors. As David William Foster contends, queer studies "have become a site for not only bringing race, class, and ethnicity into a discussion of homoeroticism, but for showing that it is imperative to construct a calculus of all elements of subjectivity [*sic*] identity."[4] The term *queer* in this analysis is thus used in order to facilitate a discussion of the role that gender, sexuality, and beauty can play with respect to the formation of a Chicano/Latino homoerotic identity. At the same time, my use of the term is intended to elicit the positive sociopolitical elements that can be associated with the gay rights movement in the United States: activism, courage, and the (in)famous "We're here, we're queer . . ." affirmation.

As for the term *macho*, there is a difference between the way it is used in the United States and in many Spanish-speaking countries. In *Hombres y machos: Masculinity and Latino Culture*, Alfredo Mirandé claims that in U.S. popular culture, "When applied to Mexicans or Latinos, 'macho' remains imbued with such negative attributes as male dominance, patriarchy, authoritarianism, and spousal abuse."[5] Furthermore, he suggests that there is a difference between the Anglo macho and the Latino macho; while the term may be associated with positive attributes for Anglos (manhood and masculinity), it is typically associated with negative ones for Latinos (the oppression and coercion of women). On the other hand, Mirandé underscores that in Mexican popular culture there are often positive attributes associated with machismo: "Machos, according to the positive view, adhere to a code of ethics that stresses humility, honor, respect for oneself and others, and courage" (67). Evident in his analysis of the term is the significant difference in the way Chicano/Latino machos are perceived between Anglos and Mexicans. The queer macho is a product of both cultures and he can be used to reclaim the positive connotations associated with the term *macho*. In repositioning the Chicano/Latino macho to a queer subject position—that is, queering the macho—negative associations are implicitly challenged. Therefore, my use of the term *queer macho* is intended

to elicit the positive attributes one can associate with each of the two terms: honor, respect, and courage.

Queers and machos share a number of traits that can obfuscate the lines that tend to be drawn between the two archetypes. The queer macho is a combination of two figures that are almost always caricatured and placed in diametrically opposing positions in popular culture: the *macho* and the *maricón* (the Anglo counterparts might be the "man's man" and the "faggot," respectively). Certainly, the stereotypical representations of these two figures are not accurate depictions of the wide range of complex identities and experiences that actually exist among Chicano/Latino men. The limitations such caricatures place on the articulation of alternative forms of identity create one-dimensional portrayals that are constantly reiterated. However, the queer macho is an excellent subject for examining the multiplicity of complex Chicano/Latino identities that do exist. The queer macho destabilizes the straight/gay and *macho/maricón* binary, thereby allowing for the possibility of a Chicano/Latino gender and sexual continuum where queers can be considered macho and vice versa. Moreover, the synthesis of the two subjects facilitates the reconfiguration of notions related to gender, sexuality, beauty, and Chicano/Latino men.

The *maricón* figure is typically associated with gay Chicano/Latino men who exhibit effeminate behavior. In *Eminent Maricones: Arenas, Lorca, Puig, and Me*, Colombian writer Jaime Manrique contends that the term is used "as a way to dismiss gay men as an incomplete and worthless kind of person."[6] However, he engages in the process of resignifying the term by recognizing and accepting that he is one and by associating it with three renowned queer Hispanic writers—Reinaldo Arenas, Federico García Lorca, and Manuel Puig. Moreover, Manrique points out that authors such as Arenas, Lorca, and Puig "spoke for the oppression of the marginal" and "had the *cojones* that many heterosexual writers lacked" (113). "And thus," he asserts, "I arrived at the true meaning of *Eminent Maricones—locas, patos, jotos*—who achieved true eminence by the courageous audacity of their examples" (113). By placing himself among these three queer writers, he formulates a unified front of *maricones* as anticolonial figures readily engaged in a form of social transformation: legitimating the abject, combating homophobia, speaking for the oppressed.

Similarly, in his essay "Nationalizing Sissies," José Piedra reverses the traditional roles assigned to *maricones* by claiming that "sissy behavior" can be seen as a "nation-building trick: an active mediation in the exchanges between colonizers and colonized, a role or type

ready to qualify, modify, taint, neutralize, and even trap—at least into an illusion of domination—whomever and whatever attempts to occupy him/her or his/her territory."[7] In this way, a *maricón* becomes what Piedra refers to as a "model anticolonialist or postcolonial being" and "a rebellious agent in the colonial exchange" (375). Thus, the *maricón* can be seen as an active agent who challenges hegemonic structures—namely, patriarchy and heteronormativity.

By giving the quintessential *maricón* figure *cojones* and other traditionally masculine traits, both Piedra and Manrique empower the *maricón* by associating him with valuable attributes that can play a role in removing him and others like him from their historically abject state. As a result, the queer subject is legitimized and approximates a macho identity while deflecting the negative attributes that can be associated with either figure. I consider these men queer machos because they refuse to accept the "failed men" status that is often imposed on them. Moreover, they combat homophobic and misogynist acts that can be directed at them for exhibiting same-sex or effeminate behavior.

Theorizing the queer macho involves removing both figures, the queer and the macho, from their historically abject state. Both subjects become legitimized through removing each from the margins. In other words, neither remains positioned at either extreme of the gender or sexual continuum—a task that is necessary in order to dismantle the negative stereotypes that are often associated with each figure. While undergoing this process, they are also both freed from the limitations that categories of gender, sexuality, and beauty impose on Chicano/Latino men, thereby allowing their nonnormative bodies and stories to materialize, be visible, and take center stage. Queer machos are both masculine and feminine; a direct correlative might be neither masculine nor feminine. They possess the courage to be who they are, without bowing completely to the heteronormative or ethnocentric precepts of the dominant culture.

One experience that Chicano/Latino men and Chicano/Latino/Anglo gay men share is that they have traditionally been portrayed as abject men. Regardless of the nature of the image of these figures in cultural production ("Latin lover," "macho," "sissy," "faggot," or "*maricón*") they have typically been subjected to some form of emasculation. That is, these men inevitably get marked by some characteristic that threatens or diminishes their masculinity: lack of money/power, inability to speak polished English, lisps, mannerisms. As Manrique and Piedra demonstrate, sometimes they attempt to reposition themselves from a state of being emasculated to one where they

possess some form of agency. Overwhelmingly, the road to such a location requires attaining what are perceived as valued masculine attributes. Many queer theorists believe that this is one explanation for the relatively new and ubiquitous image of the muscular and masculine gay male body and the concomitant emergence of a male aesthetic in the United States that is based on the display of such bodies.[8]

In "Beauty (Re)Discovers the Male Body," Susan Bordo contends that the standards for male beauty we witness today can be traced precisely to gay male aesthetics. Moreover, she argues that they are designed to appeal to both men and women and that they signify the commodification of male beauty, not so much the commodification of men:

> Feminists might like to imagine that Madison Avenue heard our pleas for sexual equality, and finally gave us "men as sex objects." But what's really happened is that women have been the beneficiaries of what might be described as a triumph of pure consumerism—and with it, a burgeoning male fitness and beauty culture—over homophobia and the taboos against male vanity, male "femininity," and erotic display of the male body that have gone along with it.[9]

Bordo highlights the way in which images of the male body in advertising are replete with masculine signifiers—certain types of clothing or lack thereof, defined muscles, and bulges in the crotch area—that permit it to be eroticized and consumed by mass culture. She explains how Calvin Klein utilized such images to construct a masculine male aesthetic that played a role in making men sex objects of sorts, claiming that

> [Klein] also knew that gay sex wouldn't sell to straight men. But the rock-hard, athletic gay male bodies that Klein admired at the Flamingo did not advertise their sexual preference through the feminine codes—limp wrists, raised pinkie finger, swishy walk—which the straight world then identified with homosexuality. Rather, they embodied a highly masculine aesthetic that—although definitely exciting for gay men—would scream "heterosexual" to (clueless) straights. (123)

She concludes that images of masculinity play multiple roles for a variety of consumers, independent of sex, sexuality, or gender. Thus, an aesthetic history of a muscular male body designed to represent ideal forms of masculinity is established. However, this aesthetic history of has failed to take into account the role that Chicano/Latino men

have played in creating a popular male aesthetic or the way they have responded to the messages they receive regarding male beauty.

I argue that Chicano and Latino artists have contributed to the popular standards of masculinity and male beauty that shape the U.S. cultural landscape. The Latin lover and macho stereotypes, in particular, have influenced Anglo male aesthetics and behavior since the early twentieth century, an often overlooked phenomenon.[10] More recently, gangster/homeboy aesthetics have made their way into popular culture and transformed the fashion industry. By the same token, Chicano and Latino men and their bodies have been shaped by Anglo male and gay Anglo male aesthetics. In *Imperial Eyes: Travel Writing and Transculturation*, Mary Louise Pratt explains that even though subjugated people have little control, if any, over what the dominant culture transmits, they process the information and knowledge they receive from it in unique ways and then determine what they will use and how they will use it. In other words, the way Chicano and Latino men respond to some of the messages they receive regarding hegemonic male aesthetics may be quite different from the way Anglo males do. Moreover, I contend that the Chicano/Latino artists I examine here engage in a process of reconfiguring notions of male beauty both by not subscribing to the aesthetic norms transmitted by dominant Anglo culture and by creating unique male aesthetics that influence it. These queer Chicano and Latino artists have participated in such a process by interrogating notions of gender, sexuality, and beauty through creating queer macho representations of men that go well beyond the stereotypes of Chicano/Latino men found in U.S. popular culture.

Writing the Queer Macho: John Rechy and Michael Nava

Gay Chicano writers John Rechy and Michael Nava have consistently portrayed a unique queer macho identity and aesthetic in their works. Whereas the queer macho in Rechy's novels challenges the tendency to associate male beauty solely with Anglo men, the queer macho in the works of Nava is a rebellious agent who combats homophobia and the institutions that harbor it.

Rechy is one of the first Chicano writers to establish a queer macho figure and aesthetic. He is a best-selling author who has written several books that center on homoerotic desire. The contributions he has made to a discourse on male aesthetics and male homoeroticism is unparalleled. Rechy played a significant role in transforming the portrayal of

gay men in cultural production. In fact, the publication of *City of Night* (1963) is considered a landmark event in the history of gay culture in the United States and abroad; it spent a number of weeks as a national best seller and has been translated into several languages.

Rechy's protagonists tend to frequent gay ghettos, like the Village in New York or West Hollywood, and are often described as very masculine and "good-looking." The author underscores and extols the masculinity and beauty of his leading characters to the extent that he creates an idealized image of the male body—emblematic of the gay macho clone who emerged in the United States during the 1970s. Michael P. Levine describes this figure in the following manner:

> They expressed their new sense of self by wearing the attire of the working class (Altman 1982), which led to the emergence of the clone. Traditional masculine themes were heartily embraced—in part as a new kind of camp (as in the various over-the-top displays of gay disco groups like The Village People), and in part as a vigorous assertion of a newfound, and passionately embraced successful masculinity.[11]

The gay macho clone is closely related to the queer macho figure I am examining here, especially in the sense of being an anticolonialist being. As Michelangelo Signorile explains, this newfound masculinity was a response to the way gay men were being treated: "After many years of being stigmatized and stereotyped as effeminate and as less than manly, many of these white, middle-class gay men also proudly and enthusiastically conformed to an idealized version of physical manhood—muscles, mustaches, and tight jeans."[12] The distinction I would make between the gay macho clone and the queer macho is that the former is largely associated with a rigid gay Anglo male aesthetic—one that often excludes men of color or men who are actually working-class—whereas the queer macho embodies an aesthetic that is much more elastic, diverse, and inclusive.

Because *City of Night* was published in 1963, before the emergence of the gay macho clone in gay Anglo culture, Rechy can be placed among the artists who shaped the gay male aesthetic that in turn shaped the current male aesthetic that Bordo describes. In fact, Rechy's novels span from 1963 to the present: almost a half century of portraying male homoeroticism and ideal masculine male bodies in popular culture. Moreover, Rechy was influential in creating a discourse on Chicano/Latino aesthetics despite the criticism that he tends not to make ethnicity a central component of his characters' identities.

Perhaps due to the lack of ethnic cultural signifiers in his name and his Caucasian features, many assume Rechy is Anglo.[13] Nevertheless,

his leading protagonists are often Chicano and created in his image.[14] For example, in *City of Night* the narrator and unnamed protagonist describes his father as "that strange man who had traveled from Mexico to California spreading his seed … who then married my Mother, a beautiful Mexican woman who loves me fiercely" (14). The fact that this information is given to the reader at all and that it is disclosed at the beginning of the novel suggests that such cultural factors are significant to the development of the protagonist's identity. In *Numbers* (1967), the protagonist's name, Johnny Rio (a diminutive of the author's first name and bearing his same initials), and the description of his "dreary fatherless Mexican Catholic childhood" (22) are just a few of the cultural signifiers that mark the protagonist as Chicano. In fact, this novel offers an even closer look at the protagonist's physical features than does *City of Night*. In *Numbers*, the narrator informs the reader that "Johnny's father, now dead, was Irish. His mother is Mexican … From them he inherited a smooth complexion which sponges the sun's rays easily … Each summer his skin becomes like brown velvet" (18). The protagonist's dark skin is underscored and extolled on occasion; he is also described as an "angel of dark sex" (16). Certainly, "dark sex" can be interpreted as unsanctioned sex (between men), but it can justifiably be a reference to sex with a Chicano/Latino man. Furthermore, on occasion Johnny Rio uses Spanglish. For example, when the narrator describes how the protagonist handles a situation where he might confuse a "payer" (for sex) with someone who is merely a "number" (sexual conquest), he explains that Johnny would "try to right the situation something like this: 'Oh, gee, *mano*,' using the hip Mexican appellation, 'I knew you weren't the paying kind'" (33).[15] Thus, the protagonists in Rechy's novels often possess Chicano identity markings that should not be overlooked.

Indeed, Rechy's protagonists—like the author—do appear to physically possess the ability to pass as Anglo men. However, their identities are constructed around Anglo *and* Chicano traits: a father of European heritage and a mother of Mexican heritage, the use of Spanglish. The presence of these and the other Chicano cultural signifiers mentioned above are markings that disrupt the "passing" of these characters as exclusively Anglo. As Judith Butler contends, "What qualifies as a visible marking is a matter of being able to read a marked body in relation to unmarked bodies, where unmarked bodies constitute the currency of normative whiteness."[16] Therefore, Rechy's protagonists are not Anglo even though they may possess the ability to pass as Anglo men. What is more, the fact that a Chicano/Latino man can be portrayed as an ideal form of mainstream

male beauty challenges the tendency to associate beauty exclusively with whiteness.

Rechy's descriptions of men emphasize muscles, masculinity, and the ideal male body. They also typically and intentionally possess working-class markings that create a hypermasculine identity. At the same time, the male aesthetics are refined and polished, much like the gay macho clone described by Levine and Signorile. The characters take care of their bodies and are obviously concerned—often obsessed—with their physical appearance, but rarely to the degree that they might be associated with what may be perceived as "feminine" traits or with the recent metrosexual prototype. Elsewhere I have argued that homophobia, particularly internalized homophobia, is at play here.[17] For fear of being labeled a "failed man" or "weak," Rechy's protagonists' bodies are marked with masculine traits: youth, muscles, manly behavior, and working-class attributes. The queer macho is constructed as a paragon of male beauty that is intended to appeal to both sexes, even though he engages in sex with other men. Take, for example, the description in *Numbers* that Rechy gives of the effect his protagonist, Johnny Rio, has on others: "Again, as with all truly sexually desirable men, he attracts both sexes—even, among his own sex, some who will never recognize that attraction, who will feel it, disguised, only as a certain anger and resentment toward him. Johnny is used to a type of man, usually married, who will try to quarrel with him instantly" (18). This description bears much resemblance to the ideal male bodies Bordo describes—beautiful male bodies that have a universal appeal, regardless of the observer's sex, sexuality, or gender. The attraction that others experience for the protagonist is both mystical and dangerous. Making the character sexually desirable and, in essence, irresistible to the point that his beauty instigates conflict with others, stresses the magnitude of his beauty and creates a beauty paradigm that is primarily constructed around ideal masculine physical characteristics. Consider the following description of the protagonist: "He is very masculine, and he has been described recurrently in homosexual jargon as 'a very butch number' " (16). In order to prevent him from being associated with an artificial masculinity, he is also described as authentic and natural: "A slight crook in his nose keeps him from being a prettyboy [*sic*] and makes him, therefore, much more attractive and masculine" (16). Like most of Rechy's protagonists, Johnny Rio is obsessed with his body and working out; however, in an attempt to maintain the image of an inherent and more natural form of masculinity and maleness, his

muscles are not overdeveloped: "Johnny has a slender, muscular body. In the past few years he has exercised diligently with weights—not in order to become one of those rigid grotesques with coconut muscles that bear no relation whatever to the natural lines of the body, but to keep lithe and hard. This he has accomplished eminently" (17). It is important to recognize that these descriptions create an image of the male body as ideally masculine and aesthetically appealing while also embodying the Chicano cultural signifiers that make up the protagonist's identity: his Mexican heritage, his dark skin, and his use of Caló (Spanglish).

The queer macho in the works of John Rechy represents an aesthetic that has become mainstream and that has been used to determine what qualifies as masculine and beautiful. In his works, the queer macho represents a form of ideal male beauty even though he engages in sex with men and retains Chicano cultural signifiers. Although the emphasis on the physical may be seen as superficial, it becomes a means of repositioning gay Chicano/Latino men as legitimate by their ability to achieve and portray idealized forms of male beauty that are recognized by the dominant culture.

Whereas Rechy focuses on physical male beauty, Michael Nava depicts the queer macho in his works as an agent of social justice—adding an ethical dimension to the queer macho that can be considered an alternative, nonphysical form of male beauty that is also associated with the anticolonial figures Jaime Manrique and José Piedra describe. The leading protagonist in his well-received series of detective novels, Henry Rios, is a Chicano gay lawyer who possesses valuable personal attributes that place him among the queer machos I am examining here. His profession and his commitment to social justice become sites for evaluating Chicano/Latino aesthetics that transcend physical manifestations of male beauty.[18]

The series spans a fifteen-year period and includes seven novels. It began with the publication of *The Little Death* (1986) and ended with *Rag and Bone* (2001). Throughout the series, Henry Rios struggles with alcoholism, failed relationships, the death of a lover to AIDS, and the reality of living in a racist and homophobic society. Nevertheless, Rios manages to overcome the many obstacles he encounters; he also contributes to a discourse on the advancement of gay rights. In fact, the novels center largely on the injustices that gay men and lesbians experience while Rios assumes the responsibility of advocating on their behalf.

Rios can be seen as an anticolonialist figure—and hence, queer macho—in the way he asserts a gay identity even when in homophobic

environments; he advocates for gay rights on behalf of gay men and lesbians who are the victims of homophobia and violence; he becomes a good and ethical lawyer who fights for social justice. The combination of all these characteristics allows him to affirm an out and proud gay identity while utilizing his professional training to engage in transforming or destroying the institutions that attempt to subjugate gay men and lesbians.

From the beginning of *The Little Death*, signs materialize that reveal Rios's commitment to combating homophobia and speaking for the oppressed. As the novel opens, Rios arrives at his office in the county jail and is preparing to review some of the arrests made overnight. After the deputy, Novack, describes the arrest of Hugh Paris, Rios asks him where the detainee is. Novack responds, "In the drunk tank with the queens. He's a fag" (11). Rios responds immediately to Novack's homophobic remark: "That's no crime," and adds, "I reminded him" (11). This interchange positions Rios as someone who challenges homophobic remarks. His words speak for those who might remain silent when such remarks are uttered. The careful use of "I reminded him" insinuates that this is not the first time Rios has had to confront Novack regarding such matters.

On a number of occasions, Rios also asserts his identity as a gay man. The first incident takes place when he meets Hugh Paris in jail at the beginning of the novel. Paris says to Rios, "You're gay," and Rios matter-of-factly affirms, "Yes, I am" (14). In the context of the San Francisco Bay Area in the 1980s (the time of the onset of the AIDS crisis in the United States), such affirmations made between strangers in a homophobic space (the jailhouse, with Novack next door) are fraught with risks. Rios's conviction and courage expand beyond his interactions with other gay men and get to the point where they espouse gay rights by addressing issues pertinent to gay identity politics. For example, when Rios meets his heterosexual friend and colleague Aaron Gold for drinks, Rios reveals to him that he has developed an interest in Hugh Paris that goes beyond a professional or friendly relationship. Gold tries to stop Rios from divulging intimate aspects of his gay lifestyle during their conversation, but Rios challenges the hypocrisy of this request: "Listen, Aaron, I get to thrill to your accounts of your latest girlfriend, but you treat me like a eunuch. You confide in me, but I can't confide in you? Are we friends, or what?" (30). Gold tries to justify his behavior as a typical reaction by someone who recently found out his best friend is gay by saying, "It's just difficult. Give me time" (30). To which Rios responds, "I told you [I was gay] ten years ago" (30). By not allowing Gold to

institute double standards that privilege a heterocentric discourse, Rios engages in the advancement of a gay sociopolitical agenda. The time reference also sounds an alarm of sorts warning Gold that Rios is losing his patience. Such exchanges create a discourse that highlights injustices and advocates for a number of gay and lesbian rights.

During the time Rios and Hugh are attempting to establish their relationship, they meet one evening in the Castro district of San Francisco. As they walk down Castro Street (world renowned as a gay cultural landscape), Paris reaches over and takes Rios's hand. As the couple walk out of the Castro District, Paris lets go of Rios's hand, both well aware that they are no longer in the confines of a "safe" gay zone, both apprehensive because of the homophobia they know exists. However, Rios does not allow homophobia to interfere with his new romance. In an eloquent moment, Rios puts his hand back in Paris's and they walk thus joined, prepared to confront homophobia together: "He looked at me, startled, then tightened his grip. And life went on" (44).

In his essay "Michael Nava: Sleuthing Homophobia," David William Foster contends that homophobia is the principal force at play in maintaining Rios in a marginal position. He claims that homophobia excludes Rios from participating in Anglo-dominant spaces by making him a "nonbeing."[19] The way Rios responds to the repeated attempts by others to subjugate him and other gay men is of utmost value to the formation of a queer macho identity in Nava's works. Throughout the series, Rios challenges homophobic policies and institutions; he undertakes the arduous task of exposing corruption and dismantling the institutions that harbor homophobia as a way of destroying it, and he works diligently to solve a number of mysterious crimes that involve the murder of gay men in order to avenge their deaths.

Rios never accepts his marginalization; he makes an effort to separate himself from Anglo-dominant institutions, especially the two he perceives as bastions of homophobia that are controlled by rich Anglo heterosexual males—legal and corporate institutions. In *The Little Death*, he decides to resign from his position as a public defense attorney and start his own practice.[20] He thus gains more freedom to advance the cases and causes he values. He uses his independence to pursue the people and institutions that are responsible for the violent deaths of gay men. In *The Little Death*, homophobic corporate power is controlled by the patriarchs in Hugh Paris's family: the Pegasus Corporation and the prized Grover Linden estate.

Paris, the rightful heir to the estate, is mysteriously murdered. Had he lived, the youngest surviving male member of the affluent family, a legacy of compulsory heterosexuality and hegemonic masculinity would have come to an end. The fact that he was gay and had not produced any offspring would have meant not only the transfer of power from a homophobic patriarchal corporate institution to a gay man, but also the end of a lineage of homophobic patriarchs. It is up to Rios to avenge Paris's death by going after the corporation and the men responsible for his murder. When Rios discovers that John Smith, Paris's uncle, was responsible for his death, Smith tries to bribe Rios to drop the lawsuit, which would destroy the corporation by making a series of wrongful deaths and illegal financial dealings public in a court of law. But Rios, as an agent of social justice, wants to punish Smith to the full extent of the law: "It's never been a matter of money. I want an admission of guilt. I want that admission in open court and for the record. I want the law to run its course. No secret pay-offs, no cover-ups" (163). Rios's advocacy on behalf of gay men who become victims of violent acts and other injustices is a form of implementing social justice in sites he believes must be transformed.

Hence, Rios becomes a hero of sorts. He possesses valued traits while affirming a gay identity: being a defense lawyer, solving difficult cases, actively fighting evildoers, helping victims, combating homophobia, and being a paragon of social justice. In this way, the queer macho develops an ethical, almost heroic, aspect that contributes to an aesthetic discourse transcending the privileging of physical manifestations of masculinity and male beauty.

Overwhelmingly, the queer macho in the works of Rechy and Nava is constructed through the act of attributing masculine and valued traits to gay men, both physical (Rechy) and nonphysical (Nava). One interesting feature of these characters is that they tend to follow sociosexual behaviors that preclude them from being feminized, namely, maintaining an *activo* status. As Tomás Almaguer proposes, the sexual behavior and identity of Chicano men is shaped by two different sexual systems, the European American and the Mexican/Latin American, where men are defined according to the roles they assume during sexual acts, not by the lifestyle they lead: "In the Mexican/Latin-American context there is no cultural equivalent to the modern gay man. Instead of discrete sexual personages differentiated according to sexual preference, we have categories of people defined in terms of the role they play in the homosexual act. The Latin homosexual is divided into *activos* and *pasivos*."[21] To be

the receiver during sexual intercourse constitutes feminizing the subject, whereas to be the penetrator, regardless of the sexual object choice, is to affirm one's masculinity. Both Rechy and Nava appear to be concerned with maintaining their leading characters' masculine identity by maintaining their *activo* status. While this may be seen as a form of reinforcing hegemonic masculinity, it can also be seen as a reconfiguration of masculine norms. In the same way that gay Anglo men appropriated masculine physical attributes in an attempt to legitimize their bodies and themselves as valued members of society while affirming their nonnormative sexuality, these authors assign what are perceived as valued attributes to queer Chicano/Latino men to legitimate their existence and affirm their sexuality. Certainly, the privileging of masculinity comes at the expense of contributing to an anti-feminine ethos, a by-product of a rigid patriarchal paradigm that influences their work. However, the fact that nonnormative sexuality remains an integral component of the identities of these characters reconfigures notions of masculinity by permitting the representation of attractive and heroic men who have sex with men. In this way, the queer macho resists any attempt to be relegated exclusively to either extreme of the *macho-maricón* spectrum. This is an integral stage in the development of a queer macho identity that is not constructed around the privileging of exclusive forms of masculinity or beauty.

Performing the Queer Macho: Luis Alfaro and Guillermo Reyes

Performance artist Luis Alfaro and playwright Guillermo Reyes destabilize the *activo/pasivo* binary through the representation of queer Chicano/Latino men in their works. They allow alternative forms of gender, sexuality, and beauty to emerge that are much more ambiguous. They both remove the Chicano/Latino body from its historically marginalized position by affirming the existence of a wide range of Chicano/Latino identities that digress from normative codes without an emphasis on idealized forms of masculinity or male beauty. The queer macho image they produce discombobulates traditional notions of gender, sexuality, and beauty in particular by presenting Chicano/Latino men in nonheteronormative ways while highlighting their ethnicity and their status as worthy, legitimate human beings.

Alfaro undertakes such a task through the use of his own body; it functions as a vehicle to transport images, stories, messages, and

characters that do not subscribe to norms associated with either heteronormative codes or normative gay codes of Anglo or Chicano/Latino culture. In his collection of performance pieces, "Cuerpo Politizado" (1994), Alfaro uses his nonnormative body as a model anticolonialist figure. In one performance piece of this collection, "Vistiendo en Drag," Alfaro assumes the voice of a transvestite that is far from conventional:

> I'm bigger than most
> of the ramp walkers.
> Runaway
> from the runway.
> Dare to show
> bulge in my crotch
> because I am
> that tough.[22]

It is apparent that the narrator does not subscribe to traits typically associated with a transvestite. The narrator's larger than normal body and masculine crotch separates her/him from the traditional transvestite, who attempts to achieve and represent feminine ideals. The participant observer must reconfigure normative notions of gender, sexuality, ethnicity, and beauty through the transvestite's articulation of her-/himself as a masculine erotic model who does not subscribe to ideal representations of various elements of identity. As Foster suggests, in Alfaro's performance art he refuses to:

> propose an ideal Chicano gay identity, a complex of body-based material and psychological factors that would constitute a unifying opposition against the combined weight of Anglo stereotypes of social marginalization and homophobia and their Chicano reinscriptions. Concomitantly, Alfaro also rejects an ideal Chicano bodily presence, and his interpretations are just as laceratingly funny when they are directed against Chicano stereotypes as they are against the dominant Anglo ones that impose themselves as part of the imperative of conforming homogeneity in U.S. middle-class society.[23]

Alfaro thus creates an identity that does not correspond to the gender, social, or sexual norms related to Chicano/Latino or Anglo culture. He often assumes female roles without the usual gender markings one might expect. He may don a dress and one or two other articles of clothing or accessories normally associated with women; however, he may not feminize his character in any other way. In this manner,

not only does Alfaro refuse to conform to normative standards for female aesthetics in society, he also digresses from normative standards for drag culture, where the intention is frequently to create the illusion of being a "real" woman by approximating physical feminine ideals as much as possible or to create an over-the-top woman with exaggerated feminine features as a form of comic relief. Alfaro proudly displays obvious masculine traits—the hair on his chest and his mustache, or a bold and masculine stance—while wearing a dress and women's shoes (flats, not high heels as is customary in drag culture). In this manner, Alfaro juxtaposes traits that are stereotypically associated with both genders to allow an ambiguity that corresponds to the queer macho.

In essence, he engages in what is considered "gender bending" or "gender fucking," an act Foster describes as:

> a radical destabilization of the semiotics of dress and the signs of body language, such that, rather than collaborating with the always precarious effort to maintain the gender binary through strict processes of homologization that allows for the ready reading of a particular body as feminine or masculine, serves to confound such attempts to maintain a semiotic stability for binary structures. (157)

For Foster, Alfaro's act of queering his own body results in the formation of transgressive gender codes that destabilize the masculine/feminine and male/female binaries. As a result, the *activo/pasivo* binary is also dismantled. In this manner, Alfaro subverts patriarchal heteronormativity and simultaneously destroys binary structures. Moreover, he creates a transgressive queer mestizo body through the fusion of cultures and genders that resists any form of categorization and materializes characters with multipositional identities that permit the body to be male and female, queer and macho.

Chilean American playwright Guillermo Reyes also includes a representation of what I consider queer machos in his works. His characters are often gender or sexually ambiguous. Like Alfaro, Reyes interrogates conventional constructions of various elements of identity. He has written a number of queer-themed Chicano/Latino plays that have been produced throughout the United States. His play *Deporting the Divas* (1996) is a good example of the way he engages in the act of gender bending. The queer macho in this work is constructed around an aesthetic discourse that hijacks the social and cultural norms of the dominant culture in order to reconfigure them.

In *Deporting the Divas*, the queer macho represents a form of beauty that is aligned with ideal notions of Anglo female beauty; however, this representation takes form only in the narrative and through the characters' gazes. There is no actual attempt to materialize the markings traditionally associated with this aesthetic. Instead, while the characters in the play do not acknowledge it, the actors intentionally possess gender and ethnic markings associated with Chicano/Latino men: masculine features and accents. For example, Miss Fresno is a transvestite from Guatemala who passes as an Anglo woman in the narrative. She also wins the all-American Miss Fresno and Miss California beauty pageants. For the characters in the play, Miss Fresno represents the normative feminine Anglo ideal. Conversely, for the theater-going public, her masculine characteristics stand out: a deep voice, masculine body, and ethnic markings. Therefore, the public is forced to rethink normative ideas with regard to gender and ethnicity in order to fully participate in the narrative the play proposes. Ironically, the misrecognition of Miss Fresno in the play is facilitated by the "Miss" recognition of the character in the narrative and the masculine and ethnic markings the audience recognizes and receives. This strategy allows Miss Fresno to be read as both male and female, Anglo and Chicano, active and passive. Miss Fresno represents an aesthetic ideology that does not privilege masculinity, femininity, heteronormativity, whiteness, or Chicano aesthetics.

Miss Fresno's character challenges an array of issues related to identity. She passes as a beautiful Anglo woman and U.S. citizen despite being a male Guatemalan undocumented immigrant (figure 1.1). Even though she has the privilege of passing as a valued member of the dominant culture, Miss Fresno experiences emotional conflict and turmoil related to the rejection of her "true" identity. She ultimately decides to disclose her true identity to Michael, a Chicano border patrol agent who is enthralled by her beauty:

> *Fresno*: I'm . . . I'm an illegal alien, OK?
> *Michael*: But you can't be. You're Miss Fresno, the favorite to win Miss California.
> *Fresno*: I'm a Guatemalan of German descent, so I pass as they say. I've got no papers, so it's your job to. . .
> *Michael*: I know my job, miss, but you're not a—you're not! You can't be.[24]



Figure 1.1 Actor Andrés Alcalá as Miss Fresno, *Deporting the Divas*, Miracle Theatre, Portland, OR, 1999

This is the first of the two secrets Miss Fresno tries to divulge in her attempt to unveil aspects of her identity that are not visible. As the exchange between Miss Fresno and Michael continues, Miss Fresno also tries to reveal that she is not biologically female:

Fresno: (*Deeper voice.*) Look pendejo, I'm hiding a lot more than my legal status, ok?
Michael: Like what?
Fresno: What I really am is a . . . a . . . well, let me show you. (*Starts unbuttoning her dress.*)
Michael: (*More intimidated by this.*) Wait! Maybe I don't want to know!
Fresno: Nobody does! Nobody cares! (*She cries and hugs him.*)[25]

Michael's refusal to accept either secret is an effort to maintain stable ethnic and gender norms, which becomes obligatory as he begins to question his own sexuality. Because he finds himself emotionally and sexually attracted to Miss Fresno, accepting that she is not biologically female would require that he confront a possible nonnormative identity for himself. Instead, he relegates Miss Fresno to the optical illusion she is intended to represent despite the materialization of signs that threaten to break the illusion.

In the narrative and in Michael's eyes, Miss Fresno does not possess a visible marking that allows her to be read as anything other than an Anglo woman, despite her/his effort to articulate and reveal alternative identities. As Miss Fresno mentions, she/he passes, and, according to Judith Butler, an unmarked body constitutes normative whiteness.[26] In this way, like many of Reyes's other characters, she/he hijacks then reconfigures notions of gender, sexuality, ethnicity, and aesthetics because her body is actually marked by ethnic and gender signifiers that do not correspond to normative notions of whiteness or Anglo aesthetics. The act of an undocumented gay male Guatemalan immigrant passing as a heterosexual Anglo female citizen of the United States with ideal feminine traits simultaneously critiques Anglo female aesthetics and affirms Chicano/Latino aesthetics. Miss Fresno's official title as beauty queen legitimizes her/his body despite the abject state the other gender, sexual, and cultural signifiers could impose. The ethnic and masculine gender markings of the actor vis-à-vis the Anglo female illusion the character is intended to represent in the narrative create a decolonial space where nonnormative sociosexual codes and behaviors can not only be legitimized but also idealized.

The queer macho in the works of Alfaro and Reyes materializes a Chicano/Latino aesthetic that defies multiple norms and resists categorization. These characters can be seen as postcolonial beings who are actively engaged in battling normative modes of seeing gender, sexuality, ethnicity, and beauty. The queer macho in the works of

these artists maintains an ambiguous identity through possessing multiple gender and cultural markings that are not usually juxtaposed. At the same time, the materialization of the queer macho is facilitated through a process of legitimizing such bodies via their presence on stage, the telling of their stories, and the affirmation of their identities.

Visualizing the Queer Macho: Alex Donis and Héctor Silva

Alex Donis and Héctor Silva are visual artists who engage in queering quintessentially hypermasculine men: homeboys and patriarchal authority figures. Whereas Rechy and Nava appear interested in masculinizing gay men in their writings, Donis and Silva assign effeminate roles to stereotypical macho men. In essence, they queer the macho. As the macho approximates a queer identity, he is freed from some of the negative traits associated with his image: misogyny, violence, stoicism.

Donis depicts transgressive images of queer macho men in his works. In his *War* (2001) series, he creates homoerotic images centering on the juxtaposition of gang members/homeboys and authority figures, principally male members of the Los Angeles Police Department. Donis homoeroticizes a typical encounter between a gang member and a police officer—an arrest—by imagining as erotic the physical proximity and interaction involved in such an encounter. These two diametrically opposing figures, representatives of rival patriarchal institutions, engage in various forms of dance (from tango to hip-hop), which Donis portrays as overtly homoerotic (figure 1.2; for additional images, visit his website at http://www.alexdonis.com/). Moreover, Donis develops a homoerotic ethnic and racial discourse by frequently presenting interracial "couples," hypermasculine archetypes engaged in what is often considered nonmasculine behavior, in a traditionally homophobic space. The mixture of races and the queering of hypermasculine social and state institutions (gangs and authority figures) establish Donis as one of the most controversial gay Chicano artists. In fact, his exhibitions have been canceled many times and there have been repeated attempts by some to censor or destroy art pieces deemed offensive. His use of venerated masculine icons has added fire to the controversy.

His piece *My Cathedral* (1997) is an image of Che Guevara and César Chávez hugging and kissing intimately. Like the homoerotic images of the homeboys with the L.A. policemen in his *War* series,



Figure 1.2 *WAR*: *Sad Boy and Captain Brewer*, Alex Donis, 2001, oil and enamel on canvas, 5 × 5 feet

the portrayal is an attempt to feminize otherwise masculine figures to destabilize gender norms. In an interview published in *The Gate*, Donis explains his intention to assign what have historically been construed as feminine traits to masculine figures, which are typically represented in a stoic and hypermasculine fashion: "I created this work to try and melt down the stoicism in male Latino heroic figures and address the fear in feminizing masculinity."[27] The intimate kiss between Che Guevara and César Chávez relocates masculinity and each historical figure to a space where masculinity and femininity work in tandem to facilitate peace and intimacy. In this way, he suggests that their identities can be reconstituted: "I realized that joining these two almost cult figures in Latino culture positioned them

on the frontline of a very different cause, subverting and redefining the rhetoric to which they had historically been so entrenched."[28] By assigning "feminine" markings to macho archetypes, Donis is doing the opposite of what writers John Rechy and Michael Nava do: he queers the macho whereas the latter "macho" the queer. These are both forms of destabilizing gender, sexual, and aesthetic norms—similar to the way Alfaro and Reyes consistently portray highly ambiguous bodies—as a means of materializing the queer macho in cultural production. All these approaches to developing queer macho identities are equally viable, transgressive, and progressive.

The representation of the queer macho in Donis's work locates hypermasculine archetypal men of color—authority figures, homeboys, and iconic male figures—in what is traditionally perceived as effeminate social spaces (dancing or kissing). Thus, Donis subverts patriarchal heteronormative codes. What is more, by including homoerotic desire as a link between some of these male figures, he constructs a queer macho image in a social, cultural, and historical context that transcends normative gender, sexual, ethnic, and aesthetic boundaries.

Donis's work also reconceptualizes the homeboy aesthetic as erotic. The eroticization and commodification of a look that has historically been associated with criminality and hypermasculinity is a relatively new cultural phenomenon. Homeboy aesthetics have influenced a wide range of fashion trends among many populations in the United States and abroad: baggy pants, Old English-style lettering, and tattoos. Richard T. Rodríguez explains that the homeboy aesthetic is "an assemblage of key signifiers: clothing (baggy pants and undershirts are perhaps the most significant), hair (or, in the current moment of the aesthetic, lack of hair), bold stance, and distinct language (think *caló* mixed with hip-hop parlance), all combining to form a distinguishable cultural affectation hard to miss on Los Angeles city streets."[29]

As is the case for Black men and Black masculinity, homeboys have been eroticized in various forms of popular culture. These men can be seen in hip-hop and reggaetón[30] videos with or without undershirts, displaying bulging, oiled muscles. Certainly, the homeboy aesthetic itself can be considered queer in the way the male body is eroticized around a cult of hypermasculinity and the bad boy image, both variants of normative modes of maleness in the dominant culture. Homeboys are portrayed as being tough, violent, and all the other characteristics one might associate with gang culture. Nevertheless, their bodies become sites of multiple erotic mappings

that facilitate a discourse on homeboy homoeroticism. Furthermore, the homeboy aesthetic is queer in the way it can be fetishized. Rodríguez contends that the act of queering the homeboy aesthetic is a reference to "a style, circulating within the Chicano/Latino gay male spaces, whose visibility emanates from the interplay of materiality and fantasy" (128). For Rodríguez, the site of fantasy plays a vital role in queering the homeboy aesthetic because "it helps destabilize gender norms that commonly frame Chicano/Latino masculinity and crucially alters the ways in which the homeboy aesthetic has been made always already heterosexual or rendered antithetical to homosexuality" (131).

As an example of the queer homeboy aesthetic, Rodríguez examines the artwork of Héctor Silva, a Los Angeles–based artist who creates images that center on the intersection of cultural identity and eroticism. His artwork is especially distinguishable in the way he overtly portrays the homeboy figure as erotic and homoerotic. The images he creates are another example of how macho men can be queered; however, similar to the way Calvin Klein developed a male aesthetic that appealed to men and women in general, many of Silva's images of homeboys are designed in a manner that make them a part of a wide range of fantasies and tastes (for a look at some of his work, visit his website at http://www.artbyhector.com/erotic/).

The homeboys (aka *cholos*) in Silva's works are erotic, sensual, and aesthetically appealing. When wearing clothing, they don muscle shirts, baggy pants, boxer briefs, dark sunglasses or a number of other cultural signifiers. The parts of their bodies that are bare are often marked by tattoos, muscles, mustaches, goatees, uncut penises, and gangster jewelry. Furthermore, they are typically placed in a homeboy context with everything from the Virgin of Guadalupe to cell bars in the background. In some images, the subjects are peering at the viewer, while in others they don dark sunglasses that add an air of mystery to them or they are not facing the viewer at all. These types of gazes are useful to a discussion of queer macho aesthetics and behavior. When the subject gazes at the viewer it is not in the manner Susan Bordo describes as "face-off masculinity," where the subject appears to be engaging in a staring competition to assert his masculinity and dominance over the viewer. Instead, they might be described as what Bordo labels "leaners": "these bodies are almost always reclining, leaning against, or propped up against something in the fashion typical of women's bodies" (131). Bordo contends that the gaze or lack thereof is intended as a form of flirtation and seduction, a way of offering the body for pleasure.



Figure 1.3 *My Homeboy Obregón*, Héctor Silva, 2001, pencil, colored pencil on 2-ply museum board, 22 × 28 inches

In Silva's *My Homeboy Obregón* (2001), a shirtless, muscular homeboy is standing facing a dilapidated graffiti-marked wall with his arms stretched out against it (figure 1.3). Although his body is facing the wall, his head is turned to the left. He is wearing sunglasses, but is not looking at the viewer. He has all of the gang cultural signifiers, "OBREGON"[31] tattooed on his back, a mustache, goatee, boxer briefs, an earring in his left ear, and gangster jewelry around his neck and wrists. He appears to be the epitome of a hypermasculine archetype prevalent in U.S. cultural production, the "gangster thug" (typically assigned Chicano/Latino or Black cultural signifiers). His stance against the wall could well be interpreted as an arrest scene; however, in the context of Silva's other work, it is obviously the eroticization of not only the homeboy and his body, but of the act of being arrested itself. As opposed to facilitating a fantasy around what the homeboy might do to the viewer, what I find most compelling about this image is that it allows the viewer to fantasize about what he/she could do to the homeboy who has thus surrendered his body. The nearly naked body positioned in a submissive stance is inviting the viewer to penetrate

it. Regardless of the obvious invitation to sodomize his body, one dare not question the subject's masculinity. His macho status is protected by his clearly marked hypermasculine homeboy image.

In another image *My Homeboys #2* (2002), Silva portrays two completely naked muscular homeboys, both facing the viewer. The one in the background has his arms interlocked around the shoulders of the one in the foreground and the latter has one hand positioned on the wrist and the other hand on the thigh of the other's body. Their intimate embrace with their bodies facing the same direction also shares references to acts of sodomy; however, the prominent presence of the uncut penis of the man in the foreground and the obvious similarities in appearance between the two erase the possible emasculation of either subject by the sexual act their bodies in such a position emulate. Moreover, their gazes are far from threatening. Instead, they appear to be inviting the viewer to participate in their union. The presence of the necklace with the Virgin of Guadalupe, sitting snuggly between the firm chest muscles and prominent nipples of the homeboy in the foreground, is a cultural signifier that adds an air of sanctity to the union—confirming not only their union but the legitimation of the two of them as human beings.

The images Donis and Silva create invite all viewers to participate in an erotic act, either as another subject within the scene or as a voyeur. As Rodríguez claims with respect to Silva's work, the viewer can either identify with the subjects in the images or merely desire and fantasize about them. Thus, these homeboys are eroticized in a manner designed to instill pleasure and incite fantasy. One result of reconfiguring the homeboy aesthetic in this way is that it challenges the negative stereotypes that are typically associated with it: violence, criminality, ugliness, stoicism. Instead, the homeboy becomes erotic, aesthetically appealing, and sensual. This reconstitution of normative models of representation produces an aesthetic that disrupts patriarchal heteronormativity by challenging the association of whiteness with beauty, or masculinity with heterosexuality. Because these figures are queer and macho, their masculinity is not compromised by their eroticization nor by the homoerotic acts they simulate. The homeboy archetype is simultaneously homoeroticized and legitimized, thereby challenging its sociohistorical marginalization from the dominant culture. The queer macho in the works of these two artists involves repositioning macho archetypes from a rigid masculine paradigm towards a queer subject position; moreover, the act of queering a macho archetype is analogous to masculinizing the *maricón* archetype.

Conclusion: The Birth of the Queer Macho

The representation of the male Chicano/Latino body is one that is shaped by the fusion of various cultures, a process that is emblematic of the mestizaje such bodies encompass and the relationship they have with the dominant culture. As "othered" people, these men are automatically relegated to a marginal status. In many cases, these bodies resist such marginalization; they do what is necessary to materialize and obtain some form of autonomy or agency. As seen in my analysis of the various artists who portray queer Chicano and Latino bodies in a variety of artistic mediums, this can be done by creating and displaying queer macho aesthetics that shape and reconfigure beauty paradigms.

As I have shown, in the works of John Rechy and Michael Nava, attributing traditionally masculine traits (both physical and nonphysical) to gay archetypes (the faggot or *maricón*) can be seen as a way to legitimize gay men. By machoizing *maricones*, gay Chicano/Latino men appropriate traits valued by the dominant culture. Similarly, producing gender-ambiguous Chicano/Latino bodies, as in the works of Luis Alfaro and Guillermo Reyes, facilitates a dismantling of gender, sexual, and aesthetic norms, which formulates identities that resist all forms of categorization. Finally, assigning traditionally feminine roles to macho archetypes (Che Guevara or the homeboy/gangster thug), as seen in the works of Alex Donis and Héctor Silva, is a means of legitimizing macho men. Via the queering of the macho, hypermasculine men are removed from a rigid gender and sexual paradigm and are allowed to be sensual, (homo)erotic, and beautiful. All of these bodies are both macho *and* queer. These are the subjects I call queer machos; they possess the courage to be who they are without bowing to Anglo patriarchal heteronormative precepts.

Male beauty standards for Chicano/Latino men extend well beyond the physical ideal typically associated with Anglo males. Chicano/Latino bodies are under a gender and ethnic lens that is constantly evaluating their authenticity; they must also contend with the stereotypes that shape their identities. Historically, to maintain a macho image, one had to at least give the public impression that he/she is always *activo*—the one on top, the *chingón* (the one who fucks), the *mero mero* (the head honcho). However, I have given several examples of representations of queer Chicano/Latino men that challenge such thinking. Their bodies and their identities are not defined by strict gender, sexual, or ethnic codes but by the legitimation of their bodies as they are. What I have highlighted here are the

Chicano/Latino artists who are engaged in this process of reconfiguring notions of gender, sexuality, ethnicity, and beauty by developing characters that are simultaneously queer and macho.

The queer macho is not a new figure in U.S. cultural production. He/she has existed for several decades. I also contend that the queer macho transcends borders, both literal and figurative; he/she can be examined in an array of social, historical, and cultural contexts. In the next chapter, I examine the Latin lover to show how he too can be considered a queer macho, thereby tracing a trajectory of this figure in the United States starting in the early twentieth century. Current celebrities and popular culture icons are ripe subjects for examining as queer machos: Mario López, George López, Ricky Martin, Antonio Banderas, and Edward James Olmos. There are also several other artists and mediums that invite similar analyses: Culture Clash,[32] John Leguizamo,[33] and the visual artist Daniel Salazar.[34] My examination of the Latin lover includes some of these celebrities and artists.

2

(Re)Examining the Latin Lover: Screening Chicano/Latino Sexualities

Marriage? Not for me.

Ramón Novarro[1]

Chicano/Latino males have been caricatured, stereotyped, and eroticized on the big screen throughout the history of U.S. cinema and television. In *Latino Images in Film*, Charles Ramírez Berg highlights the most common stereotypes for these men: *bandido*, gang member, buffoon, and Latin lover (68–76). Although several Chicana/o and Latina/o artists and producers have created images of Chicanas/os and Latinas/os that challenge these stereotypes, they nonetheless persist. Here, I am interested in examining the Latin lover archetype as it has been shaped by U.S. popular culture to demonstrate the way this image has evolved over the years and, at the same time, to show how the Latin lover has always had queer characteristics. I trace the trajectory of the Latin lover, beginning with Ramón Novarro and ending with Mario López, and highlight queer aspects of this identity while also underscoring the influence it has had on male aesthetics and on facilitating nonnormative discourses on sexuality.

The Latin lover archetype has been prevalent in U.S. cultural production for almost a century. If anything, the representation of the Latin lover in cultural production has increased exponentially since the 1920s: Desi Arnaz, Ricardo Montalbán, Fernando Lamas, Anthony Quinn, Jimmy Smits, Andy García, Antonio Banderas, Javier Bardem, John Leguizamo, Víctor Manuel Resendiz Ruis (the Mexican "Latin Lover" of world wrestling) and Mario López (named *People* magazine's Summer's Hottest Bachelor in 2008). The majority of these actors have participated in mainstream film and television projects, and their identities off screen are very much intertwined

with the Latin lover stereotype they portray. These men often continue to perform as Latin lovers in other parts of the public sphere: in commercials, interviews, guest appearances, and tabloids. Although there may be a social and economic imperative that requires them to sustain this image on and off the big screen, I maintain that they do have some agency concerning the image they project and the Latin lover identity they perform. Therefore, I propose that performing the Latin lover archetype be seen in and of itself as a form of Chicano/Latino cultural production.

The Latin lover image and subsequent craze emerged in the early twentieth century with the presence of two larger-than-life actors in silent films: Rudolph Valentino and Ramón Novarro.[2] In *Dangerous Men: Pre-Code Hollywood and the Birth of the Modern Man*, Mick LaSalle claims that it was during this era that the mainstream in the United States began to see the "primitive-type lover" as fantasy (7). These men were portrayed as sexy and dangerous, sometimes naive and innocent while at other times evil and savage. They could seduce with their physical beauty, and they became icons of ethnic and, as portrayed in U.S. films, foreign male beauty. Berg suggests that this stereotype was constructed around the Latin lover "as the possessor of a primal sexuality that made him capable of making a sensuous but dangerous—and clearly non-WASP—brand of love" (76). He also claims that these roles can be characterized as "eroticism, exoticism, tenderness tinged with violence and danger, all adding up to the romantic promise that, sexually, things could very well get out of control" (76). In general, the Latin lover's identity was and still is constructed around the synthesis of eroticism, exoticism, and danger; he is attractive and irresistible, but not to be trusted.

Physically, the Latin lover possesses three basic attributes: good looks, masculine features/behavior, and ethnic markings (whatever may be construed as being "Latin"—dark hair, olive skin, a foreign accent). Furthermore, his public persona is typically constructed around women and compulsory heterosexuality: his unyielding pursuit of women and the women who find themselves irrevocably attracted to him. In *Hollywood's Latin Lovers*, Victoria Thomas suggests that "Hollywood's Latin lover was the man your mother warned you about. He was the man women yearned to touch. He was the man other men yearned to become."[3] Besides at times being portrayed as a tough guy or bandit, the Latin lover was dangerous because he could hypnotize women into doing things they presumably did not want to do, not to mention that, unlike his repressed Anglo counterpart, his sexuality was insatiable and unrestrained. As Thomas

contends, he was a "creature of the erotic imagination" designed to appeal to both women and men: "The Latin Lover appealed to men as well, because he represented their most ungentlemanly urges, unbound. His on-screen character was frequently more overtly sexual and more violent than his mainstream counterpart, thus offering vicarious liberation to female and male audiences alike" (10). Thus, the Latin lover was/is designed to have a universal appeal, much like the male models Susan Bordo describes in "Beauty (Re)Discovers the Male Body," a highly masculine and erotic aesthetic that is designed to appeal to a variety of consumers: female and male, gay and straight.[4]

According to LaSalle, it was in the early twentieth century that men began developing a consciousness of themselves as sexy: "Young men strove to be sexually attractive in a way their fathers could not understand. In the nineteenth century men didn't need to be sexy. If they wanted sex, they could go to a brothel. For that, all they needed was money, all the more reason to work hard and save for a rainy day" (3). Examples of the eroticized male body abound throughout the twentieth century in popular culture. Although Bordo suggests that the display of such bodies in the media and popular culture is primarily linked to consumerism, there is no doubt that the male body has become objectified. In *Stiffed: The Betrayal of the American Man*, Susan Faludi explains that at the core of an "ornamental culture" like ours lies a voyeuristic lens where sex is the "gold standard" (505). In her interview with Sam Shahid, an advertising executive who was instrumental in shaping the Adonis-like images found in numerous ads for companies such as Abercrombie & Fitch and Versace, she quotes him as saying, "Pecs are the new breasts now," and, "Men have become *bigger* sex objects than women! They are the sex gods now! The have replaced women!" (506). Shahid claims that women no longer wanted to be sex objects whereas men were screaming "Use me!" (506). Although his claims might appear to be exaggerated and overgeneralized, they do highlight the male body as an erotic object, which is a queer phenomenon in and of itself because it rejects the masculine and male imperative that men always remain in control of their environment. As Faludi contends:

> The man controlling his environment is today the prevailing American image of masculinity. A man is expected to prove himself not by being part of society but by being untouched by it, soaring above it. He is to travel unfettered, beyond society's clutches, alone—making or breaking whatever or whoever crosses his path. He is to be in the driver's

> seat, the king of the road, forever charging down the open highway, along that masculine Möbius strip that cycles endlessly through a numbing stream of movies, TV shows, novels, advertisements, and pop tunes. He's a man because he won't be stopped. He'll fight attempts to tamp him down; if he has to, he'll use his gun. (10)

In essence, the display of the male body as erotic "feminizes" the subject. Besides men's pecs being seen as a substitute for women's breasts, the erotic male body on display is stripped of agency as viewers gaze freely, fantasize about it, and, ultimately, consume it. Men as sex objects are queer in the way they assume a passive role in the exchange between viewer and subject. Eroticized male subjects have little control over their environment or the display of their bodies. Whether their bodies are intended to be consumed by male or female viewers is ultimately irrelevant because both types disrupt the active/passive binary by placing a man in a submissive role and thereby destabilizing normative gender and sexual roles.

I also argue that the way the Latin lover is eroticized extends well beyond merely women yearning to touch him and other men wanting to be like him. Victoria Thomas fails to recognize that some women may fantasize about being a Latin lover themselves and endlessly seducing other women while some men may fantasize about being seduced by Ramón Novarro or Mario López. Moreover, their on- and off-screen persona often includes homoerotic acts and other forms of nonheteronormative sexualities that make these lovers queer machos, as defined in chapter 1: men who possess the courage to be who they are without bowing completely to the heteronormative or ethnocentric precepts of the dominant culture.

If one looks beyond the heterosexual facade projected on the big screen, queer cultural signifiers abound in the Latin lover archetype. The Latin lover is by default nonheteronormative. His foreignness, promiscuity, and body can all become sites for mapping queer identities. Because the Latin lover—like other Chicana/o and Latina/o archetypes (i.e., the hot and spicy Latina)—has been portrayed as someone who has an insatiable sexual appetite, there has existed a certain amount of ambiguity with respect to his sexual object choices. This is partially due to his perceived foreignness—a "that's just what they do" or "that's just how they are" attitude. Moreover, one cannot disregard differing aspects of identity development. The Latin lover is not a one-dimensional character, although some might portray or imagine him as such. What he does outside of the Latin lover box must also be taken into consideration when examining his identity.

In John Leguizamo's *Mambo Mouth* (1991) he includes the portrayal of Agamemnon, the host of *Naked Personalities*—a fictitious talk radio show. Agamemnon is the quintessential Latin lover—satirically portrayed. As the host of the show, his targeted audience is made up of the women who love him and the men who want to be like him. Throughout the performance piece he defines and emphasizes Latin lover traits: passion, omnipotence, dominance, and egocentrism. He claims he never falls in love and would never marry a woman: "Let's get something straight, I don't get involved with my women. I'm a short term guy, I don't fall in love, and I certainly am not going to marry you. The only thing you can count on me for is satisfaction, gratification, ecstasy, passion, decadence, debauchery, and, maybe, kissing."[5] The Latin lover not only disrespects women but he often abuses them verbally, sometimes physically. Agamemnon instructs one male caller who is trying to woo a woman by showering her with gifts that he must stop the gift-giving, mistreat her, and sleep around in order to tip the scale his way and get what he wants. When Agamemnon reenacts a movie scene in which he played a typical Latin lover, he demonstrates how he slapped the woman he was trying to seduce when she kissed him—punishing her for breaking a Latin lover code: always be in control of the situation, always be the *chingón*. Agamemnon also demonstrates the cat and mouse routine in which the Latin lover and women typically engage—a dance where he chases and gropes her while she attempts to get away. Although Leguizamo's portrayal of the Latin lover is intended to be farcical, it does summarize what could be considered features of the Latin lover box: good-looking, hypersexual, "Latin," masculine, dominant, self-centered, irresistible, dangerous, womanizer, and disrespectful or violent with women. All these traits have repeatedly been used to construct a Latin lover identity in popular culture since the early twentieth century. While the Latin lover image that remains in the box can be seen as queer in and of itself, when the Latin lover steps outside the box, his identity remains rooted in queerness.

Many actors have assumed roles in film and television that displace their Latin lover identities. For example, many of those who have played the Latin lover part have also played gay and transsexual roles: John Leguizamo as Manny the Fanny in *Mambo Mouth* and as Chi-Chi Rodríguez in *To Wong Foo, Thanks for Everything! Julie Lemar* (1995), Antonio Banderas as Miguel in *Philadelphia* (1993), Mario López as Greg Louganis in *Breaking the Surface* (1997), and Javier Bardem as Reinaldo Arenas in *Before Night Falls* (2000). Playing gay/transsexual roles simultaneously disrupts and reiterates the Latin lover

archetype. It disrupts it by reconfiguring the erotic coupling of the Latin lover with a man as opposed to a woman or by imaging him as a woman instead of as a man; it reiterates the Latin lover stereotype by confirming a pansexual or unrestrained sexuality. Furthermore, the actor's private life has often been under a gender and sexual lens, where questions abound regarding his sexual and love interests, male and female alike: Ramón Novarro was known to have sexual relationships with other men and Mario López continues to joke and play gay as a response to the rumors that he is gay. All of these nonheteronormative discourses contribute to a Latin lover queer identity, where ambiguities with respect to gender and sexual identities proliferate. The Latin lover does not adhere to heteronormative gender and sexual codes. Although his identity is constructed around his erotic relationship with women, it is equally constructed around his inability to maintain a relationship with one woman. Moreover, his perceived foreignness permits his sexuality to veer significantly from heteronormativity: having multiple partners, savage sex in indiscriminate places, using little or exotic clothing (sarongs and turbans), and sex scenes with S&M overtones. I now look at a couple of key Latin lover figures to demonstrate specific ways their identities are queer.

Ravishing Ramón Novarro

Ramón Novarro (1899–1968) is mostly known for the title role he assumed in the most expensive silent film ever made: *Ben-Hur* (1925). Also known as "Ravishing Ramón," he was considered one of the most beautiful of the Latin lovers of his time. Novarro was born José Ramón Gil Samaniego in Durango, Mexico; he was a cousin of the legendary Mexican actress, Dolores del Río. Although he attempted to begin his acting career using his birth name, he was advised to change his name in order to advance his career, which proved to be a way to make his identity more ambiguous and mysterious. The roles that Novarro assumed ran the gamut with respect to cultural mappings: Frenchman, sheik, pagan, Jew, Italian, German, Polynesian, and Native American. As Victoria Thomas explains, Latin lovers were often cast in a variety of roles that were deemed ethnic or Latin:

> The sad truth is that Hollywood knew little about Latin cultures, histories or traditions. Latin characters were conceived and scripted with only a tourist's postcard-understanding of *Latinismo*; the results are as laughable as a souvenir sombrero (or simply insulting, depending upon your point of view). In addition to seducers, most Latin leading men

> have played rollicking gypsy-boys, mustachioed banditos, gangsters and other all-purpose scoundrels, roles which reinforced the notion of ethnic people as morally inferior. In this sense, Hollywood's Latin Lover was truly a man without a country. (12)

The Latin lover's exoticization is thus rarely linked to a particular nationality. Instead, it is his body that becomes the site of a compendium of markings that signify his otherness and his immorality. By stripping him of national origin, the Latin lover remains countryless and his body is appropriated and eventually consumed by mass culture in ways that relegate him to an abject status. In essence, it is used the way many male models have been used in place of women as sex objects—it is displayed freely, eroticized, exoticized, and used to create fantasy narratives where the Latin lover fulfills the hidden desires of unsuspecting victims or of the viewers themselves.

The Latin lover image is established by projecting a character as both foreign and erotic. In *Ben-Hur*, Novarro captivates his audience by displaying his body in a variety of scenes. At times he is bare-chested and wears a small wrap around his waist, especially when he is forced into slavery and thrown into the galleys. In other scenes, his chest, biceps, and muscular legs protrude from his Roman uniform (figure 2.1). These revealing costumes played an important role in establishing Novarro as an erotic Other. Besides accentuating and displaying the actor's body, they function as disguises that mask certain aspects of the character's identity. For example, in his Roman uniform, the leading man's Jewish identity is concealed. Although these disguises can be seen as innocuous parts of the narrative, to audience members they send a cautionary message that the Latin lover can disguise himself in many ways—thereby reinforcing xenophobia. After *Ben-Hur*, Novarro went on to play a wide range of characters from various race, ethnic, religious, and nonreligious backgrounds.

In *The Pagan* (1929), Novarro plays the title role of a native Polynesian who wanders throughout a tropical island in a skimpy sarong (figure 2.2). His role in this film is emblematic of the Latin lover as primitive and erotic. According to LaSalle, at the time Novarro was at his pinnacle with respect to his physical features: "It was his apotheosis, providing him with a role that capitalized on his physical beauty and sex appeal and made a virtue of his intrinsic air of innocence" (8). Besides his physical beauty, the film made use of Novarro's singing talent. As his last silent film, the title theme song—"Pagan Love Song"—plays throughout and his voice was used to



Figure 2.1 Francis Xavier Bushman (left) and Ramón Novarro in the original *Ben-Hur* (1925)



Figure 2.2 Ramón Novarro as a Polynesian in *The Pagan* (1929)

seduce audiences. Nevertheless, as Victoria Thomas suggests, "it was the star's skimpy sarong, not sound, which caused the epidemic of front-row fainting" (27). Novarro's voice, taut body, and good looks fed the fantasies of many of his viewers. As one of the first men to replace the female body as an erotic entity in U.S. popular culture and, in essence, become a sex object, his body is "feminized" and queered.

Besides the objectification of Novarro's body, his off-screen identity is also queer. In his biography on Novarro, *Beyond Paradise: The Life of Ramón Novarro*, André Soares discloses intimate details of the handsome film star's sexuality. He documents some of the sexual relationships Novarro had with other men, his escapades to male bordellos, and his brutal murder at the hands of two male hustlers. Clearly, Novarro's private life was quite different from the Latin lover image he projected on the big screen. Unlike some gay male actors who resorted to "lavender marriages" in order to protect their image,[6] Novarro never married and made remarks dismissing or disparaging the institution of marriage or a long-term commitment to any woman. Although this could be considered a way to maintain a Latin lover image, knowing what we know now about his private life, his rejection of serious intimate relationships with women is related more to his homosexuality than to maintaining a Latin lover reputation. I see this refusal to adhere to conventional norms as a queer macho stance. Novarro risked tarnishing his Latin lover image by not succumbing to a lavender marriage or playing the compulsory heterosexuality card. Although he did not live an out and proud gay lifestyle, his public persona challenged heteronormative thinking by engaging the public in nonheteronormative discourses, with the actor's queer life at the center of the discussion.

Novarro was devoted to his family (his parents and his siblings), had a reputation for being a devout Catholic, and at times projected conservative views with respect to cultural values. This presented a conflict with his unconventional lifestyle. Plenty of rumors and evidence surfaced of his sexual encounters with other men; moreover, there were unsubstantiated rumors that he and Rudolph Valentino were lovers. Nevertheless, he did not marry and did not resort to projecting a heteronormative lifestyle off-screen. I must emphasize that Novarro did not handle these conflicts very well. Soares suggests that the internal conflicts plaguing Novarro contributed to his problems with alcohol, risky sexual encounters, and, ultimately, his demise. All these issues tarnished his image and his brutal murder at the hands of two male hustlers would become one of the events most difficult for the public to separate from his legacy.

Nevertheless, Novarro can be seen as a queer macho. He refused to allow heteronormativity to completely dictate parameters on his life. At a time when not succumbing to the projection of a heterosexual and heteronormative image in the public sphere was tantamount to committing career suicide, Novarro did not participate in a lavender marriage. What is more, the fact that so many rumors existed around his sexuality and his relationship with Rudolph Valentino—the protégés of ideal male ethnic beauty in the United States—gives rise to a compendium of issues related to sexual identity politics. It also opens the door—or closet—to the ways in which Latin lovers can be queer and queer men can be Latin lovers.

Desi Arnaz: From Latin Lover to Innocent Child, Wha Hoppened?

Desi Arnaz (1917–1986) is another quintessential Latin lover. Best known for his role as Ricky Ricardo in the classic *I Love Lucy* (1951–1960), Arnaz also starred in a number of films between 1940 and 1982 and had a long, successful career as a musician and singer. Besides his handsome looks, Arnaz used his body to exude sexuality by gyrating his hips uncontrollably—preceding Elvis Presley by more than a decade. Victoria Thomas describes his performance style in the following manner:

> His power as a performer rested on one simple fact: Desi moved his hips. His sensual gyrations were a shock to the nation, especially since, in the 1930s, white America denied life below the waist. The lower body, with its shameful cravings and awful consequences, was best ignored; that way, those hips would cause the least trouble. So the arch and shimmy of Desi's pelvis, powered by the syncopated rhythms of his tall congas electrified the country much the way Elvis would in the fifties and the Twist would in the sixties. (85)

Arnaz developed a reputation for having what appeared to be an uncontrollable sexuality, especially when performing musical numbers. His wild side on stage brought out the wild side of his audience members: "His sexuality was exuberant, natural and joyous. Desi was kinetic, fearless in much the same way a great athlete is fearless. As a performer, he was willing to surrender control, making his performances edgy, thrilling and cathartic" (Thomas, 86). His sexuality was also something to be feared because it was so wild and savage. For Lucille Ball, this proved to be both a simultaneously attractive

and scary feature: "He was very handsome and romantic. But he also frightened me, he was so wild. I knew I shouldn't have married him, but that was one of the biggest attractions" (Thomas, 88). Despite eventually marrying Ball, Arnaz was known as a playboy. Rumors abounded that he had extramarital affairs, and in his autobiography, *A Book* (1976), he confesses that he did have relationships with other women and, moreover, that Lucille Ball knew about them: "I must admit that I was an old-fashioned Latin, raised observing and believing in the classic double standard. Your wife is your wife and you want to know that you can trust her and be secure in that knowledge. Your fooling around can in no way affect your love for her. That relationship is sacred and a few peccadilloes mean nothing. Lucy knew this" (175). Besides knowing that Arnaz was having extramarital affairs, there exists evidence that Ball was also engaging in her own infidelities. When Laura Bergquist asked Ball during an interview for *Look* magazine about the source of the conflict between them, Bergquist tended to blame Arnaz's machismo: "Was that the conflict? The double standard, the so-called 'machismo'? Machismo is that which supposedly all Latins are constantly trying to prove, that they are good studs, that their sexual capabilities are extraordinary" (Arnaz, 175). Instead of playing the victim and blaming Arnaz's machismo for their problems, Ball responds, "No, the 'machismo' didn't bother me. I like to play games, too" (Arnaz, 175).

Extramarital affairs are in and of themselves queer; however, it is often assumed that only the male—especially the Latin lover—engages in them. The fact that Ball also engaged in her own affairs and that both were aware of each other's infidelities is another queer aspect of their relationship. Furthermore, Arnaz and Ball did not have children until after they were married through the Catholic Church in 1949; they spent almost ten years in an unsanctioned marriage and childless. The list of queer cultural signifiers in their relationship is lengthy: an interracial relationship, Ball's fear/attraction to Arnaz's wild side, the infidelities, the years they spent in a union not sanctioned by the Church, and the difference in their ages—Ball was six years senior. The age and ethnic differences between the two in particular emasculate Arnaz in a way that is also queer, which is most evident in his role as Ricky Ricardo. First, I will focus on their relationship outside of *I Love Lucy* and then examine a couple of episodes of the show to demonstrate the way their relationship was queer both in and outside of the public purview.

Arnaz and Ball met while working on *Too Many Girls* (1940), Arnaz's first film.[7] They eloped that same year, but had a tumultuous

love-hate relationship that would last throughout their marriage. Arnaz puts it this way: "We would love furiously and fight furiously" (112). He describes several of their problems and heated arguments in detail; he claims that they were both very jealous and temperamental. Arnaz also confesses that he did a number of things in excess:

> The one thing I have never been able to do is work and play concurrently and in moderation, whatever that means. I guess I have a lot of company though—Alcoholics Anonymous for the drinkers, Weight Watchers for the fat ones, Cigarettes Anonymous for the smoker. And considering all the action, Sex Anonymous may be next. If they are all successful we could become a pretty dull group of skinny, sober, thumb-sucking virgins. I guess if I had learned the meaning of moderation and had been able to practice it, the Desilu monster we had created and our marriage might not have been so hard to cope with. (311)

Obviously, the relationship the two had in real life was very different from the one they projected on television. They fought constantly and created a cycle where they would fight, break up, make up, and fight. The cycle would eventually break when they divorced in 1959, after almost twenty years of trying to make their union work:

> The vicious cycle continued. The more we fought, the less sex we had, the more seeking others, the more jealousy, the more separations, the more drinking, which led right back to more fights, less sex and more seeking others, etc., etc., etc. The cycle was soon completed. Add to this the herculean [*sic*] effort we had to make to maintain the imaginary bliss of Lucy and Ricky, and our lives became a nightmare. (312)

Arnaz confesses that one of the problems between them in the early years was his fear of becoming Mr. Ball and living in Lucille Ball's shadow. In *A Book* he recalls how he was often introduced to other celebrities: "Desi Arnaz, married to Lucille Ball, he's a Cuban" (139). Although he had had some success in show business prior to the *I Love Lucy* show, he was frequently unemployed or reduced to minor roles in low-budget films. He feared what would become of him: "All I have done so far are three lousy pictures and now I'm out of a job. There's no way I'm going to stay here and become Mr. Ball" (133).

Despite not wanting to live in Ball's shadow, Arnaz's big break came out of her insistence that they do a husband-and-wife situation comedy together. At the time, Lucy had been doing a popular radio show on CBS titled *My Favorite Husband*. In the show, Ball's husband

(played by Richard Denning) was a stereotypical Anglo businessman and, as Arnaz comments, there was no way he could convincingly play that role: "Her husband on the radio show was a typical American guy, second vice-president of a bank and a tall, blue-eyed blond. There was no way I could be believed in that role" (193). When CBS began talking to Ball about converting *My Favorite Husband* to a television series, she agreed, but under one condition: "only if Desi plays the husband" (193). Initially, CBS did not respond favorably: "However, the network, the agencies, everybody involved said that nobody was going to believe that a Latin bandleader with a Cuban Pete conga-drum Babalu image could ever be married to a typical red-headed American girl" (193). Nevertheless, Lucy did not give up. She insisted that they try, even when Arnaz was ready to throw in the towel; he feared that they would jeopardize their careers and their marriage. *I Love Lucy* would go on to break a number of records and Arnaz—along with Desilu Productions—would become household names. However, his Latin lover image would be considerably diminished in the role for which he is now most remembered. The trajectory of the early part of his career highlights the role that Ball played in making Arnaz a celebrity. Ball was basically the person who controlled his career and Arnaz was much more passive in these endeavors than most people think. The power dynamic between the two leaned considerably in favor of Ball, and I posit that this power differential remained as such in the roles they assumed in *I Love Lucy*.

In the beginning of the series, Lucy and Ricky are a young married couple. Ricky is a singer and orchestra leader in show business and Lucy is a housewife with little talent but with limitless fantasies about making it in show business.[8] The series had enormous success and continues to be syndicated in dozens of languages all over the world. Filmed during the Hays Code era (1934–68), *I Love Lucy* was subjected to strict rules regarding the display/discussion of sex or anything deemed immoral. In effect, Arnaz's gyrating hips were contained; his "wild" sexuality repressed. As such, I contend that Ricky Ricardo is emasculated throughout the series just as Desi Arnaz was in real life—constantly living in Lucille Ball's shadow; he does not assume the role typically associated with men of this era, especially Latin lover archetypes. Although his music and singing can be seen as mediums through which he might seduce audiences, overall, Ricky is confined to a submissive role throughout the series. The first way he is emasculated is through his heavy accent and his unpolished English. Throughout the series, Lucy mocks his speech as if he were a child. Whereas most of the show's comedy relies on Lucy's clowning

(facial expressions and getting caught in compromising positions), Ricky's body is rarely used as a comedic venue; instead, his speech—particularly his responses to Lucy's antics—is the primary mode of his comedic expression. His unforgettable "Luuuuucy!" and "Wha Hoppened?" lines—and his accent in general—function as signifiers of his otherness. On the show's surface, one might suspect that Lucy is the one who behaves in a childlike manner, constantly getting into trouble, being scolded by Ricky, and breaking into tears with her famous "Waaaaa!" However, I argue that if one analyzes the dynamics of their relationship more closely, one of the most salient aspects of it is that of Ricky as child and Lucy as mother. The language issue is just one of several examples.

In "Lucy Hires an English Tutor" (which first aired December 19, 1952, on CBS), Lucy decides that she and everyone else who is going to be around the baby she and Ricky are expecting should speak perfect English. When Ricky responds by saying: "Well, honey, it's a very nice thought but as usual you have no logical splanation for doing it the way you are doing it." Lucy counters with the following remark: "Promise me that until our child is at least nineteen or twenty years old you won't talk to it." Lucy's remark—regardless of whether or not it is in jest—is an attempt to erase Ricky from the child's life in fear of the influence Ricky's accent and improper English will have on it. She proceeds to mock Ricky's accent by asking him to read an excerpt of a children's book for her in order to evaluate his reading skills. As he reads, he makes several errors while Lucy corrects his mistakes in a childlike fashion.

Lucy decides to hire an English tutor for everyone: Lucy, Ricky, Ethel Mertz (Vivian Vance), and Fred Mertz (William Frawley). On the day they are to hold class and meet the tutor—Mr. Livermore—Fred prances into the room dressed in a school uniform. He skips around while sucking a large lollipop and making schoolyard comments. The tutor himself identifies Fred as Ethel's child and Ethel, in an effort to discipline him, pulls him by the ear and they both play out the mother-child routine:

> *Fred*: Ouch! You hurt me mommy.
> *Ethel*: Behave yourself!

A similar dynamic is portrayed between Lucy and Ricky. When Mr. Livermore tries to get the group to practice vowel sounds, Ricky insists on saying them in Spanish. The tutor makes a snide remark with respect to Ricky's pronunciation: "Mr. Ricardo, wherever did you acquire that odd pronunciation?" To which Ricky responds, "I

went to school in Cuba. What's your excuse?" Lucy immediately steps in to break up the fight: "Ricky! Apologize! Apologize!" The manner in which Ricky is chastised by the English tutor for his speech and by Lucy for his behavior is a good example of the way his accent and the mother-son relationship he has with his spouse function to undermine his masculinity and his manhood overall.

When Arnaz was asked why *I Love Lucy* was so successful, he commented on some of the rules they had with respect to jokes, claiming that ethnic ones were off limits: "We did have some rules from the very beginning: basic good taste, moral values, never do a joke if that joke, no matter how funny and what a big laugh it could get, would in any way offend even a small segment of our viewers" (259). As Arnaz stresses, mocking Ricky's accent had a successful comedic effect only when Lucy and Ricky did it: "The only ones close to an ethnic joke were the ones about Ricky's accent, and of course those were in the category of making fun of yourself, which is fine. But even those did not work too well if anybody but Lucy used them. When Fred and Ethel made fun of Ricky's accent, they didn't get a laugh" (259). Nevertheless, the mocking of Ricky's speech throughout the series can certainly be seen as an ethnic joke in and of itself, one tinged with racism and xenophobia. In "Lucy Hires an English Tutor" Lucy also expresses an aversion to Ricky's suggestion that they teach their child Spanish and that they will send their child to Havana University. The obvious efforts that Lucy makes to limit the impact that Ricky's cultural heritage might have on their child is linked to her lack of respect for him as a man and as her "ethnic" husband. She wants the child to grow up speaking proper English and living an Anglo lifestyle despite the obvious fact that her husband is Cuban.

In addition to Ricky being mocked and undermined for his lack of polished English, he is often treated as a child and not as a husband. The episode "Ricky Loses His Voice" (which first aired December 1, 1952, on CBS) is one of the best examples. In the narrative, Ricky begins feeling a bit under the weather. When he gets home, he whines and nags for Lucy to give him an aspirin. Lucy treats him as a child and makes several comments and references to him as such. She asks Ethel if Fred always acts "like a child when he gets ill" and poses the question, "Why are men such babies?" When she brings Ricky the aspirin and a glass of water, she places her hand on his forehead to check for a fever and says, "Poor baby." Although this may be seen as a general commentary on the way men behave when they are sick, the evidence that exists throughout the series of Ricky's being treated as a child moves it to the realm of a mother-son relationship. This

particular episode goes well beyond a men-behave-like-children-when-they-are-ill discourse when Ricky is forced to stay in bed for a week. Ricky continues whining and Lucy continues to treat him as a child. When she examines his throat, she grabs him by the hair and pulls his head back forcefully. Since he has a virus in his throat he is not supposed to speak and he is given a small chalkboard to communicate with Lucy. When Lucy tries to get him to take his medicine—what appears to be cough syrup—he writes "No" on his board. She emphasizes that the doctor's orders were for him to take his medication, but he replies in even bigger letters, "NO!!" To which she replies, "Don't shout at me!" She proceeds to try to force him to take his medication, but he closes his mouth and shakes his head while she tries to put a spoonful of cough syrup in it. The cough syrup spills all over his face and his pajamas. Lucy remarks, "Now Ricky, look what you did! Oh, for heaven's sake! Now look, if you are going to act like a child, I am going to treat you like one." She then places him in a headlock and pinches his nose in order to force him to open his mouth. Finally, she manages to get the top of the bottle of cough syrup in his mouth and a dose of the medication down his throat (figure 2.3). While these



Figure 2.3 Lucille Ball as Lucy Ricardo and Desi Arnaz as Ricky Ricardo in "Ricky Loses His Voice" (*I Love Lucy*, 1952)

antics might be dismissed as mere comedic effect, I believe they are primarily used to maintain Ricky in a childlike state and to diminish any cultural capital that his ethnicity might elicit. It is a means of emasculating the Latin lover and simultaneously stripping him of his sexuality and agency.

In his analysis of *I Love Lucy*, Alexander Doty contends that the relationship between Lucy and Ethel in the series is one that is based on lesbian desire.[9] He demonstrates the way the narrative centers on homosocial contexts in order to strengthen the relationship, both physical and emotional, between Lucy and Ethel at the exclusion of Ricky and Fred: "While as a couple Lucy and Ethel only achieve partial or temporary disruption of the status quo, the series depends on their lesbian comic energies to establish and propel most *I Love Lucy* narratives" (*Making Things*, 46). Naturally, one can do a similar homosocial analysis between Ricky and Fred, highlighting the way they at times conspire and bond in opposition to Lucy and Ethel's coupling because the latter obviously threatens the patriarchal order. However, I'm more interested in the way Ricky is not automatically conferred male privilege and, in effect, is unable to maintain a heteronormative household due to: (1) his ethnicity/accent, (2) his childlike role, and (3) his inability to control his spouse.

Lucy is obviously not a "normal" housewife, especially in the context of 1950s television. Besides being in an interracial marriage, she constantly gets involved in wacky schemes to overcome Ricky's attempts to keep her cloistered in the domestic space, doing domestic duties. While Lucy continually figures out ways to undermine Ricky's authority, this comes at the expense of emasculating Ricky. Ricky is a failed husband and man. Even though he is the main breadwinner, he is not completely in control of the household or the household finances. On several occasions, Lucy refuses to do household chores in order to manipulate Ricky. She finds ways to get Ricky to pay for the things she wants even when they cannot afford them. This is one way the power dynamics between the two are reversed. Although she eventually gets caught in some of her own schemes, Lucy undermines Ricky by tricking him or doing things behind his back, especially when she knows he would not approve. I believe all of these tactics are ways in which Ricky's identity is developed as being more of a child than a man. In addition to constantly mocking Ricky for speaking in a funny manner and getting him to do things he doesn't want to do, Lucy is the one who truly controls the household—finances and all. Moreover, her relationship with Ethel often takes precedence over her relationship with Ricky. In his analysis of the famous "Lucy Is

Enciente" episode (1952), Doty maintains that Lucy's pregnancy is portrayed as being more about Lucy and Ethel having a child together than Lucy and Ricky. An interesting nuance in this episode is that when Ricky—while at work—does finally find out that Lucy is pregnant, he stumbles over his words and introduces her as his mother: "I'd like you to meet my mother … I mean, my wife!" This Freudian slip is rather appropriate considering that the birth of Ricky Junior is symbolically the rebirth of Ricky Ricardo, with Lucy and Ethel as the mothers of this nonnuclear family.

Ricky Ricardo as child is one way the Latin lover is queer in *I Love Lucy*. Since the television show is unable to project Desi Arnaz as a Latin lover, most likely due to Hays Code regulations, his sexuality is repressed, his ethnicity is undermined, and his character is reduced to an innocuous childlike figure. Whereas Ramón Novarro's Latin lover image on screen was quite different from his private life, Desi Arnaz's television image was quite different from his real-life reputation as a Latin lover. This interesting reversal and difference in Latin lover roles—public vs. private—is one that isn't always so easy to distinguish, especially today. I now turn to a contemporary representation of the Latin lover, Mario López.

Mario López: On Being a Sex Object and the Reconquista of Beauty

Although there are a number of celebrities I could use for a contemporary analysis of the Latin lover, I believe a look at Mario López (b. 1973) will suffice to show how the Latin lover image has remained virtually static and retains queer characteristics. Besides the fact that today the majority of images of the Latin lover are projected in color as opposed to black and white, not much else has changed with respect to this archetype in the last century; privately and publicly he continues to live in and outside of the Latin lover box, constantly challenging gender and sexual codes of behavior by his varied performances.

Mario López became a teen heartthrob while portraying A.C. Slater in *Saved by the Bell* (1989–93). He has since gone on to participate in a number of film and television projects. There are a number of ways in which he and his body are queer. On a couple of occasions he has played overt gay roles in films and on television: *Breaking the Surface: The Greg Louganis Story* and *Wetback Mountain*. The latter is a *Brokeback Mountain* parody that aired on *Mind of Mencia* in 2006 in which he and Carlos Mencía pretend to be gay in order to prevent

others from suspecting they are Mexican immigrants (the video is available online). López continues to toy with the rumors that he is gay by playing the role in a farcical manner. In 2007, he appeared on *Mind of Mencia* to address the rumors that he was gay. He takes part in what Carlos Mencía labels a "Carlos Slam," where celebrities do spoken poetry performance pieces. When Mencía introduces López, he claims that he wanted to give his friend the opportunity to address the rumors "because way too many people be talking shit about him."[10] As expected, the appearance is a ruse to continue to perplex and entertain the public. Nevertheless, López's performance piece is a poem titled "I Am Not Gay," which highlights the politics surrounding his identity:

> I'm not gay.
> What? You think I'm gay
> because I'm all in good shape
> because I can dance
> and I got dimples?
> Maybe you think I'm pretty.
> Would you be willing to bet your wife on it?
> Come on.
> Just give me 5 minutes.
> I'll do all sorts of gay stuff to her.
> With my big gay tool.[11]

After his reading, López steps off the stage and approaches a male-female married couple who are obviously actors planted in the audience. He asks the man if the woman next to him is his wife, then grabs her, stands her up, and kisses her passionately—demonstrating his virility and his ability to seduce unsuspecting women. After the lengthy, deep kissing, he throws her back in her seat, where she remains dazed by the incident. He then turns to the husband and says, "You're next homes." The entire routine is designed to be comedic, but the politics at play have serious implications and are designed to maintain his identity as ambiguous. López feels compelled to address the rumors that he is gay. To both dispel and confirm the rumors, he capitalizes on his Latin lover identity by threatening men to leave their women with him for five minutes so that he can do "all sorts of gay stuff" to them, publicly demonstrating an erotic act with a woman, and threatening/teasing the husbands that they are next. The performance is a way to maintain López's appeal to a wide range of erotic interests; the Latin lover remains pansexual and omnipotent, dangerous and irresistible. Regardless of whether or not the rumors are true, the fact that

López has and does play gay roles—as mentioned above—both disrupts and reiterates his image as a Latin lover.

Another queer cultural reading one can do of López is around the homosocial relationship between his *Saved by the Bell* character, A.C. Slater, and Zack Morris (played by Mark-Paul Gosselaar). The two characters have an intimate relationship that has obvious homoerotic overtones. There is an excellent *Brokeback Mountain* parody of this relationship available on Youtube that summarizes their relationship in less than four minutes: *Brokeback by the Bell* (aka *Saved by the Bell: Brokeback Style*).

Although the above-mentioned roles are fruitful sites for conducting a queer analysis, I am interested in focusing on two areas with respect to the display of López's body in popular culture: (1) the way it is consumed by mass culture in a manner that relegates it to a submissive position and (2) the way his body and his looks have conquered the United States and white male beauty—what I am calling a *reconquista* of male beauty.

López's sculpted body and good looks have become icons of male beauty. He proudly displays his body and his muscles in various forms: from his naked Burt Reynolds–like pose in *People* (2008) to his shapely butt in *Nip/Tuck* (season 4, 2006). He even has his own exercise book, *Mario Lopez's Knockout Fitness* (2008), where fans can gaze at him shirtless or in skimpy exercise attire under the guise that they are interested in his diet and exercise program. Photos abound of Mario López's body in the media and on the internet. From a young age López began displaying his muscled body for the viewing public. It has been consumed by mass culture for almost twenty years and continues to entertain and intrigue viewers and his fans. Although López is an actor, dancer, musician, and exercise guru, the primary way he entertains is through the erotic display of his body. Both the media and the entertainer himself have long recognized that his beautiful body is a commodity to be exchanged for money, pleasure, and erotic interests.[12] Little commentary focuses on his acting ability, talent as a musician, his ethnicity, or his intellect. Instead, his abs, chest, arms, and buttocks dominate the media attention he receives. Although one might imagine that López would like to be taken seriously as an actor and entertainer, he has been reduced to a sexual object and his body has become the property of voyeurs—male and female alike. What is clear is that López has little control over the public and erotic display of his body. Although some might argue that he has some agency when it comes to such displays or underscore the actor's narcissistic traits, I believe

there exists a socioeconomic imperative that obligates him to remove his clothing and display his body. In *People* (online, September 15, 2008) he was quoted as saying, "My shirtless photo-shoot days are behind me."[13] Nevertheless, he is repeatedly asked to do roles that require him to remove his shirt and other articles of clothing even though he may not feel comfortable having his body used in this way.[14] For example, in his photo shoot for *People* magazine he imitates Christopher Atkins's pose in *The Blue Lagoon* (1980) by wearing a primitive bikini that looks like a cross between Tarzan's underwear and a diaper. In the magazine he is quoted as saying, "This was the most embarrassing and uncomfortable picture to shoot . . . I felt like Mowgli from *The Jungle Book*."[15] Thus, although at times he may not be comfortable displaying his body in highly provocative ways, he is compelled to do so in order to maintain his identity as a sex object, obtain roles, and continue to capitalize on his body. López's identity as a Latin lover has always been ambiguous. He has established a reputation as a man who can seduce others with his good looks, but he is also accused of being too pretty (his dimples often provoking special mention) and appearing gay. López has a body and a look now often associated with the gay macho clone.[16] Although López did marry once—for a brief, two-week period—he has otherwise been single and lived as a bachelor. His brief married life ended after he was accused of being unfaithful to his wife, Ali Landry, even before they got married. Now moving into his late thirties, López remains single and maintains the Latin lover/bachelor image.

Undoubtedly, López's body is something to be admired and consumed. In *Nip/Tuck* (season 4, 2006), López plays a fit and striking plastic surgeon named Mike Hamoui.[17] In a now-famous scene, he is showering at the gym when Christian Troy (played by Julian McMahon)—another plastic surgeon and one of the leading characters of the series—walks into the room. Troy is immediately captivated by Hamoui and, through Troy's eyes, the viewer gets to ogle López's body—he soaps, poses, and caresses his naked body while the camera traces his muscles, abs, and buttocks. The background music is seductive, like the type used in strip clubs or bathhouses. After Hamoui seduces Troy—not to mention us—with his naked dance, Troy takes the shower area right next to him even though they are the only two men in this part of the locker room and there are several other showers from which to choose. This brief scene is highly homoerotic. The two men engage in a conversation that centers on Hamoui's body while they stand naked in the shower and size one



Figure 2.4 Mario López as Mike Hamoui (left) and Julian McMahon as Christian Troy in *Nip/Tuck* (2006)

another up (figure 2.4). The conversation begins when Hamoui catches Troy peering at his body and asks: "Are you staring at my dick?" To which Troy responds, "No, I'm checking out your ass." After a short dialogue related to their work, they return to the issue of Hamoui's body: his abs, his workout routine, his eating habits, and his sex life. Hamoui basically tells Troy that Troy is too old and does not have the discipline it takes to cultivate a body like his. Nevertheless, the relationship between the two maintains its homoerotic overtones and Hamoui clearly comes out on top—so to speak. One of the last scenes of this episode is of Troy visiting Hamoui for plastic surgery. With all of its phallic imagery and implications of sodomy, the scene is of Troy lying facedown in Hamoui's exam/procedure room, naked, with his buttocks exposed (figure 2.5). Hamoui inserts a suction tube in and out of Troy's love handles and buttocks area—penetrating him while removing fat deposits. This erotic exchange between Hamoui and Troy is symbolic of the way López conquers other white males and male beauty in general. Although Julian McMahon is good-looking and a former soap opera star and model himself, López's good looks clearly trump McMahon's and, in effect, López colonizes his body. This reversal of roles between Latino and Anglo men is even more evident in the *People* magazine photo shoot for which López posed in 2008.

In the June 30, 2008 issue of *People*, Mario López was named the Summer's Hottest Bachelor—beating out a number of primarily



Figure 2.5 Mario López (top) and Julian McMahon (bottom) in *Nip/Tuck* (2006)

white men. Besides the fact that López was named the hottest bachelor out of a number of current heartthrobs, what I find most intriguing about the photo shoot is that López displaces a handful of historical white male heartthrobs. The theme of the photo shoot is that of restaging famous poses by sexy men. In all, he does five "sexy poses" that are labeled as such: "Sexy Pose 1," "Sexy Pose 2," and so on. Three of the poses are full-page pictures and two of them are centerfolds (images available online). The famous poses López restages are: Burt Reynolds in *Cosmopolitan* (1972), Richard Gere in *American Gigolo* (1980), Marky Mark in the famous Calvin Klein ad (1992), Brad Pitt in *Thelma and Louise* (1991), and Christopher Atkins in *The Blue Lagoon*. The title of the "article" is somewhat misleading: "Mario Lopez Bares All!" Even though he is completely naked in the first pose, where he imitates Burt Reynolds's famous picture, his arm is placed between his legs and his pubic hair is airbrushed away. The pictures are all obviously digitally altered. Nevertheless, López's beauty emanates from each one. For each photo, there is a small box with a picture of the original pose with bibliographic information. Mario's presence dominates each page while the original men—all Anglo—are reduced to a small corner and basically stripped of their respective titles as sex objects. In one fell swoop, López conquers a whole generation of sex objects (ranging from 1972 to 2008, if one includes the images of the current contenders for the title) and replaces their Anglo bodies with his prized Latino one.[18]

The *People* layout and the interview itself have several queer signifiers. In addition to the erotic display of his body, each photo is accompanied by a quote from López. With respect to the Marky Mark pose ("Sexy Pose 3"), he is quoted as saying, "My buddies tease me because I'm always running around my house in my underwear. I'm a boxer-briefs kind of guy. That's my deal."[19] If the vague "that's my deal" and being a "boxer-briefs kind of guy" identification is not evidence enough that López is queer, one should certainly question why he runs around in boxer briefs when his "buddies" are "visiting." Moreover, with respect to his Brad Pitt pose, "Sexy Pose 4," he remarks: "I loved *Thelma and Louise*, and Brad Pitt's role was iconic. Messing around with the blow dryer was fun."[20] It is impossible not to notice the resemblance to a gay macho clone in this image: shirtless, jeans unbuckled, and long strands of hair protruding from his cowboy hat while holding a phallic symbol in his hand. As a phallic symbol, the rather large hair dryer can be considered a means of displaying that mysterious part of López's anatomy that remains behind the zipper that his unbuckled jeans invite the viewer to search for and fantasize about, but it can also represent Brad Pitt's phallus, or any one else's. The use of the hair dryer in both the original Pitt scene and in López's photo replaces a potentially destructive phallic symbol—a gun—with something that is not as dangerous and typically associated with female beauty.

Overall, López's body has been used to set a new standard of male beauty where the Chicano/Latino male body replaces the white male body as the paragon of male beauty. This aesthetic is now more mainstream than not. Whereas the original Latin lover identity was constructed around him as the ethnic other, López's body relocates the Latin lover to the center of popular culture, where it is designed to be consumed by mass culture. It is not so much the exotic other, but more so the erotic ideal to which all men are compared and measured. López's body and looks are to be showcased and admired; he exudes an unrestrained and ambiguous sexuality. As such, the Latin lover remains within the parameters of a Latin lover identity while simultaneously possessing queer characteristics that shape a queer identity.

Conclusion: Latin Lovers Are Queer

The Latin lover has a long trajectory in popular culture in the United States. His identity has been shaped by his exotic and erotic markings, and his limitless capacity to seduce others. He has been used to fulfill

hidden fantasies, to establish male aesthetics, and as a model for illicit and unrestrained sexuality. To some degree, the Latin lover has not changed at all. As I have shown, he has always possessed queer characteristics; his gender and his sexuality have consistently fluctuated along a gender and sexual continuum in a way that prohibits his identity from being categorized in any fixed way. The Latin lover is not Latin or a lover, but a product of the hidden desires of the people who have consumed him for almost a century.

2

(In)Visible Queer Identities

3

(Re)Reading the Chicano Literary Canon

> In short, he was a sissy, really, and he could fool a lot of people.
> Narrator of *Pocho*, describing Richard Rubio[1]

The bildungsroman has a long and ubiquitous presence in the history of literature worldwide. As narratives that center on the maturation of a young protagonist and her/his relationship to the society in which she/he resides, novels of this genre often include experiences that shape gender and sexual development and, in turn, identity. Such locations present numerous opportunities for examining queer identities. In her excellent analysis of Chicana "lesbian" works of fiction, *With Her Machete in Her Hand: Reading Chicana Lesbians* (2006), Catrióna Rueda Esquibel examines Chicana novels that center on young female protagonists: *The House on Mango Street*, by Sandra Cisneros (1984); *The Last of the Menu Girls*, by Denise Chávez (1986); *Margins*, by Terri de la Peña (1992); and *Gulf Dreams*, by Emma Pérez (1996). In each, Esquibel focuses on the ways in which intimate relationships between girls/women are homoerotic. She argues that Chicana lesbian writing has a long trajectory in the history of Chicana/o literature that goes beyond those texts where clearly marked lesbian identities are present. In this way, she expands and enriches the Chicana lesbian canon considerably and creates a discourse on the ways in which characters that are not overtly marked as gay or lesbian can and do contribute to a discourse on nonnormative gender and sexuality.

In this section, I show how three canonical Chicano texts that have been historically read as heteronormative can be considered queer: *Pocho*, by José Antonio Villarreal (1959); *. . . y no se lo tragó la tierra*, by Tomás Rivera (1971); and *Bless Me, Ultima*, by Rudolfo Anaya (1972). In each, I focus on the young male leading protagonist: Richard Rubio, the unnamed protagonist in *. . . y no se lo tragó la tierra*, and Antonio Márez, respectively. My goal is to dismantle what

Alexander Doty calls the "heterocentric trap": "assuming that all characters…are straight unless labeled, coded, or otherwise obviously proven to be queer."[2] I do not believe that any of these texts or characters must necessarily be read as heterosexual. In fact, I highlight the clues present in each of the texts that point to the construction of a nonnormative social and sexual identity for each of these characters. I also do what Doty encourages us to do: fill in the gaps and silences that exist in the texts that lend themselves particularly well to queer readings.[3] These characters diverge from heteronormative paradigms and their identities are very much linked to the rejection of heteronormativity. This is what I am designating as queer.

In (re)thinking why I have always been able to identify with Richard Rubio, the unnamed protagonist in *… y no se lo tragó la tierra*, and Antonio Márez, I came to the conclusion that the processes by which we come of age, despite particular differences that might exist, share commonalities regardless of the way our identities—sexual and otherwise—may develop. Naturally, this is part of the universal appeal of bildungsromans. One can almost always find something in a coming-of-age novel with which she/he can identify irrespective of gender, class, ethnicity, or sexuality. Nevertheless, as a young Chicano, there was something about these novels that spoke to my particular experience as a farm worker, the son of working-class parents, my quest for knowledge, *and* my lack of interest in following heteronormative rituals. Like the characters in these novels, I was not interested in getting married to a woman, settling down, or having children. Instead, like these characters, I ensconced myself in books, my thoughts, other worlds. I wanted to do anything but follow in the footsteps of my parents, which I contend is the primary goal of each of these characters and many others represented in the cultural production of Chicanas/os and Latinas/os.

As bildungsromans, all three novels contain scenes that speak to the protagonists' sexual awakening. Some of these incidents include explicit sexual acts, while others highlight experiences and other characters that influence gender and sexual behavior. Each one of these characters is queer in the way he does not succumb to compulsory heterosexuality, in the relationships he has—or does not have—with other characters, and in the way he does not fulfill his obligatory roles as a male within his respective community, thereby challenging and reconfiguring gender norms.

Now, I must underscore that I am not reading these characters as gay. Instead, I want to show how they are queer. The point of showing that they are queer is to demonstrate that characters that do

not contain heteronormative markings need not be read as heterosexual. Instead of locating their identities into a rigid category, I use the term *queer* to describe a wide range of ambiguous and nonheteronormative social and sexual traits that shape each character's identity. As I make clear, the characters in these novels and their actions are not heteronormative and they should be included among the characters that have shaped a long history of queer representation in Chicana/o and Latina/o cultural texts.

Writers, "Those Others": Voyeurism, Orgies, Pedophilia, and Sodomy in *Pocho*

Pocho, first published in 1959, is a landmark novel that remains an integral part of the Chicano literary canon. It is one of the first Chicano novels to gain widespread recognition. The novel is largely based on the life of its author, José Antonio Villarreal.[4] The primary source of conflict in *Pocho* is Richard Rubio's maturation in a society that is very different from the one in which his parents were raised. Richard's parents attempt to rear their children with traditional Mexican values. However, the family resides in the Santa Clara Valley, not Mexico, and Richard finds that everything he learns from books, in school, and from other sources stands in opposition to the things he is taught at home. He constantly rejects his parents' traditional ways and searches outside the domestic space for people with whom he can engage intellectually and emotionally. Along the way, he forms close bonds with people in his community that shape his sexuality and his behavior—outside of heteronormative contexts.

One of the first significant relationships Richard has with someone outside his home and outside of a normative realm is the one he has with the Portuguese João Pedro Manõel Alves (aka Joe Pete). Joe Pete is an adult in his early forties, while Richard is approximately eleven years old. The two form an intimate bond and spend a considerable amount of time together in remote and private spaces—initially with the company of a nine-year-old, Genevieve Freitas, but eventually without her presence. Richard is intrigued by the stories Joe Pete tells about faraway places, exotic foods, the arts, and other forms of culture. From his mentor, Richard gains valuable knowledge about things he does not learn in school. What is more, Joe Pete teaches Richard about an array of nonnormative sexualities. The character is given a compendium of queer signifiers: the townspeople occasionally refer to him as "that queer one" (80), and there are rumors that he is a pedophile. Moreover, he and Richard share a special relationship.

Joe Pete begins to confide very personal and intimate details of his life, things that presumably no one else in the community knows about him. For example, Richard learns that although Joe Pete's father wanted him to become a lawyer, he chose to study literature and began hanging out with "literary friends" when "something happened" (83). Joe Pete is somewhat vague about what happened, but eventually divulges that his father began seeing him as a daughter instead of as a son. Since he is the only male among the four children, his father was counting on him to carry on the family name. Because Joe Pete is unable to fulfill this obligation, his father disowns him: "What a scene my father made when I appeared in São Miguel! I was his only son, his heir. Three sisters I had, but they would soon marry and take another name. 'You have borne me four daughters, woman!' he screamed at my mother" (83).

Besides Joe Pete's inability to fulfill his obligatory role as the only male child in his family, his queer identity is developed further by his perceived foreignness and his experiences traveling to faraway places, searching for others with whom he can identify: "In New York I was lost, so I searched for a place where I could be with some of my own kind. I was running away from my people, and yet I could not live without them, so I went to San Diego" (84). Although he does not specifically state what he means by "my own kind" or "my people," the end of the same passage reveals that during this period he was struggling with his homoerotic desire:

> For a time I used to be frightened, because something was happening to me. I found myself strongly attracted to men. Not in the strong sexual way, and not men I knew, but just anyone I chanced to see on the street. I had suddenly, when I did not expect it, a strange urge to kiss a man walking past me. But that has disappeared now. (84)

The ambiguous references to his "kind" of people and his ambivalence regarding simultaneously wanting to be with them and run away from them are indicative of a struggle with internalized homophobia. His confession that he felt a strong and inexplicable attraction to anonymous men is a reference to homoerotic desire despite his suggestions that it was not in a "strong sexual way" and that the urge has since disappeared. His use of "strong" to qualify his attraction to men leaves a wide range of sexual levels of intensity open (e.g., he was somewhat or slightly attracted to men). Moreover, his behavior and his discussions with Richard indicate that he is still struggling with homophobia.

The relationship between Joe Pete and Richard is very queer. Besides the differences in their ages, the homosocial environments they create, and their open discussions on (homo)eroticism, they have an intimate emotional and physical relationship that is homoerotic. As Eve Kosofsky Sedgwick suggests, the intimate bonds that materialize between members of the same sex in homosocial environments are directly linked to homoeroticism.[5] The two have an exclusive relationship that is imbued with a compendium of taboos, and there are several clues that make it evident that both characters are aware of this. For example, signs surface that indicate Joe Pete is battling with his feelings for Richard, knowing that the boy is too young for their relationship to fully materialize or aware that what he is doing is not socially acceptable:

> From that day, the two talked as often as possible, and the man began to see in the boy a reflected justification for his own misspent life . . . And sometimes he would have fears for the boy, and did not speak for days. At other times, the same emotion made him rave and storm, shouting fierce and unintelligible words, until, at last, he would clasp the boy tightly in his arms and cry. And although Richard did not fully comprehend the reason for these outbursts, he was not frightened by them and did not question the man. (85)

Joe Pete's behavior around Richard coincides with his ambivalent feelings regarding his attraction to other men and his desire to be with and run away from people of his "kind." The fact that Richard does not reject Joe Pete in any way and is not afraid of the intimacy between them speaks to Richard's own curiosity with respect to same-sex and nonheteronormative relationships and sexuality. Richard never tires of Joe Pete's lessons on queer sexualities; he is just as invested in his relationship with Joe Pete as the latter is in Richard. What is more, Richard is constantly probing for details when Joe Pete describes queer sexual experiences. For example, when Joe Pete tells him the story about a poet with whom he became acquainted, he describes a sexual experience that involves voyeurism, a ménage à trois and, quite possibly, sodomy and/or rimming. The scene begins with Joe Pete visiting the poet and meeting his wife and children. After putting the children to bed, the husband conveniently leaves the room (presumably the living room or den), and the woman begins seducing Joe Pete, claiming that her husband would not mind. While having sexual intercourse with the wife, Joe Pete discovers that the husband is watching and deriving pleasure from it. Then, the

poet/husband does "something" to Joe Pete that involves the latter's back area:

> And while I was over his wife, he did something to me. I was filled with disgust, and hated them and myself, for even *I* was now repugnant to myself. I fled the house. The act he performed I had heard about, but never in my life had I learned of a man getting pleasure from watching another man make love to his wife. (87)

The description of Joe Pete's physical position while fornicating renders his back area vulnerable to the poet. Notice how Joe Pete dodges details of "the act" by focusing on voyeurism instead of the physical act itself. Nevertheless, inferring that Joe Pete was sodomized in some way (either with a penis or any other phallic object) is completely logical. Richard, attentive and curious, probes for more details: "What did he do to you?" (87). Joe Pete refuses to be explicit and allows Richard to infer the act from the richness of the details he already gave him:

> "Ah! It is too horrible to even think about it! How could *you* understand?" he said with a passion. He suddenly reached out and tenderly rumpled the boy's hair, as if he felt sorry he had been rude. "Because you are young enough and as yet unspoiled enough," he said, "perhaps you *can* understand. Else why would I be telling you all this?" (87)

Joe Pete is well aware that Richard is not like the other children in the neighborhood and, as the author emphasizes with italics, *can* understand the complexities of nonheteronormative relationships, regardless of what he has or hasn't learned thus far. In fact, even though Joe Pete does not describe "the act" in detail, the narrative hints at Richard's not only drawing a conclusion about the act, but imagining it: "But he did not tell him, and though his imagination made him weak so his knees shook, Richard knew he should not ask him again" (87). What is more, Joe Pete's reflection on why he is engaging in such a dialogue with the young boy reveals that he has ulterior motives. By now, most readers are probably already questioning why Joe Pete is telling Richard about what might be considered perverse sexual encounters. Clearly, he sees something in Richard that makes him feel safe about discussing such topics; logically, he has identified Richard as someone who is one of his "own kind." Although this might be seen as a form of indoctrination to a nonheteronormative lifestyle or Joe Pete's interest in materializing a more physical relationship

with the protagonist, Richard's obvious attraction to Joe Pete and to his stories insinuate that he is invested in the relationship and is participating in it of his own free will. After all, from early in the novel, Richard has the maturity level of an adult and is associated with nonnormative gender behavior.

The relationship between the two ends unexpectedly: Joe Pete is jailed and accused of molesting several children, male and female, as well as of impregnating Genevieve Freitas. While Joe Pete's abrupt departure from Richard's life does not permit the relationship between the two to develop further, their relationship is ultimately queer with respect to the subjects they discuss (nonnormative sexuality), the homosocial environment they create, and the physical intimacy they share. Moreover, there are clues that Richard does not give complete details about the nature of their relationship nor tell the truth when questioned about it. Since most of the townspeople know that Joe Pete and Richard spent a lot of time alone together, they assume that Richard was also molested by him. When questioned by the police officer, Richard intentionally lies and withholds information about Joe Pete and their relationship. The boy knows there are secrets between them that must be kept; he also knows what the police officer is trying to get out of him, and he is so evasive the police officer accuses him of being a "*wise little bastard*" (89). Richard claims Joe Pete never touched him, which we already know is not true; they had some form of a physical relationship, even if it just involved Richard's physically consoling Joe Pete during his times of duress. Whether or not they had a sexual relationship is inconclusive, but one cannot rely on Richard's public testimony, because he has already learned that the relationship the two had was not socially acceptable. Nevertheless, they clearly had a homoerotic relationship and they formed an intimate bond with each other that lasts throughout Richard's formative years. Richard never forgets Joe Pete. In fact, he is obviously heartbroken over his absence. Almost a year later, when Richard is about to turn thirteen, the narrator tells us—in a phrase not particularly well-structured—that Richard "thought of his friend Joe Pete Manõel, though not forgotten, did not hurt as much" (102). Naturally, from this statement one can derive that the protagonist was still heartbroken to some degree. In fact, Joe Pete's memory and his name are evoked again in chapter 8 (136) and once again on the final page of the novel, where his name is included near the top of Richard's list as one of the "beautiful people he had known" (187).[6]

The fact that Joe Pete is in some way present throughout the narrative highlights the significant role he plays in shaping Richard

Rubio's life. Although Joe Pete is only physically present in one chapter (4), it is evident that Joe Pete influences Richard's life and actions throughout his young adulthood. The relationship and the conversations the two have are ingrained in Richard's psyche; they shape the way he thinks about sexuality, the world, and his place in it. I posit that Richard Rubio identifies more with Joe Pete than any other character in the novel. There are several parallels between Richard's life and Joe Pete's: both are the only male offspring in their families, both have an insatiable appetite for literature, both reject the male roles that others attempt to impose on them, both reject heteronormative institutions (marriage, religion, and God), both engage in nonnormative sexual behavior, and both experience a form of exile from the community. Joe Pete clearly possesses all these traits, and Richard is, as I show, of the same "kind."

After Joe Pete, the other character with whom Richard forms a deep emotional bond is another male who is approximately the same age as the protagonist—Ricky Malatesta. As in his relationship with Joe Pete, Ricky becomes Richard's soul mate of sorts, and there exists an inexplicable attraction between them: "The two enjoyed each other's company immensely, and though it is obscure what attraction Richard held for Ricky, they were inseparable" (109). Besides the homoerotic dimension of their homosocial relationship, Ricky becomes the only nonfamily member for whom Richard professes his love. After spending a fun afternoon together, where Ricky treats Richard to an ice-cream cone, the two have an intimate conversation about their relationship:

> *Ricky*: Gee, we had a lot of fun—huh, Richard?
> *Richard*: Yeah. We always have fun together . . . That's because we love each other.
> *Ricky*: What the hell did you say?
> *Richard*: Just that I love you, that's all.
> *Ricky*: Hey, you're not going queer, are you? 'Cause if you are, I . . .
> *Richard*: You stupid prick! . . . You had to ruin it . . . just like that you killed one of the nicest things we both have! (112)

Richard gets so upset at Ricky that he throws his ice-cream cone at him, knowing that their relationship has been ruined by Ricky's response to his avowal of his feelings. Richard appears to be upset that Ricky did not respond the way he had hoped or that Ricky eroticized Richard's notion of "love." Although Richard claims that he loves Ricky as a friend, consider that Richard is now a mature teenager and that he has already learned his lesson about intimacy between

men being taboo. His father and his experience with Joe Pete have inscribed a certain amount of homophobia in Richard. Besides Joe Pete's symbolic hanging by the angry mob of townspeople after being accused of pedophilia, Richard's father has instilled in him that heterosexuality "is the only [socially acceptable] way" (90). Despite these lessons on masculinity and compulsory heterosexuality, Richard takes the risk of professing his love to Ricky—with all its homoerotic implications—and once again, he suffers a severe emotional blow.

Richard's queer identity is developed in several ways. In *Pocho*, being a writer serves as a metaphor for being queer when related to male characters, as does having an interest in literature and reading in general. Richard's interest in books and writing stands in diametrical opposition to the masculine norms his parents and his culture attempt to instill in him. From early on, Richard's reading is associated with nonmasculine behavior. In fact, some of the first books he reads are categorized as "girls' books," which we discover when he offers his classmate Mary Madison some advice on what to read:

> *Richard*: You'll like the *Campfires* . . . They're girls' books.
> *Mary*: You read girls' books?
> *Richard*: I used to when I was little. They're not as exciting as the *Swifts* or the *Rovers*, but I got to read them all. (71)

The narrator then tells us, "She did not ask why [he read girls' books], and he liked her for it" (72). We never find out why Richard read such books during a particular time in his childhood. Nonetheless, his relief that Mary does not probe him about it hints that he is hiding something from her that is related to his interest in such books, something for which he obviously feels ashamed.

Throughout the novel, only females and queer men are associated with reading and writing; every one of the male characters who is interested in letters is linked in some way with nonnormative sexuality: Joe Pete, Juan Rubio's (Richard's father) queer acquaintance, the voyeur poet who performed "the act" on Joe Pete, and the two gay men Richard befriends from his creative writing course.[7] Richard identifies with books and writing and with the majority of these male characters. He very much wants to be a writer and he asserts this claim on various occasions. The most telling is when his father explains to him that he had an acquaintance who he identifies as queer by labeling him as "strange" and as one of "those others" (168). Juan Rubio confesses that he was worried that his son would turn out like this man: "I thought you would become like that. Because you had the bad lot to live with a houseful of girls, and your mother protected

you so much. I thought that if it happened so, I would try to understand it" (168). After telling Richard in a roundabout manner that this acquaintance was queer, he divulges that the man was also a writer: "This acquaintance I spoke about, he is a writer," to which Richard responds, "That is what I will be" (169). He proceeds to tell his father that he wants to be a writer more than anything and then asks for forgiveness, knowing that his chosen career is not one that is socially acceptable. Apparently, they both have made the association between being a writer and not adhering to heteronormative customs. His father accepts Richard's decision and offers him advice: "Only, never let anything stand in your way of it, be it women, money, or—what people talk about today—position" (169). Richard certainly heeds his advice; he never marries and never allows anything to get in the way of his goal. Asserting his identity as a writer is intrinsically linked to Richard's coming out of the closet. The careful use of "That is what I will be" is ambiguous and can be a reference to the "strange" man's queerness, his profession, or both. Notice that the conversation between the father and the son is primarily about the acquaintance's queerness and Juan Rubio just tags on "he is a writer" at the end of his description. Since Richard cannot tell his father that he wants to be one of "those others," he uses the ambiguous response, "That is what I will be," which functions as a substitute for asserting a queer identity. Richard identifies as a writer, and in the novel, being—or wanting to be—a writer serves as a metaphor for being queer. Therefore, this interchange between the young boy and his father can certainly be seen as an attempt for Richard to affirm his identity as queer.

In the earlier scene between Ricky and Richard, when Ricky rejects Richard's "I love you" comment, the two also link letters with queerness. Ricky, trying to dissipate the tension between the two, tells Richard, "Aw, that's okay, Richard. I don't really think you're queer. You're just funnier'n hell sometimes, and then you read all that poetry and stuff" (113). Immediately after Ricky's comment, Richard goes home, feeling despondent and alone. Although Ricky claims he doesn't think Richard is queer, the passage after the dialogue and the "funnier'n hell" comment make it clear that Ricky does think Richard is queer and the protagonist comes to the conclusion that Ricky will never be a "writer" like him:

> He felt empty and suddenly very lonely. Then he thought of how, at one time, he had lived in fear lest Ricky should decide to become a writer, for if he should, Ricky would, without a doubt, be a greater one than he

> could ever be. And the thought that he had passed beyond Ricky made him confident once more. Confident and strangely powerful. (113)

Aside from this passage, there is never any indication that Richard's best friend has an interest in being a writer. In fact, Ricky has no interest in college or books; he only wants to make money in the "grocery business."[8] Moreover, apart from enjoying each other's company and the similarity in their names, the narrative indicates that Richard and Ricky have little in common. There are a series of traits in each character and in their relationship that place Ricky in a masculine position and Richard in a nonmasculine one: while Ricky rejects school and books, Richard is absorbed in them; whereas Ricky has hair on his legs, Richard's are hairless; Ricky possesses the economic means to support their extracurricular activities, and Richard has no money. There is also the issue of Richard's shame in exposing his dirty and hairless legs to Ricky, to which I will return later.

Richard's fear that Ricky will become a writer is really a form of homophobia, a fear that his friend might be queer also. Ricky never demonstrates an interest in being a writer, but Richard imagines Ricky as a "writer" (i.e., queer), which is problematic for the protagonist because he does not know of a way to consummate a loving relationship with another male; he may also fear that Ricky would excel in the imagined queer existence (as he excels at everything he does), whereas Richard has yet to figure out how to live a queer lifestyle freely. What is more, Richard knows that if he is to live a queer existence, he cannot do it in his community. Queerness in the novel is overwhelmingly associated with other worlds and individuals separating themselves from their communities of origin. Notice that when Richard decides that Ricky will not be a "writer," he feels confident and powerful because he has "passed beyond Ricky," even though there was never a competition between the two to be writers. The only way he passes beyond Ricky is via his queerness. Richard has concluded that he is more queer than Ricky and will have to leave Ricky behind. Consider that after the incident above, they stop spending time alone together and their relationship is ultimately ruined by Richard's "I love you" comment.

After the exchange with Ricky, Richard does experiment with a relationship with a female; however, he never truly forms intimate bonds with any females in the novel. The young Mary Madison develops a childhood crush on him and claims she will marry him, but Richard does not respond. His interest in her is only intellectual, because she shares his love for reading. Later, Richard does date the

former tomboy Zelda, but he clearly does not fall in love with her. Besides not holding her in very high esteem, he never tells her he loves her (143). Moreover, his relationship with Zelda appears to be only a smoke screen hiding his desire to be with his male companions, especially Ricky. When his friends from the gang begin partaking in a circle jerk in the big barn in Richard's backyard, initially Richard does not participate, choosing to masturbate in the privacy of his bathroom at home. Ricky and the others attempt to lure Richard into their masturbatory circle (which is queer in and of itself), but it is not until Zelda joins them that Richard begins to partake in a veritable orgy,[9] where Zelda becomes the medium by which both Richard and his male friends consummate their desire for one another.

From a very young age, Zelda begins hanging out with boys only. She is characterized as a tomboy and bully, almost an ogre. She possesses the ability to beat up all the boys in the group, and she is inarticulate and unkempt. The first way she is queer is through her nonconformity to normative gender roles. Her identity is constructed as not only just-one-of-the-guys, but also as one of the most feared members of the gang. Early in the narrative, she dominates and physically tortures all the boys, including Ricky:

> Ricky Malatesta first gained Richard's admiration when he fought and lost to Zelda on five successive days. At least once a week thereafter, he tried to wrest the leadership from the rugged tomboy, and was the only one in that section of town who did not fear her. Her dominance was practically the only frustration in Ricky's young life, for he could do anything. (109)

Zelda maintains her status as the strongest and most feared member of the gang until her body is eroticized. When this happens, her body is used sexually by multiple members of the gang simultaneously. In "The Traffic in Women: Notes on the 'Political Economy' of Sex," Gayle Rubin argues that in a patriarchal society women are often used as objects of exchange between men in order to strengthen their kinship while maintaining women in a constant state of oppression.[10] Thus, women may be gifted as a means of strengthening homosocial bonds. Clearly, Zelda's body becomes the conduit by which the gang members are further able to act on their homoerotic desire for one another. While initially Richard and Zelda do not participate in the masturbatory circles, they both get involved once Zelda's body is eroticized. Not surprisingly, Zelda and Richard are the two members who eventually get marked by nonmasculine traits. As they get older, both

of their identities transform in a way that makes them less masculine in order to disassociate them from the rest of the gang members.

Zelda is eventually overpowered, not by any individual but by the whole gang, when her body is "feminized" and eroticized. Zelda is reduced to a submissive role during the first orgy and is never able to regain the status she held prior to the encounter. The day of the first encounter, Ricky is the first person who has sexual intercourse with Zelda. The narrative gives us clues as to Richard's thoughts during the incident, which can easily be seen as a homoerotic encounter between Richard and Ricky. During the scene, Richard is clearly fixated on Ricky's unbuckling his belt and engaging in intercourse with Zelda. Richard's interest appears to be to see Ricky naked and to watch him fornicate: "Jesus Christ! thought Richard. That Ricky!" (119). Notice the ambiguity in his reaction. His amazement can certainly be at the mere fact that Ricky is following through with the encounter, but it can equally be a reaction to seeing his friend's body or witnessing his ability to perform sexually. Considering that the narrative describes only Ricky's actions as he is about to have sex with Zelda and that there is little regard for Zelda (not even a reference to her body or actions), I find the latter conclusion to be more logical, especially if we take into account the history between the two boys and Richard's attempt to develop a loving relationship with him. As René Girard explains, a subject's desire for a certain object is provoked by another person's desire (the mediator) for the same object, thereby creating a triangular relationship where the mediator becomes the mechanism by which the subject and object materialize their desire for one another.[11]

After several orgies with the rest of the gang in Richard's backyard barn, Richard and Zelda begin to develop an exclusive physical relationship. When Zelda asks him, "Why'd ya make me do it with all the guys that day?" Richard responds, "I didn't care about them, but I wanted it, and that was the only way I could get it" (142). Notice he doesn't say, I wanted *you*, but I wanted "it," which some might see as a reference to having sex with Zelda but can arguably also refer to seeing Ricky naked, seeing Ricky have sex, or having sex with Ricky vicariously through a voyeuristic act or through having sex with Zelda immediately after Ricky. If the novel contained only one or two ambiguous responses of this nature, I might be more apt to let such responses go by without interrogating them in such a way, but the fact that I have pointed out several ambiguous responses of this nature should make it clear that these are not only legitimate but also logical conclusions.

Zelda and Ricky do carry on a sexual relationship, but it is not heteronormative. Besides Zelda's initial characterization as a bully, ogre, and just-one-of-the-guys, she was the only one who was able to dominate Ricky. For Richard, Ricky "*was* the top" (109); he saw Ricky as a hero of sorts, despite his inability to overpower Zelda. However, once Richard accepts that he cannot have an intimate relationship with Ricky because Ricky will never be a "writer" like him, he settles for the only person who is accessible and happens to be stronger (i.e., more masculine); Zelda is the only person with whom he can have a socially acceptable sexual relationship while living in his community, but she is also a substitute for all the boys in the gang, especially for Ricky, since the two were constantly vying for control of the gang and since the other members of the gang do not figure prominently in the narrative.

There is an interesting parallel between the relationship Richard and Zelda have and the one between Richard and Ricky that becomes evident in a minute detail that is scattered in two different parts of the narrative. Just before Richard professes his love for Ricky, the two boys are sitting on a curb, waiting for the bus. Ricky stretches his legs out to admire his shoes and then pulls up his pant legs to show Richard that he is growing hair. When he tries to get Richard to show his legs, Richard gets very uncomfortable because his legs are dirty and hairless, so he initially refuses. Richard finally surrenders once Ricky tells him it is okay that his legs are dirty and he is moved deeply: "Richard felt affection surge through him because Ricky said nothing about his very dirty legs" (110).

Compare a later scene that takes place just before the first orgy, when Zelda removes her clothes and displays her vulnerable and naked body in front of the gang. All the other boys remain speechless for a while, admiring her body. However, Richard is the first to speak and he comments, "Your legs are dirty" (118), which makes her blush. In a later scene, she admits to Richard that she was ashamed when he made that comment (142). Whereas Richard focuses on the flaws of Zelda's exposed body, he relishes Ricky's overlooking the flaws in his exposed legs, dirty and hairless as they may be. In the same manner that Ricky penetrated Richard's legs with his gaze, making the latter blush and relegating him to a submissive position, Richard peers at Zelda's legs, which relegates her to a submissive position, just before Ricky has his way with her. As a result, Zelda's legs become an extension of Richard's legs, just one of several clues that Zelda serves as the medium by which Richard is able to act on his desire for Ricky.

Richard's relationship with Zelda proves to be nothing like the relationship he has with Ricky. Whereas Richard seeks companionship, approval, and affection from Ricky, he treats Zelda like a disposable object: "Few people knew that Zelda was his girl, because Richard seldom took her to movies or dances. Nor did they spend all their time together, as most young people going steady will do" (144). Nonetheless, he maintains the relationship peripherally, in order to create the illusion that he is normal. He admits to himself and others that he will never commit himself to a woman entirely, nor to the institution of marriage. Aside from their sexual relationship, the two have little in common and do not share intimate moments. The only thing they do have in common is Ricky, who has been part of this love triangle from the onset.

Richard Rubio is queer. He straddles two worlds, a hypermasculine, heterosexist one and a queer one. All along, Richard does not adhere to heteronormative behavior—gender, social, or sexual. Although he does not overtly identify as queer, I have shown that he overwhelmingly engages in queer social and sexual behavior. His identity falls somewhere along a Chicano gender and sexual continuum, but at neither extreme. In other words, he is not straight or gay; instead, he is queer, which can encompass a wide range of sexualities that diverge from heteronormativity. Similarly, with respect to gender, he is not entirely masculine or "feminine." Throughout the novel, Richard is often ambiguously portrayed as both. For example, when he turns twelve, he is already developing an awareness of himself as being somewhere in between the two:

> [Richard] might not be a boy, after all, because he had seen a hermaphrodite in the carnival at the Portagee [*sic*] fiesta, and now spent a lot of time in front of the mirror watching to see on which side he would have the breast and mustache; yet this morning when he woke up, he was twelve and a man, for he had a hard on, and it was a real good one, and did not go away until he peed." (96)

Richard is often associated with both genders. He is sometimes a "sissy" and sometimes a "man." Since Richard does not fulfill his obligatory roles as a male, both within his family structure and his community, he never truly becomes the person his parents want him to be. While Richard's parents attempt to make a "man" out of their son by trying to get him to quit school, quit reading, and work to help support the family, Richard consistently disrupts their plans for

him. Moreover, when Richard's parents separate and his father leaves the house, Richard's mother expects her son to become the "man of the house" and step into his father's shoes. Richard tells her he will do it, but then leaves the house also. Instead of replacing his father's role in the home, he enrolls in a creative writing course and eventually leaves Santa Clara altogether.

As is the case with many protagonists in Chicana/o and Latina/o texts, the protagonist removes himself from the barrio. He manages to leave his environment and escape a heteronormative existence by joining the military, thereby ensconcing himself in a homosocial space. Although there are few signs that Richard will ever live a heteronormative existence, there are several that hint at a nonheteronormative one: the absence of a female partner, his association with "those others," the rejection of his family, the rejection of religion, his self-imposed exile, the preference for homosocial environments, and his refusal to accept his obligatory role as the remaining male member in his household. All these traits contribute to the construction of a queer identity for Richard Rubio that prevents him from fully participating in the heteronormative world he rejects, and as the narrator informs the reader, for him "there would never be a coming back" (187).

CONFESSING SINS: VOYEURISM, SACRILEGE, AND PERVERSITY IN . . . *Y NO SE LO TRAGÓ LA TIERRA*

As with Richard Rubio, there is absolutely no reason why the unnamed protagonist in Tomás Rivera's 1971 classic, . . . *y no se lo tragó la tierra*, must be read as heterosexual. As another bildungsroman, the novella includes scenes that highlight the youth's sexual awakening; however, there is never any clear indication that he is or will be heteronormative. In fact, I argue that there are more clues that he will reject heteronormativity. In the same way that he rejects religion and separates himself from the structure of the family through his solitude, the protagonist appears to be disaffected by heterosexual acts. The source of his disaffection is unclear, but this ambiguity in the novel indeed permits the character to be read as queer. Moreover, the novella itself contains a number of nonheteronormative characters and acts.

When the protagonist is forced to live with Don Laíto and Doña Bone for three weeks so he can finish school, he is introduced to a bizarre and unsettling lifestyle, not to mention a morbid situation. He learns that many of the rumors regarding the two were in fact true: they were bootleggers, they stole, and the sweetbread they made

and sold to the townspeople was made in unsanitary conditions. The protagonist is also privy to more private and sexual matters concerning the relationship between the two. He witnesses the relationship that develops between Doña Bone and "the wetback" while Don Laíto is away. Although he doesn't actually see their physical interaction, the protagonist knows that when "the wetback" arrives the child is not allowed in the house and that the man leaves Doña Bone money. It doesn't take the protagonist long to put two and two together, and he claims he felt embarrassed when Doña Bone tried to explain the relationship she was having.[12]

Doña Bone's extramarital relationship with "the wetback" is just one queer dimension of these characters. The fact that there is an exchange of money further queers the relationship by adding an element of prostitution to it—both infidelity and prostitution are outside of heteronormative realms regardless of the gender of the subjects involved because they involve multiple partners, relationships that are not sanctioned by the state or the Church, and sex acts that are not committed for procreative purposes. Moreover, there is an indication that Don Laíto knows and condones what Doña Bone is doing. In fact, after a number of visits, Doña Bone conspires with Don Laíto to murder "the wetback" and steal his money and valuables. They carry out their plot and force the child protagonist to bury the body. The relationship between Doña Bone and "the wetback" and the one between Doña Bone and Don Laíto are queer in that they veer from heteronormative paradigms. Doña Bone has an extramarital relationship that involves an exchange of money and that is condoned by her husband. These traits mark these characters as queer because they do not behave according to the social and sexual edicts of heteronormativity.

In the novella, not even the nuns or priests manage to avoid queer markings. The protagonist's relationship with the Church, authority figures of the Church, and, ultimately, God is mired by the hypocrisy and injustices he witnesses. Nevertheless, he tries to follow the teachings of the Church and prepares himself for his first communion. His recollection of the nun who taught catechism centers on her obsession with "sins of the flesh": "The nun liked for us to talk about the sins of the flesh. The real truth was that we practiced a lot telling our sins, but the real truth was that I didn't understand a lot of things."[13] Although the protagonist is not sure exactly what "sins of the flesh" are at this point, he does make the strong correlation between them as being sacrilegious and a one-way ticket to hell. As a result, he spends the night before his first communion preparing for confession

by contemplating the sins he has committed: "It must have been dawn by the time I finally satisfied my conscience. I had committed one hundred and fifty sins, but I was going to admit to two hundred" (115). The reader never learns exactly what the protagonist's sins are, but this is just one of many silences in the text that beg to be filled.

On his way to confession, the protagonist gains some understanding regarding what "sins of the flesh" are by accidentally witnessing a man and a woman engaging in sexual intercourse on the floor of the local cleaners. The image stalks him and serves as the impetus for him to imagine other adults engaging in the same act:

> When I saw my Dad and my Mother, I imagined them on the floor. I started seeing all of the grown-ups naked and their faces even looked distorted, and I could even hear them laughing and moaning, even though they weren't even laughing. Then I started imagining the priest and the nun on the floor. I couldn't hardly eat any of the sweet bread or drink the chocolate. As soon as I finished, I recall running out of the house. It felt like I couldn't breath [*sic*]. (116)

What I find compelling about this scene is that none of the sexual acts he witnesses or imagines are heteronormative. Despite the existence of heterosexual coupling, the acts themselves are queer: an extramarital affair, a priest and nun engaged in a sexual act, and couples having sex on the floor instead of on a bed—all these scenarios are critiques of heteronormative paradigms. Moreover, the young man's reaction can be read in multiple ways. He could be discomforted by his role as a voyeur and, thus, a participant in the act. When the protagonist sees the actual couple on the floor of the cleaners, he remarks, "I don't know why, but I couldn't move away from the window" (116). The protagonist may also be uneasy about imagining people he knows engaging in sexual intercourse, especially his parents and the priest with the nun. His reaction could also be interpreted as his being erotically stimulated instead of being repulsed by the images he was creating in his head, perhaps even imagining himself in one of the sexual positions. Later, he does claim, "I kept remembering the scene at the cleaners, and there, alone, I even liked recalling it" (117). Notice he does not indicate a particular erotic interest. He never comments on any aspect of the male *or* female body. One of many conclusions one might infer from these clues is that the protagonist is developing an interest in voyeurism, which has queer implications nonetheless.

Regardless, what is imperative is that we recognize that the protagonist does not have to be read in any particular manner. We have

absolutely no way of knowing how to classify his response to his sexual encounter or what shape his sexual development will take. There are few, if any, overt markings related to the protagonist's sexuality in the text, which renders his sexual identity or erotic interests ambiguous. The ambiguity that the lack of such markings presents can certainly contribute to a discussion on queer Chicano sexuality. In the same way that no two people truly read the same text because the reading of it depends on a myriad of factors concerning individual experiences and distinctive personal identities, no characters must be read in the same way. I believe this is one reason why many Chicano/Latino gay men can identify in some way with Rivera's protagonist. Claiming such protagonists as queer is not only legitimate but, more important, it is also a way to expand the breadth of our history and representation in cultural texts.

Consider the following: although the reader is privy to a year in the life of the young protagonist, there is never any indication that he is interested in a relationship, even a friendship, with anyone else, male or female. One of the principal themes of the novel is the protagonist's solitude, which provides a space for him to reflect on his life, his family, and his community. The protagonist bears witness to a number of injustices he sees in the daily lives of the people of his community. Through the short narratives—or vignettes—of people he knows, he receives a number of messages regarding relationships. Besides seeing couples engaged in extramarital affairs, the protagonist witnesses a number of relationships unfold throughout the year. With the exception of his parents, virtually all the other relationships between men and women that he witnesses are tinged by death, destruction, illnesses, or infidelities. A good example is the story of the young lovers Ramón and Juanita in the chapter titled "The Night the Lights Went Out." After dating for a year and exchanging rings, Ramón goes off to work in the fields for the summer, expecting to return and marry Juanita. However, while he is away, he hears rumors that she is seeing someone else. When he returns, he sees her dancing with another guy at a dance. After a heated exchange, Ramón storms out of the dance hall and commits suicide by throwing himself onto the transformer of a local power plant.

Similarly, there is the relationship between an older man named Figueroa and an Anglo seventeen-year-old girl. The story is very terse. Nevertheless, it is a good example of the nonheteronormative characters and relationships present in the novella. Besides being thrown in jail for pedophilia, he emerges from jail sick, with "a very strange disease" (141). The disease is unnamed, and although the book was

written in the pre-AIDS era, the description of the character and his illness resemble someone with HIV or some other sexually transmitted disease that is commonly associated with same-sex relationships between men in prison.

All these relationships and characters—from Doña Bone to Figueroa—serve as warnings to the protagonist against heterosexual coupling. The narrative presents them as unsuccessful relationships that are ultimately linked to illness, destruction, and death. The protagonist does not move in the direction of acting on any form of heterosexual desire. Instead, he ensconces himself in the tree, underneath the house, and in the cemetery, where he can be alone. His solitude is a rejection of a reality that surrounds him and functions as a means of escaping an existence. Much like Richard Rubio, the unnamed protagonist of *... y no se lo tragó la tierra* engages in a form of self-imposed exile to a place where he can be himself, in all his solitude and in all his queerness.

Forgiving the Sinner: Creating a Queer Religion Somewhere in the Middle

Without going into too much detail, I now turn to Rudolfo Anaya's *Bless Me, Ultima*. There are so many parallels between the three novels I am examining here that I believe it is now evident how several characters and situations lend themselves to particularly good and logical queer readings. Although *Bless Me, Ultima* focuses on the early stages of development in the life of a young preadolescent male, there remain several questions regarding the protagonist's maturation and the way that he responds to his indoctrination into adolescence—and, in turn, adulthood—that can contribute to a discourse on queer identities.

Like *Pocho* and *... y no se lo tragó la tierra*, the story is obviously told from the perspective of the narrator as an adult looking back at his childhood. As in the other two novels, we never learn what becomes of Antonio Márez as an adult; again, the reader is left to decide the fate of the protagonist. While his father wants him to become a vaquero and ride the llano freely, Antonio's mother wants him to be a priest. However, when Ultima—a *curandera* and admired community member—moves in with the family, she reveals to Antonio's mother that he will be a "man of learning." Now, his parents' wishes for him to become a vaquero or a priest would be nonheteronormative outcomes—both would subject him to a queer position because neither is associated with heterosexual coupling or heteronormativity. As the novel progresses and Ultima's influence on

Antonio strengthens, it appears her prognostication will come true: he will be a "man of learning." Although this is a vague outcome and can be interpreted in several ways because many of the young boy's experiences in the novel are life lessons and he takes them all to heart, he does have an aptitude for academics, as does Richard Rubio in *Pocho* and the unnamed protagonist of *... y no se lo tragó la tierra*. As a "man of learning" Antonio will most likely continue to leave his heart and mind open to alternative viewpoints as well as pursue educational endeavors, something that is not customary in his family and community. Although one cannot say with certainty what his future holds, the character's childhood experiences clearly shape his identity and the decisions he will make in the future. Therefore, it is important to examine the ways in which Antonio responds to certain situations that shape his identity.

As in *Pocho* and *... y no se lo tragó la tierra*, in *Bless Me, Ultima*, several identity constructs are portrayed as complete binaries: masculine/feminine, good/evil, and Catholicism/paganism. As is the case with the other two protagonists I examined above, Antonio Márez is always in the liminal space between two competing systems. He does not entirely identify with any particular element over another. Instead, he embodies some aspects of each social location:

> After Easter I went to confession every Saturday and on Sunday morning I took communion, but I was not satisfied. The God I so eagerly sought was not there, and the understanding I thought to gain was not there. The bad blood of spring filled us with strange yearnings and tumult, and the boys from Los Jaros split off from the boys from town and there were gang fights. Since I was not from across the tracks or from town, I was caught in the middle.[14]

As Gloria Anzaldúa suggests, besides the geographical implications of living life on the border, there are psychological matters that play a significant role in formulating a mestiza/o consciousness.[15] Antonio is clearly in this in-between space, physically and psychologically. He questions the teachings of the Catholic Church and is intrigued by the thought of worshipping alternative gods, like the golden carp. He learns not to judge others, even if they have different belief systems or if they engage in alternative lifestyles, like prostitution. He straddles dual systems that attempt to maintain him in certain social locations, never succumbing fully to one or the other. He also does not identify solely with his mother's side of the family or his father's, which is representative of a nonnormative gender position.

Throughout the novel there is a constant separation between his parents' last names and the characteristics associated with each. His mother's side of the family is Luna, and they are described as peaceful, good, and steady people while his father's side is Márez and they are described as nomads, warriors, and near savage. As his father explains to him just before Antonio is sent to work with his maternal uncles in the fields:

> We lived two different lives, your mother and I. I came from a people who held the wind as brother, because he is free, and the horse as companion, because his is the living, fleeting wind—and your mother, well, she came from men who hold the earth as brother, they are a steady, settled people. We have been at odds all of our lives, the wind and the earth. Perhaps it is time we gave up the old differences. (235)

The Luna side is clearly associated with femininity, while the Márez side is portrayed as masculine. After years of seeing these two sides of the family as opposing forces, Antonio's father appears to have come to terms with the fact that his son is a product of the two. But, for his part, Antonio does not identify with one or the other; he is both a Luna and a Márez, or, the direct correlative, neither a Luna nor a Márez. Throughout the novel, he and Ultima function as the mediators between these opposing realms. While sometimes getting caught in the line of fire, they both do what they can to relieve the tension persisting between both sides. For Antonio, this means trying to placate his parents, a task he eventually finds impossible to accomplish.

Although there are few clues as to Antonio's sexual development, the obvious rejection of patriarchal institutions, like the Catholic Church and its teachings, is a rejection of an imposed heteronormativity. Antonio views other aspects of a normative existence also with uncertainty. As he states, after spending the summer working with his uncles (Lunas): "I knew that the future was uncertain and I did not yet know if I could follow in their footsteps and till the earth forever, but I did know that if I chose that life that it would be good" (238). His uncertainties lead him to the conclusion that he cannot compartmentalize any of these experiences; instead, he must take them all into consideration to build a new religion of sorts: " 'Take the llano and the river valley, the moon and the sea, God and the golden carp—and make something new,' I said to myself. That is what Ultima meant by building strength from life. 'Papá,' I asked, 'can a new religion be made?' " (236).

Chances are Antonio will not follow in the footsteps of his parents. He will not be a Luna or a Márez. He will not be a devout Catholic and probably not a devout pagan either. Instead, Antonio develops a unique identity that reflects his entire life experiences and all the people who have influenced him throughout his childhood. If anything, the title of the book and the significant role Ultima plays in the life of the child hint that her influence on him will leave a lasting impression, into adulthood. What is interesting about this position with respect to queer identity development is that both Antonio and Ultima are basically the only two characters in the novel who do not adhere to traditional gender norms.

In his essay "Culture, Tradition, Family: Gender Roles in Rudolfo Anaya's *Bless Me, Ultima* (1972)," Montye P. Fuse contends that, with the exception of Ultima, the other women in the novel play minor and conventional roles. He claims that the women in the novel can be placed into one of three categories: "(1) those who are silent and/or inconsequential to Antonio's development … (2) those who are virginal and/or who emulate qualities of the Virgin Mary …(3) those who are evil and/or of ill-repute" (45).[16] He also insists that Ultima does not fit into any of these categories and is depicted as being "other-worldly" instead—"dynamic, empowered, and unconventional" (46). Ultima does not conform to normative gender roles and throughout her time with Antonio, she inevitably instills such traits in Antonio as well. In effect, Ultima and Antonio are the two characters who most act outside normative gender roles, especially when compared to the other characters in the novel—male and female—who possess stereotypical gender traits. This ambiguous gender position is queer; both characters assume mystical characteristics that place them outside the heteronormative realm. For Ultima, this position is largely constructed around her as a *curandera*; for Antonio, it is through his introduction to *curanderismo* and paganism that he digresses from traditional gender roles for men.

In the same way that Antonio tries to learn and accept the teachings of the Catholic Church but constantly discovers alternative viewpoints that challenge such teachings, as a child he unexpectedly plays the role of a priest on a number of occasions but tends to fail. He is witness to several deaths in his community—some violent. One of the first deaths in the novel is that of Lupito, a veteran suffering from psychological problems who commits an act of murder and is hunted down like an animal and killed by an angry mob of men that includes Antonio's father. Antonio happens to be near Lupito when the latter is shot and killed. Despite Lupito's plea for Antonio to bless him,

Antonio runs away and laments not being able to save Lupito or appropriately perform an act of contrition for him. In a later scene, once again Antonio finds a dying man at his feet. This time it is Narciso, a friend of the family who is on his way to the Márez household to warn them that an angry and armed Tenorio is threatening to kill Ultima for being a *bruja* and casting an evil spell on his sick daughter. Narciso is assaulted and shot by Tenorio en route. On this occasion, Antonio does perform an act of contrition for Narciso just before he dies, but not before affirming, "I am not a priest" (162). Finally, Antonio attempts to do the same for a childhood friend, Florence, who drowns, but the young protagonist realizes that his efforts are in vain because Florence does not believe in God. Every one of these acts as priest is shadowed by doubt and helplessness. Antonio constantly asserts that he is not a priest; he refuses to accept the role despite being placed in these precarious situations by happenstance.

Essentially, many of Antonio's friends and family members see priestly attributes in him. While questioning his faith and his fate, Antonio has the opportunity to play the role of a priest on other occasions that don't involve death. In one scene, his friends talk him into pretending to be their priest right before they go to confession and have their first communion. He is chosen because his friends claim he "knows more about religion and stuff like that than anyone" (200). They basically force him into the role by cloaking him with their jackets and sweaters. In order to practice before sitting next to an actual priest in a confessional booth, one of the kids—Horse—begins confessing to Antonio. He tells the "priest" (while the other kids are listening) that he made a hole in the wall of the girl's restroom at school and saw girls and a female teacher urinating. Antonio gives Horse a mild penance and then the next confessor, Bones, proudly reveals his sin, which involves watching two teenagers fornicating. While Antonio is not interested in punishing these "sinners," a competition ensues to see who committed the biggest or worst sin. Eventually, they interrogate Florence, who has a gripe with God; he exclaims, "It is God who has sinned against me!" (204). Florence blames God for the death of his parents, for his sisters' need to work as prostitutes, and for a combination of other negative things he has seen or experienced. The rest of the kids see Florence's anti-God stance as the ultimate sin and believe that he should receive a severe penance, but Antonio does not concur. Even after the mob cries for Florence to be stoned, beaten, and killed, Antonio attempts to exert

his authority and shouts, "There will be no punishment, there will be no penance! His sins are forgiven!" (204). Not happy that Antonio allowed Florence to get away with such remarks, the mob attacks and tortures Antonio. He is symbolically crucified for not behaving as they expect a priest to behave, and it is not too long after this scene that Florence drowns.

Evidently, Antonio hesitates to judge any of his friends or castigate them in any way for at least two reasons: (1) because he recognizes that he too is a sinner who can be both good and evil, and (2) because he is also questioning the role of the Catholic Church and the existence of God altogether. Although most see him as an innocent child, Antonio knows he is not. Besides witnessing several violent acts and deaths, he has contemplated worshipping other gods. These experiences lead him to question his innocence, as he does just before Narciso's death: "Had I already lost my innocence? How? I had seen Lupito murdered … I had seen Ultima's cure … I had seen the men come to hang her … I had seen the awful fight just now … I had seen and reveled in the beauty of the golden carp!" (156). Moreover, he has learned about what transpires in the local brothel—Rosie's—and later discovers that his brother, and quite possibly most of the men in his community (including his father), frequent it. As a bildungsroman, the novel portrays a loss of innocence as a central theme, which marks Antonio as a member of his family and his community by giving him human qualities. Nevertheless, his mystical qualities remain. As Antonio matures, he distances himself from traditional institutions, like the Church and his home. He adopts some of Ultima's traits: paganism and *curanderismo*.

Although there are numerous possibilities regarding what will become of Antonio, his refusal to adhere to the norms of the Church and other patriarchal institutions is essentially a rejection of heteronormativity. His character is clearly developed as an individual who is caught between competing worlds and social systems: good and evil, Catholicism and paganism, masculinity and femininity. But Antonio inhabits the liminal spaces in between these social locations. His identity is constructed around his being all and none of these things simultaneously. If anything, an identity he does assume is that of being a "man of learning," which means he will most likely continue to break family traditions by going to school, exploring other worlds, and, in essence, not following the roles to which men in his community are typically confined. In this way, he can also be considered queer.

CONCLUSION: QUEER (W)RITES OF PASSAGE

These bildungsromans present the lives and experiences of three male protagonists. All three are queer in the way they reject the social and sexual norms of the societies in which they reside. The plethora of ambiguities that exist with respect to each character's social location and future endeavors are replete with queer cultural signifiers. They are clearly not interested in replicating heteronormative paradigms. Instead, they are located outside a normative social and sexual sphere, which allows them to move between and within unique social systems without allowing their identities to be codified by heteronormativity. Although these texts do not openly portray gay or lesbian-identified characters, they contain a variety of characters with queer traits and can thus be included in a discourse on queer Chicano/Latino sexuality.

In his essay "Homosexuality and the Chicano Novel," Juan Bruce-Novoa examines the portrayal of homosexuality in early Chicano novels. He claims that the Chicano novel provided a safe space for engaging in a dialogue on homosexuality:

> What is heartening is that in the majority of cases, homosexuals and homosexual acts are not subjected to stereotypical prejudice. If the novel gives us an accurate reading of the Chicano community—a question in itself debatable—we can say that our community is less sexually repressive than we might expect. If nothing else, among Chicano novelists there are varying attitudes and a willingness to address the topic. This makes the Chicano novel a progressive space of dialogue, an appropriate space in and through which a more androgenous [*sic*] and humane Chicano identity may be forged.[17]

Bruce-Novoa insists that homosexuality in Chicano novels was far from being ignored during the 1960s and early 1970s, but that despite being a progressive space, homophobia may have regulated the visibility and portrayal of openly gay characters. Portraying out and proud gay Chicano characters during the time these three novels were published (1959–1972) was virtually nonexistent. Characters that were overtly gay marked were typically associated with negative attributes or removed from the barrio, like Joe Pete in *Pocho* or the unnamed protagonist in John Rechy's *City of Night*. According to Karl J. Reinhardt, gay representation in the Chicano novel during this era consisted of three types of characters: (1) incidental gay characters not pertinent to the plot who are presented derogatorily and who are virtually asexual, (2) gay characters somehow pertinent to the plot but who

commit unacceptable acts and suffer retribution, and (3) gay Chicano characters who do not participate in a Chicano space.[18] Consequently, the visibility of openly gay Chicano characters may have been limited by such stereotypical representations, whereas a dialogue on nonnormative sexuality may not have been subjected to the same restrictions. As Bruce-Novoa contends, the Chicano novel has historically allowed androgynous and complex Chicano characters to emerge and facilitate a dialogue on nonnormative sexuality. It is this dialogue that can narrow the gap that tends to be situated between "gay" and "straight" novels and "gay" and "straight" characters. The numerous references to nonnormative sexualities and nonnormative gender roles in these three novels facilitate a discourse on queer identities that needs to be included in a discussion on queer Chicano/Latino sexualities. These characters are not "straight"; instead, their identities are shaped by a multiplicity of queer acts in which they engage and queer traits that they possess.

4

La Movie Rara: Viewing Queer Chicana/o and Latina/o Identities

What happened to our children, María? What did we do wrong?
José Sánchez, father in *Mi familia* (played by Eduardo López Rojas)

Chicana/o cinema has its roots in several forms of oppression: economic, social, and political. As a cinema by, for, and about people who experience systematic oppression on a daily basis, it has remained in a marginal status since its inception. As Gary D. Keller suggests, financial neglect and exploitation have limited the number of Chicana/o films and the shape of the final product: "Indeed, as an oppressed cinema as well as a cinema about oppression, its limitations have been primarily of the sort—both in terms of the number of productions and the aspirations and results of the extant product—that are imposed by financial neglect or its malignant verso, financial exploitation" (13).[1] In order to produce films, Chicana/o filmmakers had to find ways to subvert the oppression that relegated them and their projects to the margins. According to Keller, this was partially accomplished during the civil rights movement thanks to the advocacy of Chicana/o college students and Hispanic organizations (46). He also suggests that as a result, "the film industry itself sought to increase the participation of Chicanos and other minorities in the craft of filmmaking" (46). In this manner, for the first time Chicanas/os were able to play a significant role in the development of Chicana/o-themed films. However, despite its ability to emerge as a viable art form in the 1960s, oppression has remained a principal theme of Chicana/o cinema because it remains a part of the everyday lives of Chicana/o people.

In his analysis of Chicana/o cinema, Charles Ramírez Berg suggests that the canon can be divided into three waves. He contends

that the first wave is defined by an overwhelming interest in creating documentaries that reflected the ideals of the Chicano movement: "The First Wave (roughly from 1969 to 1976, or from El Teatro Campesino's *Yo Soy Joaquín* to Luis Valdez's *El Corrido*) was the radical documentary era. The cinematic expression of a cultural nationalist movement, it was politically contestational and formally oppositional" (185).[2]

Films of the first wave of Chicana/o cinema were especially interested in documenting some of the oppression and injustices experienced by Chicanas/os in the United States, and they had a significant influence on the ensuing waves. Berg suggests that the second wave, while not as nationalist and separatist as the first, is still rebellious in nature:

> Second Wave Chicano cinema dates from 1977—the year of Esperanza Vasquez's *Agueda Martínez*, Jesús Salvador Treviño's *Raíces de Sangre*, and Robert M. Young's *¡Alambrista!*—and continues to the present day. Though the documentary impulse that spawned First Wave filmmaking remains in evidence, the politics of the Second Wave are rebellious, not separatist. Indignation still fuels the rhetoric, but the anger is channeled into more accessible forms. (186)

According to Berg, the second wave is marked by the appearance of narrative films. He claims that feature-length docudramas like *Raíces de Sangre* (1977) and *¡Alambrista!* (1977) served as transitional works that inspired such films (186). Early full-length narrative films of this stage include *Zoot Suit* (1981) and *The Ballad of Gregorio Cortez* (1982). According to David R. Maciel and Susan Racho, these films have common themes:

> Thematically, Chicano narrative films of the 1970s and later have shared certain trends. Historical revision of key events in the Chicana/o experience has predominated in feature films. Mexican/Latino immigration to the United States is a key issue. In narrative cinema another major source of inspiration for filmmakers has been the rich literary expression of recent Chicana/o writers. Family and traditions have been dominant elements in Chicano feature films. In addition, drama has clearly overshadowed all other cinematic genres.[3]

The use of narrative to create dramatic portrayals of the lives and traditions of Chicana/o families became a viable medium for continuing to express the oppression of the people while also serving as a medium for recording their family histories and traditions. In these

films, oppression and ethnicity are central to the plot and character development. This differs slightly from the third wave. For Berg, the difference between the two is that in the third wave, oppression and ethnicity are no longer primary themes or central to the characters' development. He suggests that the difference is not in whether or not oppression and ethnicity are a part of the narrative, rather, to what degree they influence the narrative:

> For the most part [the third wave] consists of genre films, made either within the Hollywood system or, if not, adhering closely to the Hollywood paradigm. As such, Third Wave films do not accentuate Chicano oppression or resistance; ethnicity in these films exists as one fact of several that shape characters' lives and stamp their personalities. (187)

The films I analyze in this chapter clearly belong to the second wave. At the center, they place characters whose lives and experiences are shaped by ethnicity and gender as well as patriarchy and other forms of oppression. Two of the films were written and directed by Gregory Nava, *My Family/Mi familia* (1995) and *Selena* (1997). The third film, *Real Women Have Curves*, was originally a play, written by Josefina López; it premiered in San Francisco in 1990. With her assistance, it was made into a motion picture in 2001 and was released in 2002. The three films were well received and enjoyed box office success. *Mi familia* cost $5.5 million to make and grossed $11 million at the box office; *Selena* cost $20 million to make and grossed $35 million; and *Real Women* cost $3 million and took in $6 million.[4] They have since become an integral part of Chicana/o and Latina/o popular culture.

In examining these films, I focus on the characters themselves: their identities and the oppression they experience that shapes their identities. At times, the source of oppression is clearly from the characters' relationship to the dominant Anglo culture, while at other times it is from her/his relationship to traditional Mexican culture. These characters respond to such oppression in their own way, often creating unique identities that do not conform to the norms of either culture. These identities are overwhelmingly made up of queer configurations.

According to Berg, in the history of Latina/o images in U.S. cinema, there are six basic stereotypes: "*el bandido*, the harlot, the male buffoon, the female clown, the Latin lover, and the dark lady" (66). Berg contends that these stereotypes have been a part of U.S.

cinema for more than a century: "Sometimes the stereotypes were combined, sometimes they were altered superficially, but their core defining—and demeaning—characteristics have remained consistent for more than a century and are still evident today" (66). Although such stereotypes have been persistent in mainstream U.S. cinema, Chicana/o filmmakers appear to be particularly concerned with representing characters that digress from them. As Berg acknowledges, there are exceptions to these stereotypes due in large part to the fact that Chicanas/os and Latinas/os started making their own films:

> But there have also been exceptions to this rule: studio-made films that went against the stereotyping grain, stars who managed to portray Latinos with integrity despite a filmmaking system heavily reliant on stereotyping, and, more recently, a growing number of Latino filmmakers who began consciously breaking with the stereotyping paradigm of classical Hollywood. (66)

In the films I have chosen for this analysis, the identity of the characters does not correspond to the stereotypes historically portrayed in U.S. cinema. Rather than being stereotypical, these characters' identities are extremely complex, often a result of the mestizaje of two or more cultures, and of their response to the oppression they experience from each culture. I contend that these unique and multifaceted identities are rich sites for mapping queer identities. The characters I examine do not conform to social, sexual, or gender norms of Anglo, Mexican, or Chicano/Latino culture.

Although some popular culture theorists suggest that popular culture is essentially queer because heteronormative texts do not appeal to heterosexuals, I do not believe this is the case for the majority of Chicana/o films. I do not deny that queer narratives are shaped by an economic imperative; however, Chicana/o films are not mainstream films per se. They may be considered of Chicana/o and Latina/o popular culture, but they are not considered U.S. popular culture films overall. Furthermore, as films from the second wave, these three films are overwhelmingly invested in documenting the actual lives and experiences of real people. Chicana/o and Latina/o films were conceived from a documentary tradition, where highlighting issues related to injustices, oppression, and cultural heritage—themes mainstream filmmakers were not addressing—was a priority. These narratives are driven primarily by oppression and Chicana/o and Latina/o identity. Certainly, there must be some entertainment and economic factors that shape the narratives and the production of the films

I examine; to make films, typically one must have the economic means and/or convince investors that a project is economically viable. However, I contend that even though these are dramatic narratives, they are primarily concerned with documenting real lives and the Chicana/o and Latina/o experience. Both Gregory Nava and Josefina López have mentioned that *Mi familia* and *Real Women*, respectively, are largely based on their own lives and their families; of course, *Selena* was filmed precisely to document Selena's life. This autobiographical element is important to consider because it brings us closer to understanding how Chicana/o and Latina/o identities are shaped by oppression in ways that are ultimately queer. Hence, Chicana/o and Latina/o cultural production that centers on the Chicana/o and Latina/o experience is also queer, not so much due to an economic imperative but to the intersection of unique gender, ethnic, sexual, and class roles that digress from heteronormativity and shape queer identities.

Once again, as Alexander Doty suggests, "Queer readings aren't 'alternative' readings, wishful or willful misreadings, or 'reading too much into things' readings. They result from the recognition and articulation of the complex range of queerness *that has been in popular culture texts and their audiences all along*."[5] My interest here is thus not to do queer readings of these films; this would imply that I am "reading into" them. Instead, I am interested in extrapolating the inherent queerness in them.

Often what is queer can be articulated or defined based on what it is not. For example, identifying something as not heteronormative is analogous to identifying it as queer. However, such a broad classification would make it difficult to highlight characteristics that may be considered more queer than others in any given context. Considering that the majority of these films take place in a barrio, an analysis of the way the characters' identities digress from class and race norms may not yield particularly interesting outcomes. As a result, I have chosen to focus on queer identities that are shaped by the refusal to adhere to social, gender, and sexual norms.

Mi Familia Rara: Why Paco Isn't Married

My Family/Mi familia, written and directed by Gregory Nava, is the story of a Mexican immigrant named José Sánchez (played by Jacob Vargas and Eduardo López Rojas)[6] who migrates to the United States and settles in Los Angeles. He marries a Mexican American woman named María (Jennifer López and Jenny Gago) who was born and

raised in California. They begin a family and eventually end up having six children: Paco (Anthony González, Michael González, Benito Martínez, and Edward James Olmos), Irene (Susana Campos, María Canals-Barrera, Cassandra Campos, and Lupe Ontiveros), Chucho (Esai Morales), Toni (Constance Marie), Memo (Greg Albert and Enrique Castillo), and Jimmy (Jonathan Hernández and Jimmy Smits), in order from oldest to youngest.

The story spans three generations of the Sánchez family. It is a story of hardship, celebrations, rituals, failures, and successes, based largely on Nava's own family.[7] The story is told through the eyes of Paco—a writer who witnesses the many tragedies that afflict the family as well as the discrimination and oppression of Mexican and Chicano people in his community.

As José and María begin their family, they try to instill the traditional Mexican family values that they both have inherited from their parents: deep-seated Catholicism and all the sacraments and beliefs associated with the Catholic Church, a solid work ethic, and the importance of having a united traditional family. However, as the children get older, the parents find themselves losing the battle against acculturation. Their children adopt behaviors and values counter to both the traditional Mexican ones that José and María espouse and the norms of the dominant Anglo culture.

It is important to point out that the battle between the social systems of the older and younger generations is not a new theme; especially trenchant has been the battle between immigrants who have been raised in their homelands and their offspring who are being raised, for the most part, in an entirely different country. Inevitably, the parents find it virtually impossible to instill their personal values in their children. This type of conflict has been a common theme in Chicano literature. For example, early Chicano texts like *Pocho* (1959) and *... y no se lo tragó la tierra* (1971) clearly depict the dilemma that arises when generations find themselves in this situation. More recently, films like *Selena* and *Real Women Have Curves* follow a similar narrative.

In *Mi familia*, the observer witnesses the transition of the Sánchez children from childhood to adulthood as well as the common conflicts that arise between parental figures and their offspring. Although this is a universal theme, here I am interested in exploring how the children in this family develop identities that not only digress from the cultural norms of their parents but also defy heteronormative codes of social and sexual behavior as associated with Mexican, Chicano, and Anglo cultures, and are thus queer.

The first character to set the stage for a compendium of queer cultural readings in the film is actually not one of the Sánchez children but El Californio (played by León Singer), an elderly man who was born and raised in California, and who has built a modest home in the East Los Angeles area. When José arrives in the United States, El Californio invites him to stay in his home and allows him to begin a family there. It is not clear how José and El Californio are related but they have distant relatives in common. El Californio becomes a father figure to José and his family. The queerest thing about El Californio is that there is absolutely no mention of his ever having been with a woman or having a family of his own. Here we have an elderly man who more than likely has never had any children. Although there are no clear indications of his sexual orientation, there are many clues that he is not heteronormative. Not only does he not satisfy the obligatory role for men to procreate, but he also defies Church- and state-sanctioned codes of conduct, which are largely based on patriarchal heteronormative paradigms. Early in the narrative, when he dies, the narrator tells us that in his will El Californio bequeathed his home to José and his family, and he gives clear instructions regarding what he wants them to do with his defunct body: to bury it in the cornfield in the backyard of the house. According to the narrator, "He didn't want nothing to do with the pinche Church or the pinche government." José feels obligated to carry out El Californio's wishes even though they go against his moral and religious convictions, just the first of a long line of moral and ethical compromises that he will have to make throughout his life in the United States.

El Californio's rejection of anything having to do with both the Church and the state is, in essence, a rejection of heteronormativity. By having his body buried in his own backyard without any religious rituals, El Californio is able to defy the two institutions that function as the primary arbiters of heteronormativity within both Mexican and U.S. culture. The silences with regard to his sexuality allow the observer to draw conclusions about his sexual identity. If El Californio has not had a wife or any children (although it is never made clear that he never married or had children, the fact that that there is no indication of anyone else in his life, and that he bequeathed all his possessions to José, would make this a reasonable conclusion), the inquisitive observer may ask why. Naturally, there can be any number of explanations. However, these silences are precisely the ones that Doty claims allow us to draw conclusions with respect to a character's sexual identity. I claim that El Californio's rejection of anything having to do with the Church and state and his lack of heterosexual

indicators make him a quintessential queer character. This is not to say that El Californio has a homosexual identity, although concluding such a thing is certainly not illogical. Instead, it suffices to say that he does not engage in heteronormative practices and, therefore, he is queer.

El Californio is also instrumental in the rearing of José's children, who, as one might expect, adopt some of the same beliefs and behavior. In many ways, Paco, the narrator, follows in El Californio's footsteps. Even though the story spans almost half a century, Paco never marries. Instead, he joins the navy and, when he finishes his duty, he attempts to start a writing career while working odd jobs. There is absolutely no indication that Paco ever has a girlfriend or any type of sexual relationship with a woman at any time in the span of his chronicled life. Here we have the eldest son who never marries and never obtains a steady job—two of the most important rites his father wants for all his children to undergo, because he sees them as necessary for the creation of a family.

Paco, like El Californio, is ultimately queer, not only because he does not follow in the footsteps of his parents but, more important, because there are no heterosexual markings on this character at all. Instead, his identity is formed by a series of queer traits: no indication of sexual intercourse with a woman whatsoever throughout his life, a stint in the navy (a homosocial space), and a nonnormative chosen profession. It appears that Paco is avoiding all the customary rituals one would expect from a man in society: to get a good job, get married, and raise a family. His life does not head in any of these directions. Paco can logically be read as a gay character but, as was the case with El Californio, it suffices to say that his identity is a queer one. As Doty suggests, reading characters that lack heterosexual markings as heterosexuals tends to occur because the observer falls into a "heterocentric trap" (*Flaming*, 2). Characters, such as El Californio and Paco, that are not overtly coded as heteronormative are precisely those that permit queer mappings.

The fact that Paco is the narrator of the saga is an underlying factor in the proposition that the film itself is overwhelmingly queer. Since the story is told from his point of view, one might suspect that he holds a bias for those events in the history of the family that also challenged the social and sexual norms his parents represent. This would explain the obvious preference in the narrative for those characters who defy heteronormative codes. Moreover, these characters are often lauded for their rejection of traditional family values, whereas the parental figures are constantly challenged and asked to rethink their

values in order to maintain cordial familial relations. Ultimately, everyone engages in some form of negotiation, either with another family member or with their own personal belief system, which allows them to participate in the family structure is some way. Nevertheless, the overall family structure undergoes a series of reconfigurations that do not correspond to patriarchal heteronormative paradigms.

After the death of El Californio the movie jumps ahead twenty-five years to 1958, "más o menos." By this time, the observer has the opportunity to see the first four children as adults and two new children as adolescents. Proof that his parents have fulfilled their heterosexual duties, the narrator explains how "the house grew and grew with the family. Everything unplanned." This is when we learn that Paco joined the navy, Chucho had become a "pachuco,"[8] Toni had become extremely "bossy," and that Irene is ready to marry. All this information unfolds under the hustle and bustle of the family's preparation for Irene's wedding. Irene is the only child of the six who has a traditional marriage. She is the first and only member to somewhat reproduce their parents' understanding of the family structure that José and María have worked so dutifully to form. However, the other characters and their queer identities completely overshadow any semblance of heteronormativity one would expect a heterosexual wedding to produce. In fact, I argue that Irene and her husband, Gerardo, are solely marginal characters whose lives do not form an integral part of the narrative.

Instead, the film centers on three life histories: Chucho's, Toni's, and Jimmy's, each imbued with unique queer characteristics. Chucho and Toni function as the principal counterparts to the heteronormative implications of Irene's wedding. On the day of the wedding, the scene opens with Chucho ironing his pants in a pachuco fashion. While he is ironing, Toni harasses him for being a pachuco and for spending so much time on his pants. During this scene, the narrator tells the viewer that Toni became "the bossy type," unlike "normal" women (i.e., submissive). The masculinization of her name (her full name is Antonia) along with this defining characteristic suggests she is not like other women.

Chucho as a pachuco and Toni as a "bossy," assertive woman are the two queer identities that are intentionally simultaneously constructed as a means of undermining the traditional wedding José and María have worked so hard to put together. José has gotten himself into significant debt to make this wedding special, and it does turn out to be one of their happiest days. When it is time for José to give a speech, as is tradition, he stumbles over his words but manages to

express his sentiments. In his speech, he addresses his new son-in-law and all the other guests present: "A good wife is the best thing that can happen to a man in his life." Later, he adds, "The greatest tradition a man can have in his life: familia, mi familia." José proceeds to call all his children forward, showcasing his large family for the guests, extolling his own ability to procreate and pass along family traditions. However, during the wedding, two important things happen that overshadow a day that was intended to mark the beginning of the replication of the family: Toni's decision to become a nun and the arrival of Butch Mejía (played by Michael de Lorenzo), Chucho's enemy and leader of a rival gang.

When the time comes for Irene to throw the bridal bouquet, it falls unexpectedly into Toni's hands. She was apparently not even among the other women who were eager to catch the bouquet, long accepted as a sign that they will be the next to marry and carry on the institution of marriage and, subsequently, the family. When Toni realizes that the bouquet has fallen into her hands and becomes aware of the implications that it has, she shakes her head and throws it back to Irene, yelling, "Throw it again Irene!" She then runs away in tears. Her mother follows her to see what is wrong and Toni confesses to her, "I'm never going to get married." After a short pause she adds, "I'm going to be a nun." Naturally, María is elated when she hears this news. Overjoyed, she tells José as he approaches them, "Our daughter is going to marry our Lord Jesus." The word spreads like fire and her many suitors are completely disappointed. One remarks, "A nun? Ah man. What a waste." The narrator then comments, "We all thought it was a little strange that Toni wanted to become a nun. Then again, she was always the bossy type and that's the type that becomes a nun." Thus, not only does Toni decide not to marry or follow in the footsteps of her older sister, but she also decides to reject the entire institution of traditional marriage by ensconcing herself in the Church and protecting her body from the many suitors who, following the dictate of their male privilege, compete for its ownership. The use of the adjective *bossy* is particularly interesting. The film and the narrator highlight this as her defining characteristic. Obviously, a "bossy" woman exerts, or at least attempts to exert, her dominion over others. The narrator's comment that these are precisely the type of women who become nuns, suggests that women who are "bossy" are not suitable for marrying a man because within the family structure, the man must assume the active role. Marrying a "bossy" woman means a man would be reduced to a submissive role, at least on occasion. Instead, as the narrator suggests, these "uncontrollable" women

types become nuns, and become trained to serve the ultimate patriarchal authority, the Church and the male authoritative figures associated with it: God, Jesus Christ, priests, and others. Not surprisingly, upon first hearing the news about Toni's intention to become a nun, her parents are ecstatic. With six children, they can certainly afford to lose one to the Church. María, like many Mexican women of her generation, has a deeply abiding faith in the Catholic Church, particularly in la Virgen.

In an interview, Gregory Nava revealed that Toni's character was based on someone he knew who was a former nun and who had married a former priest. After hearing from other women who did the same thing, he came to the conclusion that this type of scenario was "more of a common thing than I realized" (West, 27). He added that during the 1950s, "the only alternative [for women] to getting married and having kids and being a mother, which [Toni] didn't want to do, was going into a religious order" (West, 27). He compared Toni's situation with that of the iconic Sor Juana Inés de la Cruz. For Toni, joining the religious order is the only way she can leave the barrio, educate herself, and see the world. This decision dismisses her from the obligatory role she would otherwise have to assume as a woman residing in the barrio. Consequently, her identity is shaped by nonnormative traits.

The second important event that takes place during Irene's wedding centers on Chucho. His gang rivals arrive in the parking lot and challenge him and his homeboys to a fight. Chucho, the leader of his gang, and Butch Mejía, the leader of the rival gang, engage in a verbal exchange that has sexual and homoerotic overtones. Mejía verbally challenges Chucho. In an effort to avoid ruining his sister's wedding, he refuses to accept the challenge. Instead, he gives Mejía a verbal threat that functions as an act of verbal rape: "I'll find you, I'll cut your dick off and shove it down your throat." Mejía pulls out a pocketknife, an obvious phallic symbol, and threatens Chucho, but Chucho walks away and avoids the confrontation in order to maintain the celebratory nature of the wedding.

Chucho and Mejía have a relationship that borders on the homoerotic. There exists a form of desire between the two that manifests itself in unique ways. As Carl Gutiérrez-Jones contends, institutional settings, like gangs, are spaces where members attack one another to "codify their relationship among themselves, even their desire for each other."[9] Moreover, the narrator sheds some light on the nature of this relationship when he describes the feelings the two gang leaders have for each other: "They were so full of hate and anger and

nowhere to put it except in each other." During this first encounter the two men do engage in the verbal rape of each other, and in their second encounter, a few days after the wedding, they go a step further and engage in a fight that concludes in a tragic ending to both characters.

After the wedding, the film centers on Chucho's story or, I should say, the relationship between Chucho and Mejía. We learn that Chucho has started selling marijuana and has become a full-fledged pachuco, getting into trouble with the police and defying his father. Late one night, he arrives home after his father had received a call from the local police suggesting his son was selling marijuana. José questions his son's whereabouts and wants to know the source of his money. In an attempt to impose his values on his son, José tells him, "I didn't raise my children to be sinvergüenzas." For José, the most important attributes that define a man are dignity, work, and respect, but Chucho rejects his father's traditional values and tells him: "Fuck la dignidad. This is all they respect in this country," as he waves a fist full of money in front of him. Chucho rejects everything for which his father stands: José likes mariachi music, Chucho hates it and prefers mambo; José does manual labor all day long and earns a modest income, Chucho sells drugs and makes plenty of money.

Chucho also tries to indoctrinate the children in the neighborhood into his alternative lifestyle. One afternoon, when Chucho is out washing his shiny red car, he is playing mambo music. Many of the children in the neighborhood are present, and he begins teaching them how to dance the mambo. The children begin following Chucho around the car as they dance and repeat after him, "Mambo! Mambo!" In an effort to protect her son from Chucho and all he represents, one woman (played by Bel Hernández) runs out of the house, grabs her son Eddie (Romeo René Fabian), and drags him inside the house. The use of mambo as a symbol of an alternative lifestyle is another form of queering the barrio. Traditional Mexican music is not Chucho's preference; instead, he chooses a form of music that digresses from the cultural norms of the barrio. Eddie's mother is well aware of the implications that learning such music and form of dance can have on her son's upbringing.

Shortly after this scene, Chucho and Mejía meet once more. This time, Chucho and a girlfriend are at a dance, making out on the dance floor during a slow song, when Mejía and his girlfriend enter the ballroom. From across the crowded room, Mejía immediately spots Chucho and, like a jealous lover, he grabs his girlfriend by the arm and moves to a spot right next to Chucho. The music changes

from a slow song to a fast swing and both couples begin dancing while acknowledging each other's presence, gazing at one another like lovers under the pretext that they despise one another. Although Chucho tries to avoid Mejía, the latter starts to intentionally bump up against him, in an effort to grab his attention and find an excuse to touch him. Finally, Chucho stops dancing with his girlfriend and the two men begin a physical confrontation. The music stops and the crowd gathers around them to watch the fight. Mejía pulls out a pocketknife and cuts Chucho a couple of times. Chucho's girlfriend throws him a pocketknife and he manages to cut his opponent. They lacerate one another and shed blood in what could be described as a mutual and reciprocal violent rape scene, where the pocketknives function as phallic objects that penetrate the victim's bodies. During this entire exchange, Mejía is the principal instigator. Chucho does not truly want to fight, but Mejía continues to attack him, lunging his body at him so that he ends up in Chucho's arms practically every time. Finally, Mejía charges Chucho, who pretty much accidentally sticks his knife into his enemy's stomach. Mejía falls to the ground and Chucho, leaning over him, watches him die in disbelief (figure 4.1). The audience runs out of the ballroom while the two men remain on the dance floor in a scene that is truly reminiscent of a tragic lost love with numerous Romeo and Juliet overtones. Chucho and Mejía look into each other's eyes as the latter reaches out to the former; both appear completely paralyzed



Figure 4.1 Esai Morales as Chucho (top) and Michael de Lorenzo as Butch Mejía in *Mi familia* (1995)

by the tragedy. This moment lasts for only a few seconds, seemingly longer, thanks to the intense gaze and the silence. Chucho appears to be in disbelief not only about the fact that he has just killed someone but that this someone is Mejía, his longtime rival, the person who purportedly most hates him. The history of their relationship and the nature of the events described allow for an alternative reading of this scene. Mejía's death could certainly be considered a form of suicide. He charges Chucho knowing the latter has a knife pointed at him. Chucho's silence and disbelief resemble the feelings of losing a loved one and not wanting to leave his side. In fact, Chucho does not move from Mejía's side until his girlfriend runs back inside and drags him away minutes before the police arrive. Mejía's death/suicide leads to Chucho's death.

Chucho's relationship with Butch Mejía is queer. In the two confrontations that I examine above, it is evident that their relationship is a manifestation of their mutual homoerotic desire. The manner in which Mejía not only seeks out Chucho in both confrontations but also hungers for any type of physical contact with him, attests to this desire. Chucho's identity as a pachuco and his relationship to Mejía clearly make him a queer character, one that goes against heteronormative codes. In the film, Chucho does suffer severe repercussions for digressing from these norms. Not only does he become alienated from his family, but he also kills his main rival/lover and he himself is hunted and shot by the police.

After this scene, the film jumps forward another twenty years, more or less to the early 1980s. This next segment centers on the lives of María and José's two other children, Jimmy and Toni. The scene opens with Jimmy's release from prison for armed robbery. Jimmy has followed in Chucho's footsteps, living the life of a "cholo."[10] For all intents and purposes, he is a prodigy of his deceased older brother. Jimmy's cholo identity functions in parallel with Chucho's pachuco identity. The only difference is the generational gap and the era in which they develop their corresponding counterculture identities. The fact that he has just finished a five-year stint in prison means that he and his body have been subjected to a submissive role in the sense that it has been controlled by the state.

When Jimmy arrives home, he encounters the same confrontations with his father as Chucho had some years before. José invites Jimmy to go work with him in the cornfield, but Jimmy refuses. By this time, it is apparent that José has given up on trying to impose his values on his children. Unlike the battles he engaged in with Chucho, José accepts Jimmy's rejection and humbly leaves him alone. The entire

family sort of tiptoes around Jimmy and allows him to be however he wants to be, partly because they know how close he was to Chucho and that he was the only one in the family who actually saw him get killed. The plot suggests that Jimmy's behavior is the result of the trauma he suffered from witnessing the death of his older brother.

As Jimmy's story unfolds, Toni comes back into the picture. Both of these characters return home around the same time. Toni knocks on the door unexpectedly, dressed in civilian clothes, and announces to her dumbfounded parents that she has left her order. Upon hearing the announcement, Jimmy comments, "That makes two of us that are out of the pen," a comment that reminds us that the two were in homosocial environments key to the development of queer identities.

Toni further shocks her parents when she tells them that she has in fact married a priest (played by Scott Bakula), who has also left the Church. María faints as an expression of her disapproval. At this moment, the camera cuts to Toni's thoughts, and we witness the sexual encounter between Toni and her new husband, both completely naked, lying on the ground of a forest that resembles traditional depictions of the Garden of Eden. The sexual act between nun and priest is only one queer aspect of the relationship between these two characters. One would think that Toni's marriage to an actual man instead of to the "Lord Jesus" would be the first step to her integration into a normative lifestyle. An interesting nuance in this segment is that, for the first time, we hear Toni's full name, Antonia, which could be read as an attempt to "feminize" her or make her a "normal" woman now that she is married to an actual man. However, I would argue that her character remains as queer as it was before. She and her new husband become radical leftists and spend the rest of their lives fighting for immigrant rights. They never have any children and, hence, never conform to a heteronormative lifestyle. Therefore, Toni/Antonia remains a queer character throughout the film, never succumbing to the roles designated for women in either Chicano or Anglo culture. In fact, her "bossy" nature remains intact and becomes essential in her line of work.

Perhaps the most eloquent moment of the entire film occurs the night José and María get the news from Toni. Unable to sleep, María reaches over, awakens José, and says: "José. Our children, José. Antonia married to a priest. Are you up? Antonia and a priest. How can this be possible? And Jimmy, when I think of Jimmy. Mi querido Jimmy and how beautiful he was." José interrupts and asks, "What happened to our children, María? What did we do wrong?" She begins to cry and

responds, "I don't know. Y Paco, still unmarried, wants to be a writer." "A writer," José adds, "who's going to pay him to do that?"

The two are finally able to get to sleep while thinking of their son, Memo, who is still in law school; he is their last hope that one of their children will have a successful, respectable career, and maybe even marry a woman and have children. They don't mention Irene and her family at all, confirming their role as merely marginal characters.

Toni's work with refugees puts her in a situation where she feels obligated to save a Salvadoran immigrant named Isabel (Elipidia Carillo) from being deported. She manages to convince her brother Jimmy to do her a favor and marry the woman in order to save her. Try as he may to reject the institution of marriage, Jimmy cannot resist his "bossy" sister. Isabel is not even told about their plans but, once married, she accepts the fact that they are spouses and she tries to play the role of a housewife, which, in her mind, entails cooking, cleaning, and, ultimately, bearing children for her husband. Jimmy rejects her on the basis that they are just "technically married." However, Isabel remains steadfast; she hunts him and finds her way into his home even when he does not want her around.

When José and María find out about the marriage arrangement, they accuse Toni's "porquería" politics of tampering with the institution of marriage. But haven't their children been doing this all along? They try to convince their children that "there are certain things in life that are sacred, sagradas." Nevertheless, they are unable to convince their children of the sanctity of marriage, just as they are unable to replicate a nuclear family.

Jimmy tries to continue his life as a loner and cholo; however, one day, Isabel removes his oldies cassette from the radio while he is washing his car and she inserts her merengue music. She tries to get Jimmy to dance, but he refuses, revealing his ignorance of how to dance with a woman. Jimmy only knows the streets, his homeboys, and the prison. In other words, he knows how to interact socially with other men. Initially, he refuses Isabel's advances to dance, but after much hesitation, he gives in and starts trying as his homeboys and neighbors watch and make fun of him. In what appears to be his first time dancing with a woman, and after much resistance and a bit of practice, he begins following the music. With bodies moving and hips gyrating, she manages to get him sexually aroused. It is important to note that she is the aggressor in this scene; she seduces Jimmy, who acts as the passive partner. When they kiss, she asks, "Entonces ¿qué? ¿Eres mi hombre?" Before Jimmy can answer, she jumps on top of him as he is standing and spreads her legs around him, simulating a

sexual position. From there, they go into his apartment and make love. After they make love, she ogles and caresses the scars and tattoos that Jimmy has all over his body, gifts from his "carnales" in prison, he tells her. This remark is an indication that his enemies and his homeboys are the ones who possessed and penetrated his body before Isabel entered the picture.

Isabel becomes pregnant, and she nearly manages to legitimize Jimmy's manhood by making him play the role of husband and father. For the first time in his life, he gets a job and begins adapting to a legitimate male role in society: working hard and caring for his pregnant spouse. It might appear that this is Jimmy's induction into a life of compulsory heterosexuality, but, remaining true to the queerness of the film, his life takes a not-so-unexpected turn. Isabel ends up dying immediately after giving birth to their first son, and Jimmy, in a fit of anger, retreats to his homeboy lifestyle, commits a robbery, and intentionally gets himself thrown back in jail—back to the violent and homosocial environment with which he is much more familiar and comfortable.

María and José end up raising Carlitos (Paul Robert Langdon), Jimmy's orphaned son, who is designated as a real "travieso," like his father. When Jimmy gets out of prison the second time, he tries to become a father to Carlitos, but the child rejects him for having left him alone and for rejecting his role as a father. By the end of the movie, the two do reconcile their differences, but it is still unclear whether Jimmy will ever be a successful father.

On the other hand, the family's last hope, Memo, finishes law school and becomes a lawyer, to the satisfaction of his parents. One day, he brings his Anglo fiancée and her upper-class parents to meet his family, but the meeting turns out to be a disaster because Memo is completely embarrassed by his family and is caught in a pool of lies. Memo has now transcended the working-class status of his family, symbolized by his profession, his tailored suit, and his shiny new Mercedes. His family discovers that he has changed his name from Memo to Bill in what they view as an effort to anglicize his identity—a symbol of the rejection of his culture and his family. From the look of disbelief that his fiancée and his future in-laws display as they are introduced to his family and its many eccentricities, it appears the wedding will likely be cancelled and Memo will probably follow in the footsteps of his brothers and sisters in their inability to reproduce the traditional family structure.

Thus, the film ends with the grown men of the family failing as fathers and/or husbands. Only one of the four brothers, Jimmy, gets

married, and not through his own free will. The death of his spouse confirms that he never actually fulfills his obligatory role as a male in this society: to be a husband and a father. The narrator confirms how the children in this family are unable to fulfill their parents' expectations. After commenting on the mishaps of the family and his parents' disappointments and frustrations, Paco confesses, "Memo and I were worthless," implying that they were of no use to their parents because they were unable to procreate and produce a heteronormative family. But the women in the film, as mothers and wives, also fail. Toni never has children and continues to be a "bossy" woman; Irene does get married and has children, but she is merely a marginal character.[11]

The saga of this family is based on José and María's struggle to impose compulsory heterosexuality based on Mexican family values on their children, who are being raised in the United States. As I have shown, these characters completely fail to reproduce a heteronormative family. Instead, they reject traditional rites and family values (i.e., marriage through the Church, respectable employment, and child rearing) and develop queer identities that leave José and María shaking their heads and asking themselves, "What happened to our children?"

In the final scene, when María and José are alone, they contemplate their lives and their family. José tells María, "María, we have had a good life." Initially, she does not agree. She responds, "It would have been even better if . . . ," but she is interrupted by José. We don't get to hear what she would have liked to have happened. The viewer is free to complete the hypothetical statement: if Memo had gotten married, if Toni had had children, if Paco had gotten married, if Isabel had not died, or any other combination of heteronormative outcomes. Instead, José insists, "No, María, don't say it." He continues to suggest that they have had a good life until María finally repeats his words, "We've had a good life." José and María remain in their home alone, trying to convince themselves they have led a good life and that they have done a good job rearing their children. Whether they are authentically happy with their lives, their family, and their roles as parents, or merely trying to convince each other that they are, is left to the observer to decide. Clearly, however, the configuration of the family itself has been drastically altered. Throughout the narrative, notions of family and family values have been constantly challenged, negotiated, and reconfigured. Virtually all characters experience these three processes and manage to somehow participate in the family and maintain some sort of familial bond. As I have demonstrated, some family members do this more successfully than others. Nevertheless,

an alternative family structure takes shape, one that does not comply with the parental figures' original plans for each of their children. The fact that virtually every child possess a compendium of queer markings makes *Mi familia* a quintessential queer text. Although the theme of children defying their parents' wishes and going against their traditional family values is a common one, I have shown that the characters in this film, especially the second generation, defy heteronormative gender, social, and sexual norms. Instead, they construct multifaceted queer identities that ultimately lead to the creation of *una familia rara*.

Creating Selena y los Dinos: Queer Mestiza/o Identities

Another popular film that was written and directed by Gregory Nava is *Selena*. The film is basically a biography of the famed Tejana singer who was killed at the age of twenty-three when the president of her fan club, who had been accused of laundering money, shot her. The movie was filmed and released in record time with the cooperation of Selena's family, building off the Selena (1971–1995) frenzy that ensued after her death.[12] The final product is an acclaimed film that pays tribute to the Tejana musical icon while narrating her life from early childhood to her tragic death. The film was intended to reach the mainstream theatergoing public but, as David Maciel and Susan Racho contend, its major success came from the way it was received in the Chicana/o-Latina/o community: "Skillfully choreographed and acted by the two leading actors, *Selena* had a respectable showing at the box office in the United States and abroad. Overwhelming support for the film, however, has come from the Chicano/Latino community. As much as it attempted to be a crossover film, it did not achieve this end to the degree hoped" (120).

Selena is one of only a handful of films where a Chicana/Latina is the leading protagonist. According to Carlos E. Cortés, while Anglo women in U.S. films from 1930 to 1935 were portraying women who could intellectually and even physically compete with men, Latina women were confined to the Mexican spitfire image, based largely on sensuality and superficiality. From 1945 to 1970, he adds, Chicana women became stronger characters, but "most of these strong Chicana characters were prostitutes, kept women, or at least ladies of questionable (for that era) virtue" (101).[13] It is not until after the 1970s that there was a change in the stereotypical images of Chicanas and Latinas. In Chicano films, Chicana and Latina images generally fell

into one of two new roles: that of a gang member or that of what Cortés deems "the Latina as conscience to the central Anglo character" (103). Cortés claims that Chicana and Latina characters in film were rarely fully developed, and in the latter of these two roles, they tended to "serve critical moral functions and create interethnic film linkages" (105). As a result, these women rarely played a central role and their identities were typically shaped by ethnic stereotypes.

Initially, Chicana/o and Latina/o films did little to challenge these stereotypes. Rosa Linda Fregoso, in her book *The Bronze Screen: Chicana and Chicano Film Culture*, does her own analysis of women's roles in Chicana/o and Latina/o films, where she highlights other ways women were reduced to stereotypical roles:

> Not that women have not played major parts in Chicano films, but usually they are portrayed in terms of timeworn stereotypes: as virgins or as whores in Valdez's films *Zoot Suit* and *La Bamba*; as sidekicks of the main characters (supportive wives) in Jesús Treviño's *Raíces de Sangre* and *Seguin* and in Isaac Artenstein's *Break of Dawn*; as translators (malinches) between cultures, as in Robert Young's *The Ballad of Gregorio Cortez*; as enigmas, as in Cheech Marin's tattoo of the "homegirl" in *Born in East L.A.* and so on.[14]

Clearly, the women in these films often lacked autonomy. Their identities were typically defined by men and their relationship to men. Nevertheless, the stereotypes were often considered to be positive representations of women, especially with respect to their dedication to the family and traditional values. Fregoso contends that there is no lack of positive images of Chicanas/Latinas in contemporary Chicana/o cinema. However, she does believe these images often lack female figures that are empowered:

> The demand, therefore, is not so much for "positive" images of Chicanas, because, except for a few films, Chicano filmmakers have not spent a great deal of energy objectifying, reifying, or demeaning their women characters even though in most cases Chicanas have been excluded from participating in the "discursive fellowships" of power that Michel Foucault speaks of. (95)

Selena digresses considerably from these stereotypes. The film places at the center a woman who does not fit the virgin, whore, suffering mother, or chola image. Instead, at the center lies a highly revered and assertive woman who develops a sexualized stage persona without compromising her virtuosity.

I am interested in showing how *Selena*, as a cultural text and in its depiction of Selena, functions as a queer text through its portrayal of the Tejana musical icon. It is important to note that I will focus on the text itself and not so much on Selena's life beyond what is represented in the film, because I am trying to show how queer identities are integral to Chicana/o and Latina/o cultural texts. However, considering *Selena* is a biography, the lines between text and reality will inevitably be crossed on occasion.

Particularly important to this analysis is the notion of transnational identities. Selena constantly transcended borders that were placed in front of her: linguistic, cultural, gender, ethnic, and economic. This representation of Selena has many queer implications, because crossing borders, both figuratively and literally, is an act that fosters queer subjectivities. The act of crossing borders places the subject in a liminal position that diverges from norms of both cultures and can therefore be construed, at least temporarily, as a queer subject position. For Gloria Anzaldúa, this is what mestiza consciousness is all about, straddling more than one culture and developing a tolerance for contradictions and ambiguities.[15]

The film opens with a shot of Selena (Jennifer López) singing to an enormous crowd at the Houston Astrodome. This concert introduces the observer to a woman unlike any other. She wears a tight-fitting purple and sequined outfit that she designed with flared bottoms and a short jacket of the same design. As José E. Limón remarks, the outfit accentuates her body, creating a "voluptuous" image of a distinctly "morena" woman with wide hips.[16] This image is quite different from the typical Anglo musical icons of the era, who are more apt to be thin and virtually hipless; it is also quite different from idealized notions of beauty promoted in Anglo culture, where fair skin and thin bodies occupy a privileged space. This outfit is just the beginning of a string of cross-cultural cues that form Selena's queer identity. As she begins singing to the mostly Mexican crowd, ironically, she slides into an English medley composed of 1970s disco music. By this time, she had already recorded an English-language album of her own, *Dreaming of You* (1995). However, she chose not to begin the concert with one of her new songs or with a song in Spanish. As Deborah Parédez suggests, Selena's use of disco serves as a crossover tool to reify dominant notions of whiteness. Selena sings "I Will Survive" and "On the Radio," among other disco tunes, in English while inserting an occasional "Todo el mundo" and her famous, "¡Eso!" The band also inserts its own twists that give the disco tunes a unique flavor. In this manner, Selena borrows from her

Anglo cultural roots (she was born and raised in the United States) while mixing in her Mexican cultural roots. She creates a medley that is ultimately queer. Parédez believes that disco is seen as nonthreatening and it allows Selena a space to negotiate her identity. She also finds the use of disco particularly interesting because of its association with an alternative sexuality, especially among the gay population.[17] As Richard Dyer contends, disco has been appropriated by gay culture as a means of dealing with oppression and legitimizing their existence:

> The anarchy of capitalism throws up commodities that an oppressed group can take up and use to cobble together its own culture. In this respect, disco is very much like another profoundly ambiguous aspect of male gay culture, camp. It is a "contrary" use of what the dominant culture provides, it is important in forming a gay identity, and it has subversive potential as well as reactionary implications.[18]

Disco can, in this way, function as a medium for marginalized people to legitimate their identity by subverting oppression. Selena's use of disco can also be seen as a way for her to test the water, so to speak. By bringing it into a performance where the public is expecting her to sing in Spanish, the nonthreatening nature of disco protects her from being rejected for singing in English. Selena uses disco so as not to be confined to Mexican culture and as a sort of buffer between the Mexican culture her fans represent and the Anglo culture (rooted in capitalism) the Astrodome represents. By doing so, she creates a safe environment that draws on both traditions.

Both Parédez and Limón have commented on the irony behind the use of the Astrodome—usually an Anglo-dominant space where football and baseball games, rock concerts, and rodeos are held. In fact, Selena's concert is a part of the annual Houston Livestock and Rodeo event, where one night is deemed Mexican Night. Selena thus performs in an Anglo-dominant space as a part of an Anglo-dominant event to a Mexican-dominant crowd and she sings disco tunes in English with a hint of Spanish, dressed in a sequined purple outfit that displays her eroticized body. Her dance moves are also unusual; she does her own rendition of the shuffle with a Latina twist, gyrating her hips and turning every now and then. As Limón observes, her dance moves also suggest that she is borrowing from various cultural traditions:

> Like many other performers today, Selena dances as she sings, but during instrumental breaks in the music—as dancer—she uniquely

> dominates the entire stage, in her case with a combination of provocative, marvelously executed Latin American *cumbia* and *merengue* steps with some other moves borrowed from varying forms of American rock and roll. (3)

The act of borrowing from different cultural traditions to create a unique mestizo identity is one that has queer implications. It is impossible to place Selena in any normative category because her identity is based on a contemporary form of mestizaje. Also, her gender and her sexuality reject heteronormative codes of Mexican, Chicano, and Anglo culture. As Parédez states, "She reinvented the male-dominated genre [of rancheras and cumbias] with performances that highlighted the racialized and sexualized Tejana body" (64).

The early part of the film reveals that Selena's primary language is English. She is enticed by her father as a young girl to begin singing in Spanish. Without mastering the language, she is still able to sing like a native Spanish speaker. In this manner, Selena begins her life of crossing borders by crossing linguistic and cultural ones. This is the first of a long line of queer signifiers prevalent in the formation of her queer mestiza identity. Selena is able to transgress the boundaries that exist between Spanish- and English-speaking singers, passing as a Spanish speaker via her ability to sing in the language. As a result, Selena and her songs are appropriated by the Spanish-speaking population in the United States and abroad.

Besides overcoming linguistic barriers, Selena enters the music industry through a musical form that at the time was completely male dominated: cumbias, rancheras, and banda. Not only does she successfully enter this genre of music, she actually queers it. She accomplishes this by defying gender norms of this musical tradition, where the majority of the bands are all males, and by establishing the first successful female-led group in this area. Furthermore, by adding her own unique sexualized style, she eroticizes the tradition through the clothing she wears and her form of dancing, which a number of women imitate later. As Limón suggests,

> Selena's unique expressive stance in her time consisted of her willingness to join together, with her superb voice and dancing, these different musical traditions in a way that no one had quite done before. But she also fully expressed her bodily sexuality as no other such singer-dancer had ever quite done before a mass public audience—an expression, as I have suggested, always done at great risk, the risk of the stigma of illicit, prostitutional sexuality from either cultural side. (13)

Limón takes this analysis a bit further. He proposes that her use of sexuality is a means of granting freedom to the women and men who have been historically repressed in Mexican culture: "Selena's public sexuality permits a much-needed site of discharge and expression for a still too repressed sexuality in this culture as true for women as for men—a transaction for sexual freedom" (14).

Indeed, Selena's sexuality played an integral role in the development of her identity as a musical superstar. She borrowed from Anglo culture, particularly figures like superstar Madonna, to establish herself in the Spanish musical industry. In a culture where the representation of women tends to fall into one of two categories, either virgin or whore, Selena benefited from a most unusual classification, one that I claim falls more along the lines of an eroticized virgin (figure 4.2). Despite displaying her body onstage in a highly sexualized manner, the publicity around her private life prevented her from being relegated to a whorelike status. Instead, images in the press of Selena's private life and in *Selena*, overwhelmingly center on her humbleness, her devotion to her family, her aspirations, and her charity. Limón calls this the "good girl narrative." He claims, "Her brazen sexuality on stage is bracketed by her well-noted activities offstage" (15).



Figure 4.2 Jennifer López as Selena in *Selena* (1997)

The "good girl narrative" begins early in the film. After the opening scene at the Astrodome, *Selena* focuses on the singer's early childhood. We learn about her family, especially the role her father, Abraham (Edward James Olmos), played in developing her singing talent. Her father's involvement in her life and in her career is one that remains strong throughout Selena's life. Abraham is portrayed as the caring, overprotective, traditional father, and Selena, although somewhat rebellious, is overwhelmingly devoted to her family. Abraham becomes her coach and her manager; he is instrumental in every part of Selena's life and career.

After the brief childhood narrative, the movie jumps forward to a concert Selena gave in a Mexican rodeo space in El Paso, Texas in 1989. After many years of performing as a child, this is the first scene, after the Astrodome shot, that we have of Selena as a young adult. During her performance of "Baila esta cumbia," Selena removes her jacket and dances around the stage in a black bustier. Abraham and Marcela (Constance Marie), Selena's mother, are working some of the technical aspects of the concert when Abraham looks up and sees his daughter dancing in what he deems a bra. He shouts to Marcela: "¿Qué está pasando? Marcela! Marcela! What is she wearing? She's practically got nothing on. She's in her bra." Marcela explains that it is not a bra but "just one of those things like all the girls are wearing." He responds, "She can't be wearing things like that, there are men out here." Abraham is completely flabbergasted by seeing his daughter prance around the stage in a bustier. His reaction attests to the heightened sense of sexuality that wearing such an outfit brings and the implications that it may have. The bustier/bra, besides highlighting and eroticizing Selena's body, is another site for mapping a queer identity. Her outfit places her outside the normative standards of dress for women in Mexican or Chicano culture, while also highlighting her femininity and sexuality in the male-dominated banda industry. Her innocence—as portrayed in the film—combined with the sexually charged outfit is more closely associated with an eroticized virgin image.

Later, on the bus, Abraham tells Selena, "You can't go out there wearing stuff like that, it's, it's indecent." This is when Selena explains that "all the singers are doing it. It's the style: Madonna, Janet Jackson, Paula Abdul." The fact that she borrows her style from these artists is rather interesting. Madonna, in particular, has been studied considerably as a popular culture icon. As Marianne Thesander suggests, "Madonna loves to shock and to appear sexually aggressive and challenging; at the same time, she makes fun of female underwear and

presents a parody of femininity, which helps to break new ground for a mode of female expression."[19] Certainly, Selena's use of the bustier can be seen as an attempt to do the same in another cultural context.

Later in the evening, Selena joins Abraham as he is driving the bus and asks him if he is still angry about the bustier. She tries to explain to him, "That's just the fashion right now. On stage. You know, entertainment. And we don't want to be old-fashioned, right?" Abraham responds, "No, we don't want to be old-fashioned. But …" Selena does not allow him to finish his statement. Instead, they both compromise and reach an agreement. Selena is allowed to use the bustier as long as she does not remove her jacket on stage. This is the first sign of Abraham losing his authority over Selena and the rest of the family. Prior to this point, he made all the decisions regarding when they were going to practice, where they were going to live, where they were going to play, and what the group was going to wear. He managed every single aspect of the group and Selena's performance.

Besides the display of her body and her sensual dancing, Selena's queer identity is shaped by her acquisition of power, a trait seldom associated with women, especially Mexican women and Chicanas/Latinas. I argue that the power Selena gains through marketing her talent and developing a celebrity status repositions her as a woman with the skills and resources to subvert patriarchy. In other words, Selena acquires power through her economic success, which places her in a position where she can challenge patriarchal institutions and authorities, especially her father. For instance, the compromise Abraham makes regarding her use of a bustier. If Abraham truly had full dominion over his family as he did prior to this incident, there would be absolutely no compromise and his word would have been the final one. Instead, Selena prevents him from even expressing his views completely on the subject and she is able to finagle a way to get him to accept her provocative outfits. Throughout the rest of the film, Selena's autonomy increases substantially as she continues to have success and make more money. This reaches a point where the entire economic structure of the family and the group, Selena y los Dinos, depends on her.

When the group decides to hire an electric guitar player, a rock and roll type named Chris López (Jon Seda) auditions for the band. He looks like a stereotypical rock and roller, with long, disheveled hair and armbands—a paragon of counterculture. Abraham is not impressed with Chris's style of music and he is even more critical of his appearance. He warns his son, Abie (Jacob Vargas)—who is trying to convince Abraham that this is exactly what the band needs—that "he could be

trouble. He's wild." The rock and roll image and the reference to Chris's being "wild" both function as signifiers of his queer identity; that is, his identity is constructed around characteristics that digress from normative Anglo and Chicano/Latino culture, especially with respect to men and masculinity. Chris is hired under the condition that he clean up his look. The women in the group cut his hair and comb it back in a nice, neat ponytail. They also remove his armbands and alter his clothing. As his image is polished, Chris is transformed from a wild rock and roll type to one of the band members.

On an occasion when Selena and Chris are alone on the bus, Selena asks him how he's doing with the group. She then compliments him on his hair saying, "Looks good," and then she asks, "How do you like it?" He responds, "I like it, if you like it," affirming her dominion over Chris as well as his acceptance of a submissive role, to which he remains confined for the rest of the film. Chris is also queer in the way he does not fulfill his obligatory role as a male.

Another element of queerness in *Selena* is the music itself. In the same way the group is composed of people from different genders that have various cultural and musical interests, the music itself becomes a hybrid form that detours from the normative codes of traditional cumbias. The hybridization of cultures is a leitmotif that plays itself out in various parts of the narrative. For example, the way the English-speaking Selena learns how to sing in Spanish, the comments Abraham makes about their cultural identity as both Mexican and American, and the U.S. celebrities that influence Selena's style. However, I argue that the hybridization of the music goes beyond the Anglo/Mexican dichotomy and functions more along the lines of a queer mestizo identity. Selena y los Dinos is made up of members of differing backgrounds with respect to body type, style, gender, and age, which places the band among the queerest of those producing cumbias and banda music. Here we have an English-speaking band that sings in Spanish, Suzette (Jackie Guerra)—the overweight sister—playing the drums, a sexualized woman leading the group, a father trying to maintain some of the traditional forms of music and style, a son adding his own younger, more hip style, a liberal mother who helps her daughter develop her onstage image, and, finally, a rock and roller who adds a little hard rock to the musical form. The hybridization of these various traits places the band and the music it produces in a category of its own. Certainly, since no category exists for bands of this nonnormative nature, they are placed into the same category as all the other groups that produce banda music, even though their music has a unique sound. In a scene where Selena and

Chris are alone once again after discovering that they have attained the number one spot on the music charts for their song "Como la flor," Selena exclaims to Chris, "No. 1! My God! Can you believe it? After all these years. And then all of a sudden, bang!" Chris responds, "That's how it is. I'm telling you. You just start from here and then, pow! Like a bullet. And Abie, Abie is really smart. You know, he really knows his cumbia rhythms. He adds a little funk and then a little disco. He puts it all together and then you sing the heck out of it." Selena responds, "And you add a little heavy metal to the guitar break." This interchange describes the hybridization of the music they produce: cumbia, mixed with a little "funk," disco, and rock produce a musical style that complements the visual image that Selena promotes onstage. Both are grounded on what I contend is a sexualized mestizo identity that I am calling queer.

Selena and Chris develop a romantic relationship, but he is not the type of guy Abraham or the rest of the family want Selena to date. When one of the band members discovers their romantic interlude, he has a discussion with Chris, telling him, "Abraham's not gonna like it. Selena getting serious with a guy right now? And a guy like you?" Chris responds, "What do you mean a guy like me?" He responds, "We're musicians." As musicians, they do not identify themselves as typical men with real jobs. For Chris, this is especially true because of his punk rocker identity.

Nevertheless, Selena and Chris fall in love. When Abraham sees what is happening between them, he attempts to put a stop to it. During a bus ride, while he is driving, he looks back and sees them playing and getting a little too close. He pulls the bus over, orders everyone out, and insists that the two put an end to their relationship. However, by now Selena has reached a new stage in her career; consequently, she is closer to attaining her full autonomy.[20] Evidence that Abraham's authority is diminishing, Selena and Chris do not accept his demands. Both lash out at Abraham. Chris rebuts, "Abraham, you can't tell us what to do." And Selena asserts, "I don't care what you say. I love him." Later she adds, "He loves me and there's no way I'm going to let you take that away from me." Abraham finds this absolutely absurd, and when they both profess that they want to get married, Abraham explodes and fires Chris. Chris leaves the bus and the two lovers are separated, at least temporarily. Abraham manages to exert his authority over the two by firing Chris and threatening to break up the band. As Selena's manager and father, he is still able to control the band even though he is slowly losing his authority over his children and the individual band members.

Nonetheless, Selena and Chris continue their relationship clandestinely. They are both willing to give up the band in order to be together. In one conversation between the two, she tells him, "I can do other things. I can design clothes. I've always wanted to do that." Quitting the band would mean giving up her dream of becoming a superstar and succumbing to her father's tutelage. After getting tired of sneaking around with Chris, she decides that she is not going to allow her father to interfere with her happiness. In one visit to Chris's apartment, Selena proposes that they get married: "Let's just do it. Let's just get married right now." Initially, Chris does not agree and tells her that it is a "crazy" thing to do. When Selena questions him about his desire to marry her, he says, "Of course I want to marry you, but the right way." For Chris, the right way is a traditional wedding ceremony: white dress, bridesmaids, family, and everything else. But Selena knows her father would never accept a wedding between them under those conditions. She explains to Chris that the only way her father will accept their relationship is if they get married right away, without his consent: "The only way he will know that I am not going to give you up is if we go out and get married right now. Then he'll have to accept us." It is obvious that Selena knows how to counteract her father's hegemony. Although she does not believe she can confront him and win, she knows what she needs to do in order to get what she wants. In this manner, she not only facilitates her autonomy but is also able to control her father, the band, and Chris. After all, she is the one who decides not only that the two are going to get married, but when and how. This scenario is yet another queer aspect of the movie. As a rebellious daughter and assertive lover, she defies gender norms, especially with respect to the way Chicanas/Latinas are typically represented in films. Selena turns out to be anything but submissive, and she is not a Mexican spitfire caricature, either. She knows exactly what she wants and she develops a strategy to subvert anything and anyone that impedes her plan.

Selena and Chris do end up eloping. She returns home married, after giving her father a day to digest what she did. When she approaches him in his study, Selena is befuddled by his consent: "I'm glad you did what you did." He adds, "You did what you had to do." Abraham responds to his defeat by crying, a side he had not shown previously, which represents the end of his dominion over Selena and his concomitant emasculation.

One interesting aspect of the film is that in keeping with the "good girl narrative," there is never any indication that Selena and Chris actually have sexual intercourse before they get married.

Although it would be reasonable to conclude that they had a sexual relationship before getting married, aside from some moderate kissing and hugging, the movie does not give viewers enough clues to prove this. Nonetheless, their sexual relationship has a queer dimension that is revealed in a later scene, where Selena—as all good, down-to-earth superstars do—is mowing the lawn at home with a manual lawn mower. When Chris arrives with some food he picked up on his way home, Selena begins telling him about her dream to have a farm with all types of animals. She then divulges that she has been thinking about having children: "You know, I've been thinking about having little animals of our own." Again, she is the one who convinces Chris to go along with her idea. As she has been doing all along, she is the active person even when it concerns sex. Once Chris accepts *her* desire to have children, he tells her, "Let's get started." Then he picks her up and carries her into the house, presumably to the bedroom to have intercourse. In an attempt to maintain the "good girl narrative," the film approaches the topic of sex between the two only when the I-want-to-have-children discourse is planted, which does not occur until some time after their marriage even though one would assume that they at least had intercourse on their wedding night. Chris's reaction hints that he had not thought much about having children. Therefore, either the two were not having sex—as the film attempts to project—or they were using some form of contraceptive. Another possibility is that they were engaging in intercourse without considering pregnancy to be a possible outcome; although I find this position rather hard to believe, it does complement the representation of each of the characters as young, naïve, and relatively innocent. Regardless, the relationship is queer in various ways: Selena's active role, Chris's passive role, and the apparent lack of interest in procreating prior to engaging in the I-want-to-have-children discourse.

Selena, suddenly on top of the world, has record sales, opens a clothing boutique, and gets a Grammy nomination. She hires a woman named Yolanda Saldívar (Lupe Ontiveros), the president of her fan club, to manage various aspects of her business empire. The relationship between the two women is one that is shaped by strong homosocial bonds. Moreover, Yolanda appears to be obsessed with Selena. The fact that she is the president of her fan club is just the first of many indications of such an obsession. When several of Selena's employees contribute money to buy her a gift, Yolanda volunteers to take the money and buy a ring that she knows Selena would enjoy. Since Yolanda knows Selena intimately and is by her side most of the



Figure 4.3 Jennifer López as Selena and Lupe Ontiveros as Yolanda in *Selena* (1997)

time, the employees have faith in Yolanda and know she will pick out the best ring. Yolanda basically ends up taking the money and claiming it as her own. Either out of jealousy or in an effort to win over Selena, or both, she buys a ring with an elegant egg (symbolic of fertility and reproduction) and gives it to Selena, claiming it is a gift from her only. This scene is particularly telling with respect to how the relationship between them is portrayed in the film.

It is late at night and the two are alone in the boutique, picking out fabric. Yolanda is rubbing Selena's shoulders when she tells Selena, "You know Selena. I am so proud of you—from the opening of the boutique, to the new record. You mean so much to me, I bought you a present." She then hands her the gift box with the ring (figure 4.3). Selena is very touched by the gift and this marks a new stage in their relationship, one that I argue moves well beyond the professional and friendly one the film depicts earlier. The intimate moment is symbolically the marriage between the two women with the ring confirming their union, the egg a symbol of fertility and the birth and rebirth of their relationship. The manner in which the ring was obtained is an indication of Yolanda's willingness to commit a crime in order to codify their relationship in more intimate ways.

When Abraham discovers that Yolanda has been laundering money from Selena, they interrogate her. During the exchange Yolanda exclaims, "I would never take anything from Selena. I love Selena." Selena, feeling betrayed by Yolanda, responds, "How could you do this to me? I trusted you with everything I have." Yolanda begs Selena for an opportunity to prove that she did not steal anything from her; she is given time to produce receipts and other financial documents.

Shortly thereafter, the narrative moves to the day when Selena is shot and killed. The film does not show the actual shooting. Instead, the footage focuses on Yolanda, barricaded in her truck with a gun to her head, after the fact. An officer is talking to Yolanda over a cell phone, trying to get her to put the gun down. She cries, "I can't put the gun down." "Why?" he asks. She continues, "Because I'm ashamed of what I've done. I don't deserve to live. Look what I've done to my best friend. I want to talk to my mother." This is the last image of Yolanda. The next scene has an important detail. The scene is of Selena in the hospital with a medic trying to revive her by pumping oxygen into her. In this scene, we see only Selena's left arm with a closed fist and the medic's arms. As the medic reaches for her wrist to check her pulse, her hand—now hanging over the bed—opens and drops the ring that Yolanda had given her onto the floor. The fact that Selena held the ring in the palm of her hand during the entire ordeal leads to many questions regarding the whole situation and their relationship. Did Selena attempt to give the ring back to Yolanda? Is that why Yolanda shot her? The observer is given no other details regarding what actually happened during the confrontation, not even a clue regarding what words were exchanged. Instead, the viewer is invited to imagine the entire scenario. The ring can certainly be used in the reconstruction of the events leading to her death. However, there are many possible scenarios. For example, a reasonable conclusion would be that Selena went to Yolanda to retrieve the financial documents. Upset over Yolanda's betrayal and the entire situation, Selena removed her ring, intending to give it back to Yolanda. This, combined with the trouble she was already in, would be an obvious sign to Yolanda that their relationship was coming to an end. The removal of the ring from Selena's finger is a symbol of lost love and separation. Yolanda, unable to accept the threat of being separated from Selena, shot her and threatened to kill herself so that the two could be together, if not in life then at least in death. The ring falling to the floor confirms the end of the relationship in both life and death, because Selena dies whereas Yolanda lives. Although this is just one of several possible scenarios, the ring

and all the symbolism it entails pertaining to love, relationships, union, fertility, and birth are just one example of the homoerotic element of the portrayal of this relationship. The fact that Selena held on to the ring until her final moment of death is also a sign of the intimate bond between the women. Consider that the film highlights this particular ring, whereas we never see a ring exchange between Chris and Selena. I am not trying to suggest that this portrayal of Selena is one that is based on a lesbian identity. However, I do insist that the relationship between the two—as it is represented in the film—is queer; their relationship falls somewhere along the lesbian continuum that Adrienne Rich (1983) has described as a means of understanding the intimate bonds that exist between some women:

> I mean the term lesbian continuum to include a range . . . of woman-identified experience; not simply the fact that a woman has had or consciously desired genital sexual experience with another woman. If we expand it to embrace many more forms of primary intensity between and among women, including tyranny, the giving and receiving of practical and political support . . . we begin to grasp breadths of female history and psychology that have lain out of reach as a consequence of limited, mostly clinical, definitions of "lesbianism."[21]

Even though Selena had managed to attain a powerful position in the gender hierarchy—relative autonomy and the ability to control the many men in her life as a result of her economic independence and success—she is ultimately killed by a gun in the hands of a woman. With all its phallic implications, the gun makes Yolanda the definitive aggressor, who puts an end to the ever-so-powerful Selena.

Selena is killed shortly after recording her crossover album. She was on the verge of conquering the English-speaking market. The act of an English-speaking person doing a crossover album into her native language is a contradiction in and of itself. But hasn't Selena been crossing borders all along? Her entire career has been based on transgressing borders: gender, linguistic, geographical, class, cultural, and others. Her transnational identity parallels her mestiza background while taking it a step further; she is a conglomeration of cultural signifiers who, in the end, does not succumb to the normative codes of Chicano/Latino, Anglo, or Mexican culture. Her identity has always been shaped by contradictions and ambiguities. As *Selena* makes clear, she will forever be regarded as the queen of Tejano music, a title that captures the essence of contemporary queer mestizaje.

Queer Women Have Curves: Legitimizing Nonnormative Chicana/Latina Aesthetics

In the same way that *Selena* espouses the reconfiguration of Chicana/Latina aesthetics by projecting images of an aesthetically appealing Chicana/Latina body that does not conform to normative standards of beauty as determined by dominant Anglo culture, in her play *Real Women Have Curves* Josefina López legitimizes full-figured Chicana/Latina women by placing their bodies at the center of a discourse on what it means to be beautiful and a "real woman." *Real Women* has also been instrumental in dismantling the stereotypes that have traditionally been associated with Chicana/Latina women in the media by presenting a leading female character that is strong, intelligent, rotund, *and* beautiful. Since its debut, the play has gone on to form an integral part of U.S. Latino popular culture, especially after being adapted to the screen. Moreover, it has been popular among feminist groups in general due to its pro-feminist discourses.

The story is a bilingual (English/Spanish) semiautobiographical account of a specific stage in López's life: her transition to adulthood, her turbulent relationship with her mother, and the challenges she faces while pursuing higher education. The narrative follows five women who are racing to meet production deadlines in order to keep their tiny garment factory from going under. Set in the tiny sewing factory, the women discuss intimate aspects of their lives and share their dreams with one another. The leading protagonist is Ana, the youngest among them. She is a recent graduate of high school who has dreams of going away to college. She must first overcome many of the obstacles before her: a traditional Mexican family structure, oppressive gender roles, and economic factors that require her to work in her sister's sewing factory. Equally important is the manner in which Ana and the other full-figured women respond to the pressure they feel to conform to the ideal body images that are projected in the media and that correspond to the dresses they are making.

After seeing the play in 1998, producer George LaVoo approached López with the idea of making it into a film. Together, they wrote the screenplay and *Real Women Have Curves*, the film, was produced in Los Angeles by HBO Films in 2001 on a budget of $3 million; it was directed by Patricia Cardoso. The film was originally intended to be an HBO premiere, but after favorable reception at the Sundance Film Festival, the producers at HBO decided to go with a theatrical release first. The film made its world premiere on January 13, 2002, at Sundance.

Here, I focus on the film. Although it is based on the play, there are significant differences in the film that make it particularly rich for conducting a gender and queer analysis. For example, whereas the setting of the play is primarily in the textile factory, the movie has important scenes that take place in Ana's home and other locations. Also, whereas the play does not physically include any male characters, they are present and they do play a vital role in the film.

The opening scene takes place in Ana's (América Ferrera)[22] home; she is cleaning the windows of the house. Her older sister, Estela (Ingrid Oliu), informs Ana that her mother, Carmen (Lupe Ontiveros), is calling for her. Carmen is in bed, claiming to be very sick. When Ana walks in, her mother explains to her, "I'm really sick, you'll have to make breakfast for the men." This is our introduction to Ana's home and family life. The rest of the movie focuses on Carmen's attempt to domesticate her rebellious daughter, who refuses to succumb to her mother's attempts to have her perform the traditional roles she believes a woman should play in the family structure: cleaning the house, cooking, washing clothes, and, overall, serving the men. However, this day is Ana's last day of high school and she does not believe her mother is truly sick; she refuses to stay home and make breakfast for the men: "Today's my last day of high school. I'm not going to miss that."

Ana goes off to school, traveling from the barrio of East Los Angeles to Beverly Hills High School, a school she managed to get herself into due to her stellar academic performance. As she makes her way to school, she walks hurriedly, wearing a tight-fitting blouse that highlights her relatively large body and breasts. The song that plays in this scene, "Chica difícil" (by Los Aterciopelados), helps to set the stage for the film: "Soy una chica difícil, pero yo valgo la pena" (I am a difficult girl, but I am worth the trouble.).

Ana has recently quit her part-time job at a local restaurant without informing her parents. When Ana's parents discover this, they confront her and tell her that she is going to have to work at her sister's factory. Initially, Ana refuses, but it is particularly difficult for her to defy her father. Aware of this, when Carmen doesn't feel she is getting through to Ana, she calls on her husband, Raúl (Jorge Cervera Jr.), to support her. Nevertheless, Ana's father is only a secondary character in the film; the primary antagonist is Carmen. It is Carmen who tries to make Ana look and behave according to the standards she has for "real women," which differ considerably from Ana's. For Carmen, Ana must possess a certain body type and be able to perform the household chores traditionally assigned to women in order to find

a man willing to marry her. Consequently, Carmen constantly nags Ana to lose weight and she attempts to control what Ana consumes. One night, while Carmen and her husband are in the bedroom preparing to go to bed, she complains to him about Ana: "No quiere hacer quehaceres. No limpia su cuarto. No lava ropa. No hace de comer. Puros problemas me da" (She doesn't want to do any chores. She doesn't clean her room. She doesn't do laundry. She doesn't cook. She gives me nothing but problems.). This is Carmen's way of labeling her daughter as something other than a legitimate woman. She is convinced that if she does not intervene, her daughter will always be a "chica difícil" and will not fulfill her obligatory role as a woman in her family and in her culture. Carmen attempts to convince Raúl that he, too, must help her control their daughter by placing her in the submissive roles she believes women should hold.

However, Ana's father does not agree. He tells Carmen that their daughter does not cause problems and that she only wants to educate herself. Ironically, throughout the film, the men are the primary source of Ana's empowerment. Almost every one of the male characters accepts Ana for who she is and does not function as a formidable source of conflict. Her father and her abuelo (played by Felipe de Alba) demonstrate unconditional love for her and do not pose a threat to her. Furthermore, they do not attempt to impose patriarchal principles on her. Instead, it is Carmen who functions as the female patriarch, the most vehement arbiter of patriarchal principles. She is the one who tries to maintain and impose the status quo by preparing her daughter to be a "good girl," one who is submissive and reflects the ideal forms of beauty projected in the media—especially soap operas—so that she can attract a man, get married, and have children. This is all part of Carmen's scheme to maintain a traditional family structure and get another baby in the family. She was unsuccessful at carrying out such a plan for her older daughter, Estela, who is now twenty-nine years old, still lives at home, and shares a bedroom with Ana. By Carmen's standards, it is already too late; Estela is too old and too overweight—she has become a spinster. In her kitchen, Carmen has two miniature statues of San Antonio, the patron saint of lost things, with a baby Jesus in his hands. The one she put up eleven years earlier for Estela is now upside down—which was supposed to make him work faster—but Carmen has given up praying for her older daughter: "It's too late for Estela to get married. Now I have to concentrate on Ana." She must focus now on Ana to prevent her from ending up a spinster like Estela. Since they are the only two children, continuing the family lineage now depends on Ana.

Estela is one of several queer characters in the film. She is portrayed primarily as an asexual woman and a spinster. The size of her body and her living conditions are not heteronormative; here we have an overweight woman who is almost thirty years old, still lives with her parents, and shares a room with her younger sister. Although the main purpose of the film is to legitimize large women—or all women—as real women, this legitimization does not occur until much later in the film. As Judith Butler explains, "the limits of constructivism are exposed at those boundaries where abjected or delegitimated [*sic*] bodies fail to count as 'bodies' " (*Bodies*, 15). Thus, until a body is legitimated or materialized, it remains abject. According to Butler, "the regime of heterosexuality operates to circumscribe and contour the 'materiality' of sex, and the 'materiality' is formed and sustained through and as a materialization of regulatory norms that are in part those of heterosexual hegemony" (*Bodies*, 15). Estela, Ana, and some of the other women who work in the factory are thus initially not considered "real women" because the size of their bodies circumscribes them as nonentities; as a result, they do not believe they can fully participate in a society governed by compulsory heterosexuality and patriarchy. Even though the women fantasize about wearing the dresses they are making, the fact that they cannot fit into them—or afford them—places them at the margins of society and any societal functions where such dresses might be worn—a wedding, for example.

The first scene in the garment factory is of Carmen and Ana admiring one of the finished dresses. When her mother sees her, she tells her: "Ni te hagas las ilusiones. You'll never fit into that one. It's a size 7" (Don't even think about it …). She then grabs Ana's large breasts with both hands and says, "Mira nomás. Enormous!" (Look at these …). Ana begs her mother to stop, but she continues, "They must weigh ten kilos each." This is Carmen's way of maintaining Ana and her body in an abject state; she is attempting to get Ana to accept that she cannot be a "real woman" with her body in its current condition. Ana's inability to fit into the size 7 dress signifies her inability to live a heteronormative lifestyle because her mother believes she needs to be able to fit into the dress to attract a man and partake in heteronormative traditions. However, Ana continually refutes her mother's ideologies. Although there are signs that she internalizes some of her mother's principles (e.g., her relatively low self-esteem),[23] throughout the film Ana remains steadfast regarding her own principles related to women's bodies and women's lives.

Carmen has internalized standards for female aesthetics that pertain to the dominant culture; the media and the small-sized dresses maintain these rigid standards. It is obvious that Carmen has accepted notions of beauty that require women to be thin in order to participate in certain societal rituals. Marianne Thesander maintains that notions of beauty for women in the United States in the late twentieth century were based largely on a look that corresponded to "nature," but in an idealized form: "She was tall, slim and supple with long, well-shaped but not muscular legs" (203). Thesander suggests that the correlation with nature converted the female body to an object that could be controlled by men, especially if one considers their role in the procreative process:

> Both sexes have procreative importance and therefore equal importance as individuals in society, but the ability of women to reproduce has set them apart from men and has been used in varying forms to limit their social and cultural sex roles. And it is this life-giving ability that has produced a lasting and ambivalent attitude towards the female body: it was regarded as part of nature, with great unknown powers and was, therefore, associated with insecurity and mysticism. Like other areas of nature, too, the female body became the object of social control. The male body, on the other hand, was regarded as both substance and spirit—culture and order—and as an instrument of control. (7)

The dresses are one of the primary symbols of the oppression these women face; they function as a means of maintaining the women in subordinate positions. As Carmen makes clear, for Ana to be desired by a man and to get married, she must be able to fit into the dress. However, for Ana, donning the dress is not simply a matter of aesthetics; she refuses to become a victim to the power differential that arises as a consequence of imprisoning her body in it. As Susan Bordo suggests, "The social manipulation of the female body emerged as an absolutely central strategy in the maintenance of power relations between the sexes over the past hundred years."[24] In the film, we see Ana challenge what she perceives to be the unjust roles that women have been historically assigned.

An interesting difference between the film and the play is that, whereas there is minimal discourse in the play regarding Ana's sexuality, the film is rich with respect to this theme. This is in part due to the addition of a male character, Jimmy (Brian Sites), an Anglo classmate who takes a romantic interest in Ana. Initially, Ana does not respond to Jimmy's nuanced advances, but just before they leave for summer vacation, he writes his phone number on her hand with a pen

and invites her to "hang out." This is the first step in Ana's process of legitimizing her body. In essence, Jimmy, a patriarchal representative of the dominant culture, marks her hand with his phone number, eroticizing her otherwise abject body.

The eroticization of Ana's body by Jimmy is particularly important because, as an Anglo male, Jimmy is expected to hold the same idealized notions of beauty as the dominant culture, where whiteness and thinness are privileged social locations. Since Ana's body is not white and is not thin, she stands in diametric opposition to these norms. Jimmy's rejection of the idealized notions of beauty and his preference for Ana's body mark his identity as queer. The interracial relationship, the differences in the size of their bodies (Jimmy is rather scrawny), and the submissive role Jimmy plays in the relationship can all be considered nonnormative signifiers as well.

Ana knows that her parents would never allow her to go out on a date. She conspires with her abuelo to get out of the house at night so that she can meet Jimmy. Under the guise that they are going to the movies together, Ana and her abuelo leave the house. She leaves him at a local bar and then goes to a restaurant to meet Jimmy. This is just one example of how Ana is able to overcome her mother's attempts to control her. Once again, the men in the film, whom one would expect to be the enforcers of patriarchy, end up assisting her in subverting it instead.

On their first date, Ana meets Jimmy at a restaurant; she is wearing a red, low-cut blouse that accentuates her breasts, partially covered by an open denim jacket. When she arrives, she stands right in front of him while he is sitting, with her breasts at Jimmy's eye level. Captivated by her breasts, he finds it difficult to look her in the face. Instead of remaining silent about his demeanor, Ana bluntly asks, "Are you staring at my boobs?" Her bold question sets the stage for the power dynamic between the two, where she clearly takes the active role by forcing him to respond to her question. "No. Yes. No," Jimmy utters, not sure how he is supposed to answer the question. Ana does not allow the matter to end there. She insists that her breasts become the focus of their discussion, an exchange that Ana obviously controls: "I mean, they're so big why wouldn't you, right?" Jimmy agrees and adds, "Um, I'm a guy. I guess I kind of have to." In this manner, Ana takes an active role in their relationship while using Jimmy to legitimize her body as erotic. When Jimmy tells her, "You have a really beautiful face." She responds, "Just my face?" Although this may be considered a sign of her insecurity, I maintain that it is in part her strategy to legitimize her body via the confirmation of it as erotic and beautiful.

As they approach the end of the summer, Ana and Jimmy know they will be going their separate ways. Jimmy is leaving for the university and Ana, at this time, believes she will have to continue working at the factory. Although she knows he will be leaving soon, she does not allow him to leave without fully assisting her in her quest to legitimize her body. For Ana, he must not only demonstrate his desire for her, but also physically act on it in order to prove to her that she is desirable. Before what is to be their final date, she goes to the drugstore and buys condoms, another sign of her active role in the relationship. Later, when they are alone in Jimmy's bedroom, they make out on his bed and she tells him, "Let's do it." He asks, "Are you sure?" And she responds, "I'm ready." She proceeds to take off her blouse and helps him remove his shirt, maintaining the imbalanced power dynamic of their relationship. She pulls out a condom and he reaches over and turns off the light. After a few seconds of darkness during which we hear a little moaning, she stops their encounter and exclaims, "Wait. Turn the lights on. I want you to see me." By taking her naked body out of the dark and into the bright lights of his room, she imposes her entire body on him, forcing him to make a decision about her attractiveness. As he sits up on the bed, she stands at the mirror looking at herself: "See, this is what I look like." Jimmy gets up, goes over to her, hugs her from behind, stares at her in the mirror, and says, "Qué bonita."

It is important to note that Ana does not appear to fall in love with Jimmy. After the encounter, whereas Jimmy tells her, "I'll write to you" and "I'll e-mail you," Ana insists, "No." She knows this is the end of their relationship. She has already obtained what she wanted from it, proof that her body is desirable. By engaging in this sexual encounter with Jimmy, she has confirmed that she and her body can participate in the rites that other, desirable women experience if she so chooses. Also, by losing her virginity, she defies the Mexican patriarchal imperative that women remain virgins until they are legitimately married. When Ana returns home later that evening, she bathes and her mother catches her looking at her body in the mirror. Immediately, she snaps, "You tramp … You're not only fat, now you're a puta!" Carmen's attempt to place Ana into an even more abject state by labeling her a whore nonetheless fails because Ana does not allow her comment to go unchallenged. Ana responds, "There's more to me than what's in between my legs!" The mother and daughter have several heated exchanges like this, but Ana typically comes out on top—she continually resists her mother's hegemony.

In the garment factory, Ana attempts to change the working conditions for the women. She tries to get them to see how unjust it is that they get paid $18 for the dresses they make while Bloomingdale's sells them for $600 a piece. She labels the factory a "sweatshop" and tells the women, "You're all cheap labor for Bloomingdale's." Her efforts to undermine the control that Anglo capitalism has over the women are thwarted principally by her mother and secondly by the other women, who appear to accept their subordinate positions in society. Her feminist views also function as a counterpart to the role that capitalism and patriarchy play in determining the roles that women assume in society. Initially, the women do not accept Ana's progressive feminist views, labeling her "La Miss-Know-It-All" and dismissing her as a "spoiled brat." However, Ana remains steadfast and espouses her contradictory views regarding women's roles in society to all the women in the factory. When Carmen claims that girls who think they know it all are the ones who end up unmarried and pregnant, Ana rebuts, "The reason they end up pregnant is because they don't know how to use contraceptives." And when Carmen claims that men only want to marry virgins, Ana asks, "Why is a woman's virginity the only thing that matters? A woman has thoughts, ideas, a mind of her own."

Despite the differences between these women, homosocial bonds develop between them that shape their identities. An important element of the factory environment is the role that gossiping plays in strengthening the bonds between the women. *Chisme* (gossip) keeps the women entertained while they work and helps them escape the reality of working in the garment factory. It also functions as a mechanism for sharing personal aspects of their lives and the lives of other members of the community—a sign that the women deeply trust one another. In her introduction to the play, López writes: "I remember feeling blessed that I was a woman because male bonding could never compare with what happens when women work together. We had something special and I wanted to show the world."[25] Margo Milleret claims that female-bonding is often formulated and nourished through gossiping: "*Chisme*, with its ability to engage and connect the women to each other, helps them attain a greater sense of self-esteem and selfhood. At the same time *chisme* breaks down the barriers between the women and their cultural values."[26] Besides helping to form and strengthen bonds between the women, *chisme* can thus function as a space where nonheteronormative discourses take place. While initially Ana does not participate in gossiping with the women, her ideas eventually influence the themes they discuss.

Constantly under the threat of a deadline to complete an order for dresses, Estela and the rest of the women find their working conditions increasingly difficult. The situation is exacerbated when four of Estela's employees move to Mexico, and by the fact that the Glitz Company will not pay for an order until it is filled—leaving Estela with economic difficulties and unable to pay her employees on time. The female bonds already in place permit the rest of the women to make sacrifices for Estela, opting to continue to work and wait for their checks until Estela can afford to pay them. This female bonding takes place as a response to the oppression Estela and the others experience at the mercy of a capitalist, male-dominated system. Each woman, including Ana (after a bit of hesitation), agrees to sacrifice her paycheck and work extra hours to get a big order filled. The relationship they develop requires that they go beyond the normative gender roles prescribed for women, especially Chicana/Latina women. As María Figueroa suggests, "Rather than conforming to the stereotypical cultural gender roles of *la madre, la virgen santa*, or *la puta*, these women leave the domestic space and assume an active subjectivity as seamstresses in the work place, constructing a newly redefined familial space in which they can exist and invest their minds, bodies, and souls."[27] The women become invested in one another. They are aware that in order to maintain their jobs and their close ties with one another, they must work together. This relationship confirms their existence as productive women and human beings, which in turn becomes a path to the legitimation of their bodies. However, there still exists the question of their bodies as erotic and beautiful sites. Although they can organize to accomplish their goal of finishing so many dresses by the deadline, they are still getting paid too little for making dresses that are too small for their full-figured bodies. Each of these issues is addressed in the following scenes.

Estela's aspirations to design her own clothes and open her own boutique where women's plus sizes would be available are planted in the narrative of the film but do not fully develop; in the play, she actually opens her own boutique. Ana and the other women encourage Estela to follow her dreams and Ana, in particular, tries to teach her sister how to be a smart and assertive businesswoman.

Especially important is the matter of the dress sizes; without dresses that fit their bodies, these women remain in an abject status. The film highlights the women's admiration for the dresses they are making, which symbolize ideal feminine beauty. The women believe the dresses are beyond their reach because they could never fit into them or afford them. Estela takes it upon herself to design and make

a dress especially for Ana. When she hands her the dress, Ana cannot believe it is for her and she does not believe she can fit into it. Estela tells her, "I cut this just for your body, okay? Pretty dresses aren't just for skinny girls." This scene actually takes place just before Ana has the sexual encounter with Jimmy in his bedroom. This is just one of a string of events that solidifies the legitimation of Ana's body as that of a "real woman."

One of the final scenes, and the most famous, takes place in the factory on a particularly hot day. By this time, Ana has undergone a transformation based on the aforementioned events. It is obvious that she has achieved a new level of comfort with her body despite the fact that her mother's presence continues to undermine her autonomy. The women are on the verge of finishing a large order when Ana puts down her steam iron and removes her blouse (she is wearing a bra), relieved that they are about to finish the order and that her body is no longer imprisoned by her blouse. The exchange takes the following course:

Carmen: Ana! What are you doing?
Ana: It's so hot. All the steam has me sweating like a pig.
Carmen: We're sweating too, but we're not taking our clothes off.
Ana: Why not? We're all women. We all have the same things.

Carmen, continuing her role as female patriarch, attempts to exert control over Ana's body. She sees Ana's actions as highly inappropriate for a woman, especially considering the size and shape of her body. Naomi Wolf reminds us that standards of beauty are imposed to domesticate "wild" bodies or unacceptable behavior among women. As women's liberation threatened the social order, a "beauty backlash" arose to put women back in their submissive roles, a backlash specifically to "hypnotize women into political paralysis."[28] It is this form of aesthetic hegemony that Ana has been battling all along.

Ana begins to walk away, and Carmen chases her with her blouse, "¡Ana! ¡Póntela!" (Ana! Put it on!). Defiantly, Ana walks over to the other women and asks them if they are hot also, but Carmen continues to harass her:

Carmen: Aren't you embarrassed?
Ana: Of what?
Carmen: Look at you, you look awful.
Ana: Mamá, I happen to like myself.

Estela congratulates Ana for refuting her mother's comments, and then Carmen attacks both of them: "The two of you should lose

weight. You would look beautiful without all that fat." This time, Pancha (Soledad St. Hilaire), the largest of the women, interjects, "Ah! Doña Carmen, Ana and Estela are beautiful. They look good the way they are!" As the exchange escalates, Ana tells her mother, "Mamá, I do want to lose weight. And part of me doesn't because my weight says to everybody, fuck you!" She then adds, "How dare anyone try to tell me what I should look like or what I should be when there's so much more to me than just my weight." When Rosalí (Lourdes Pérez), the thinnest of the women, complains about her weight and says, "I look like a cow," Ana goes over to her, tells her to shut up, and forces her to look at her body to compare. This sets off a competition between the women, excluding only Carmen. They start comparing themselves to large animals, and Rosalí unbuttons her jeans and pulls them below her hips in an attempt to show them what she deems her "fat hips." Then, Ana unbuttons her jeans and pulls them down. The two women compare their bodies and their fat when Estela gets up and walks over to them. She pulls off her skirt completely, touches her thighs, and exclaims, "This is cellulite!" They then begin comparing stretch marks and remove their blouses. Eventually, the three are standing in only their underwear, gazing at one another's bodies. Carmen stands in the background, watching with an open mouth. Finally, Pancha gets up and says, "Ladies. Ladies. Let me show you stretch marks (figure 4.4)." She removes her clothes, reveals her large body, and Rosalí proclaims her the winner. The semi-naked women break out in laughter. According to Milleret: "The women's shock at their semi-nakedness and vulnerability is quickly replaced with relief, first because they feel cooler, and second because they all look the same" (121). I suggest that this relief is also a manifestation of their newfound freedom: the freedom to expose their cloistered bodies and the freedom to gaze at other female bodies. The relief also is a result of the release of the tension that existed between the women due to the fact that despite occupying a homosocial space, they were still controlled by hegemonic masculinity, largely imposed by Carmen. The women relish in a new level of intimacy thanks to the shared experience of disrobing and examining one another's bodies.

After a few moments, Pancha says, "Ladies, look how beautiful we are!" The display of their bodies and, more important, the acceptance of their bodies as beautiful are the culmination of their legitimacy as "real women." When Carmen tries to undermine their efforts by making them feel embarrassed about their bodies, Ana tells her,



Figure 4.4 From left to right: Lourdes Pérez as Rosalí, América Ferrera as Ana, Ingrid Oliu as Estela, and Soledad St. Hilaire as Pancha in *Real Women Have Curves* (2002)

"This is who we are Mamá, real women." Apparently embarrassed and frustrated, Carmen exits the room. By overthrowing Carmen, the four women triumph over patriarchy and heteronormativity. Much more energized and happy, they return to their workstations wearing only their underwear. Ana turns on the radio and they begin dancing in their respective work areas.

Throughout this scene, there is a particular amount of intimacy and touching between Ana and Rosalí. Within this homosocial environment, acts of removing clothing, gazing at one another's bodies, and touching another female body become sites for mapping homoerotic identities. The fact that these two women began the competition by removing their clothing can also be considered a means for them to codify their desire for each other. Once Carmen is removed from the picture and the dancing starts, Rosalí is seen standing up, holding a dress in her hand and dancing her way over to Ana's workstation. She hangs the dress and then moves closer to Ana. The two women begin bumping their hips together to the rhythm of the music. At one particular moment, Ana's butt grinds into Rosalí's crotch, simulating a sex act (figure 4.5). In this way, the female bonding that was already prevalent in the factory moves to another level, one that has larger homoerotic implications, because the women no longer succumb to the social parameters that prevent women from



Figure 4.5 Lourdes Pérez as Rosalí (left) and América Ferrera as Ana in *Real Women Have Curves* (2002)

behaving in such a fashion even in the absence of men. According to Milleret:

> Whereas modesty prevented the women from purposely undressing to cool off, as suggested by Ana, competition spurs them to engage in a show-and-tell to outdo each other. Thus the scene takes on a hilarious character, mocking a strip tease that instead of providing pleasure for the audience offers the women the opportunity to reclaim their own pleasure by appealing to themselves and each other. (122)

Through displaying their bodies to one another and designating them as beautiful, the women are able to act on a form of desire that allows them to be intimate to varying degrees with one another. The eroticism of the large-sized body becomes a site for subverting patriarchy and mapping nonheteronormative identities. The women do not need the gaze of a man to determine their beauty. Instead, they decide that they are beautiful and the only people they need to appeal to are themselves and one another.

In the final scenes, Ana is transformed into a complete and "real woman." Ana comes to the conclusion that she is going to go away to college, despite her family's—especially Carmen's—attempts to keep her at home and have her live as a traditional woman. When she first gets the news that she has been accepted to Columbia University, her parents tell her that she cannot go. However, after this entire

transformative process and her newfound autonomy, she does not allow her parents to stop her. She finally goes to her father, and, without even having to utter the words, her father concedes, "You have my blessing." Steadfast, Carmen does not give Ana her blessing. Nevertheless, Ana leaves home. In the final scene, she is exiting the New York subway at Times Square—confidently walking along the sidewalk, free from her mother's authority. Her manner of walking in this final scene is of utmost importance. In previous scenes, Ana walks in what might be described as a sloppy, lackadaisical fashion, usually with her shoulders slouched and practically dragging her feet—her body an asexual entity. In an early scene, her mother chastises her and tries to get her to "straighten up" and "walk like a lady." In this final scene, she holds her head high and her body sways with confidence, displaying it in an assertive way.

As I have shown, many characters in *Real Women Have Curves* do not conform to the gender or sexual norms of Anglo, Mexican, or Chicana/o culture, including the marginal male ones. Whereas Ana's father takes a submissive role by not enforcing patriarchal standards of beauty and gender roles, Carmen functions as the principal arbiter of such norms by taking on the role of female patriarch. Through resisting her mother's tutelage, and patriarchy in general, Ana is able to legitimate herself and her curvy body as that of a "real woman." The other women in the factory are also able to do the same. All these characters function as sites for mapping queer identities in the film. By rejecting normative standards of beauty, developing a female homosocial space, and completely displaying and eroticizing their full-figured bodies, these women transcend the marginalized status to which they were previously confined. Their queer identities redefine Chicana/Latina aesthetics by designating their large-sized bodies as erotic and beautiful.

Conclusion: What Happened to the Children?

In this chapter, I have analyzed three films that do not overtly portray gay and lesbian identities or themes. I chose these three films specifically for this reason and also because they focus on the Chicana/o and Latina/o experience. My intent was to show how the representation of Chicana/o and Latina/o identities in these films is queer. Despite the lack of openly gay or lesbian characters in these films, queer identities and queer themes abound. One of the characteristics that all the films share is that they center on a theme I discussed at the beginning of this chapter—the conflict between a parental figure

trying to impose his or her traditional values, largely based on Mexican culture, and their children who are being raised in not just another era but in another cultural space altogether. The fact that the children in these films come of age while residing in the United States makes imposing traditional Mexican norms a virtually impossible task. By drawing on cultural signifiers from Anglo, Mexican, Chicano, Latino, and other cultures, the younger generation is able to negotiate ways to subvert the oppression they experience from at least one parent (sometimes both) attempting to impose heteronormativity, where the primary goal is for the children to get married, procreate, and, ultimately, replicate the traditional family structure. As demonstrated, not a single parental figure is able to accomplish this goal. Instead, notions of family and family values are constantly challenged, negotiated, and reconfigured so that an alternative family structure takes shape, one that is imbued with queer characteristics.

Although the theme of children defying their parents' wishes and going against traditional family values is a common one in cultural texts, I have shown how the representation of this process in Chicana/o and Latina/o popular culture overwhelmingly defies heteronormative gender, social, and sexual codes. As these children transition into adulthood, they opt to place their education, their careers, and their own desire above the wishes of their parents. In doing so, they reject heteronormative values and customs. As a result, they engage in a series of nonnormative social and sexual behaviors that shape their identities as queer.

3

Violence and Sexualities

5

Rape, Violence, and Chicana/o and Latina/o Identities

> Got raped once . . . Makes you more aware than ever that you are one hunerd [*sic*] percent female, just in case you had any doubts. One hunerd [*sic*] percent female whether you act it . . . or like it . . . or not.[1]
>
> Corky, protagonist of Cherríe Moraga's *Giving Up the Ghost*

Violence is a prevalent theme in Chicana/o and Latina/o narratives and has become a stereotypical representation of the culture in the media. In this chapter I am interested in examining the role that violence plays in constructing queer Chicana/o and Latina/o identities in our cultural production. I analyze scenes and narratives that include representations of violent acts in order to demonstrate how such acts codify a queer body that engages, or is forced to engage, in nonheteronormative social and sexual behavior. These texts include the novel *Locas* (Yxta Maya Murray, 1997), *So Far from God* (Ana Castillo, 1994), and *Naked Ladies* (Alma Luz Villanueva, 1994) as well as the film *American Me* (Edward James Olmos, 1992). I focus on violence in three particular settings: gangs, prisons, and the domestic arena.

Central to this study is the issue of rape and its effect on identity development. As an act of violence committed against a nonconsensual subject by a perpetrator exerting dominion over the body, rape places the victim in a passive role and reduces the subject to a position of inferiority. This passive, inferior position is often marked as a nonmasculine one, a role that has historically been imposed on women, especially in patriarchal societies. Through the dehumanization of the body, rape strips the victim of agency and places the subject outside of normative codes of identity as a result of the acts that are forced upon it. The body itself is objectified and appropriated by the aggressor, who claims the possession and domination of it, even if for a brief moment. As Michel Foucault suggests, it was during the classical

age that—through acts of discipline and punishment—the body became objectified and used for economic exchange:

> The human body was entering a machinery of power that explores it, breaks it down and rearranges it. A "political anatomy," which was also a "mechanics of power," was being born; it defined how one may have a hold over others' bodies, not only so that they may do what one wishes, with the techniques, the speed and the efficiency that one determines. Thus discipline produces subjected and practised bodies, "docile" bodies. Discipline increases the forces of the body (in economic terms of utility) and diminishes these same forces (in political terms of obedience). In short, it dissociates power from the body; on the one hand, it turns it into an "aptitude," a "capacity," which it seeks to increase; on the other hand, it reverses the course of the energy, the power that might result from it, and turns it into a relation of strict subjection. If economic exploitation separates the force and the product of labour, let us say that disciplinary coercion establishes in the body the constricting link between an increased aptitude and an increased domination.[2]

The conversion of the human body into a docile object that can be used for economic exploitation thus takes place as a body is subjected to some form of discipline. Certainly, subjects can be disciplined to accept their position in society and develop a docile body. However, if the body resists, it may be subjected to some form of punishment in order to enforce its commodification, which often involves some form of rape or violent aggression. In patriarchal societies, women have overwhelmingly been the victims of rape and other forms of violence, which functions to maintain them in marginal positions.

In *New French Feminisms*, Elaine Marks and Isabelle de Courtivron include, among their feminist manifestos, a poem titled "Rape Is an Abuse of Power," which attempts to explain how and why men are the primary perpetrators of rape in partriachal societies:

> Men rape because they own (have) the law.
> They rape because they are the law.
> They rape because they make the law.
> They rape because they are the
> guardians of the peace, of law and order.
> They rape because they have power,
> the language, the money, the knowledge,
> the strength, a penis, a phallus.[3]

Thus, rape becomes a means to attain and maintain the power to control Others. While male-on-male rape is less often discussed or portrayed in popular culture, it places male victims in the same inferior position. There are several examples of men raping men and fewer incidents of women raping men. For example, the role U.S. soldiers assumed during the U.S. invasion of Iraq. The graphic photos and descriptions in the media of male Iraqi prisoners in Abu Ghraib being raped and sexually abused/tortured in some way by male and female U.S. soldiers made many rethink the way they view violent sexual acts and the people who commit them. Such acts were purportedly committed to humiliate the subjects—a common tactic used to break down the victim and create a docile subject. These acts are also extremely queer. They force the body to participate in nonnormative social and sexual behavior: bound naked bodies piled on top of one another, orifices penetrated both literally and symbolically, and a compendium of sadomasochistic elements.[4]

Therefore, rape is a form of violence used to punish subjects in order to maintain them in a submissive position regardless of the gender of the rapist or the victim. This act is essentially queer because it takes place outside of a heteronormative context: a nonconsensual, unsanctioned, violent sexual act that involves unorthodox sexual practices.

In Chicana/o and Latina/o cultural texts, the representation of violence and rape is often used to construct queer identities. Through acts of violence, the body is relocated to a position where it defies heteronormative gender and sexual norms. Such a status is attained through the dehumanization of the individual and the subsequent use of the body or certain body parts as objects of exchange in an economic system. These acts and processes have long been associated with the tumultuous relationship between the colonizer and the colonized.

For Chicanas/os, the rape of La Malinche (Hernán Cortés's interpreter, advisor, and mistress during the Spanish conquest of Mexico) holds as one of the defining characteristics of our identity. La Malinche has long been accepted as the archetypal mother of all mestizas/os. Through the colonization of the Americas, mestizo people were not only created through acts of violence and rape, but they were also placed in marginalized positions that to date have social, economic, and political ramifications. As colonized people, indigenous groups and their offspring were marked as inferior and forced into submissive roles in society. They became victims of acts of violence and humiliation. These

roles continue to shape Chicana/o identity in the United States. As Carl Gutiérrez-Jones suggests in *Rethinking the Borderlands*,

> Shame has been used to reinforce Chicana gender roles, including passivity, by associating Chicana violation with an act of consent. In the Malinche context, the principal dynamic of rape in Chicano communities—which occurs predominantly between familiars within the same social group—is refracted through a cross-cultural lens, making the event but one moment in a larger history of betrayal.[5]

Gutiérrez-Jones's assertion that shame is used to maintain Chicanas in gender roles can certainly be applied to Chicanos/Latinos and their positions in society overall. Through humiliation and violent acts committed against men and women, the victims are essentially relegated to positions of marginality.

María Herrera-Sobek, in her essay "The Politics of Rape: Sexual Transgression in Chicana Fiction," insists that although the La Malinche myth is often employed to discuss rape in cultural texts, it is only one of many factors. She suggests that other factors play a more significant role in shaping how and why rape has become a prevalent motif in Chicana narratives: "Indeed many Chicana poets employ the rape motif in their creative writings and, although the La Malinche myth is one of many vectors structuring the rape scene in Chicana literature, I believe economic, social, and political circumstances are more instrumental in influencing Chicanas to utilize sexual assault as a recurring metaphor in their works."[6] In her discussion of rape scenes portrayed in Chicana narratives, Herrera-Sobek posits that through their devaluation, "women are socialized into being participants in their own oppression" (247). She adds that rape converts the female body to a hole, a nonentity to be used by males: "The violation itself symbolizes the final act which obliterates women from the system. The process of raping, 'making an absence,' transforms women into silent, invisible, non-existent entities—as holes to be filled by males" (249). Furthermore, she describes how victims of sexual assault lose their identities as human beings and are transformed into formless entities "devoid of feeling and bodily sensations" (250). Herrera-Sobek describes how the marginalization of women leads to their economic and social dependence on men, which also results in a loss of agency and control over their own bodies. She points out that some victims ultimately seek protection from a man because they may be left with no other recourse. The dichotomy of men as perpetrators of violence and then as protectors from violence

exists in patriarchal societies because, overall, men are valued, whereas women are not; men have privilege, whereas women do not; and men possess power, whereas women do not. Herrera-Sobek makes clear that rape is about power, not sex.

In the following sections, I focus on the representation of violence and rape in Chicana/o and Latina/o cultural texts while examining the effect that it has on constructing queer identities. I demonstrate how men and women who are subjected to violence and rape develop queer identities by being forced to engage in nonheteronormative behavior. Moreover, I argue that because the perpetrators of rape also engage in a nonheteronormative act, their identities are also queer. I must underscore that my use of the term *queer* in this chapter is solely to describe nonheteronormative gender and sexual roles and behavior. By no means do I intend for there to be any particular value associated with the term *queer* in this chapter. I am merely employing the term to examine the way Chicana/o and Latina/o identities that do not adhere to heteronormative gender, social, and sexual behavior are portrayed in our cultural texts. By conducting such an analysis, I hope to show that the representation of violence and rape in Chicana/o and Latina/o cultural texts is often used to construct characters with queer identities.

Homeboys, Homegirls, and Homoeroticism: Violent Sexual Imagery in *Locas*

Gang culture has become a mainstay in Chicana/o and Latina/o cultural texts. Pachucos were the leading protagonists in Luís Valdez's *Zoot Suit* (1981); cholos and cholas have been portrayed in a number of works: the films *American Me* (1992), *Blood In, Blood Out* (1993), and *Mi Vida Loca* (1994); and the novels *Down These Mean Streets* (Piri Thomas, 1967) and *Always Running: La Vida Loca, Gang Days in L.A.* (Luís J. Rodríguez, 1993), just to name a few. Similarly, homeboy and homegirl culture has influenced U.S. popular culture significantly, from the clothes teenagers wear to the way they spruce up their vehicles and their bicycles in lowrider fashion. Gang members have also traditionally been portrayed as delinquents and have often been associated with violence and criminality, whether they engage it such acts or not.

In her excellent book on the portrayal of gangs in cultural texts, *Gang Nation: Delinquent Citizens in Puerto Rican, Chicano, and Chicana Narratives* (2002), Monica Brown suggests that "these youth have not simply turned their backs on an idealized notion of

what it means to be a good and upstanding citizen of America. Rather, they have sought in many ways to emulate existing structures from which they are excluded, including access to 'equal citizenship.'"[7] Thus, Gangs emulate the social, political, and economic structures of the dominant culture by creating a microcosm of it in order to obtain some of the same benefits and privileges that others enjoy. This microcosm is shaped by its own laws, language, and codes of conduct. Brown maintains that the norms associated with gangs in many ways mirror those of the dominant culture while simultaneously functioning as a form of counterculture:

> The complex infrastructure of certain contemporary gangs (including flags, signs, language systems, territorial loyalties, shared mythologies, "wars," military-style ranking of soldiers, and so on) relies on a carefully articulated sense of a separate and empowered "national" identity, as well as certain masculinist [*sic*] and homosocial behaviors. These "counter-nations" simultaneously mirror and expose some of the most oppressive facets of dominant culture's construction of nation and an American "national symbolic." (xvii)

Brown argues that gangs allow members the opportunity to restructure their relationship with the dominant culture by repositioning second-class citizens to first-class status in an alternative nation with its own codes of conduct.

Gangs are, more often than not, associated with violence, which becomes an integral part of their identities; they often create aggressive and violent identities to attain a certain status within their communities and with respect to their relationship with the dominant culture. Within gang nations, violence also plays an integral role in shaping identities; it is often used to initiate new members and to punish those who do not follow established norms. There are at least two areas related to violence within gangs that play a key role in creating what I am designating queer identities: homosocial bonding and economic structures.

According to Eve Kosofsky Sedgwick, homosociality is intrinsically linked to homosexuality.[8] The intimate bonds that form between members of the same sex in gangs are certainly sites for examining queer identities. Overall, gangs are made up of members of the same sex, and even if they are not, gender norms determine particularities with respect to who participates in certain spaces and roles. For example, in order to become a member of a gang, typically an initiate must first prove his/her allegiance to it—not to mention his/her qualifications—through an initiation ceremony. The most common way for a

person to join is through being "jumped in" by a group of current gang members usually of the same sex.[9] The ritual of getting "jumped in," besides being a necessary component for initiation into a gang, serves as a means of creating a docile body that will obey and carry out the social and economic rules of the gang nation—often reflections and exaggerations of the rules of the dominant culture. This ritual requires creating subordinate subjects that pledge an allegiance to the nation. The initiate must not only take a passive role in the initiation ritual by withstanding all the physical violence to which the body is subjected, but he/she must also do so without complaining or showing weakness.[10] This ritual creates a docile body that is symbolically—sometimes literally—raped by multiple gang members. Besides fortifying a gang by inducting new members, the initiation ritual itself can be seen as a means of strengthening homosocial bonds between members of the gang.

Although it is a work of fiction, in her novel *Locas*, Yxta Maya Murray depicts gang life in what some critics considered to be a realistic fashion. Her novel is one of the first to focus on women in gangs—in this case, the cholas of Echo Park in Los Angeles, members of Los Lobos. The protagonists, Cecilia and Lucía, tired of the oppression they experience from the dominant Anglo culture, Chicano/Latino culture, and the gang itself, decide to form their own gang within the Lobos gang using the same rituals as the males. The description of their initiation ceremony is full of violent sexual imagery and homoerotic overtones. Lucía, the leader of the gang, organizes the ceremony. At night, she gathers two other females to help her start the gang and they take turns "jumping in" one another. First, Lucía and Star Girl jump in Chique:

> Star Girl and me went after her, our hands reaching out like spiders, gripping her head and her hair and her throat. Chique's fat ass moved up like a pillow and we slammed it down, then chopped and slugged and scratched. I laughed wild and high, all my strong feelings going into her, and Star Girl yelled out too, loud and long like she was singing some old war song.[11]

This physically charged scene is symbolically the rape of Chique by the two young women. The image of her "ass" moving up and being forced down while all Lucía's "strong feelings" penetrate her produces an image of a rape scene that includes a form of sodomy. The final "yelling out loud" of the two women is analogous to their reaching orgasm and releasing their testosterone-filled bodies. One might argue that Chique is somewhat complacent because she is aware that

this is part of the initiation ritual. There also exists the possibility that initiates actually derive pleasure from participating in this ritual. However, when you have no other recourse but to join a gang in order to benefit from its protection and participate in its social and economic structure, you are basically forced to participate in your own oppression. Being beat and raped is a ritual that signifies the subject has survived brutal acts of violence that essentially transform the body into a nonentity, one that does not feel pain.[12]

In the three "jumping in" scenes, the body is transformed to a nonentity in order to create obedient subjects. Each time, it is lacerated in some way and it serves to satisfy the aggression that each woman feels obligated to express and carry out. After Chique gets "jumped in," Chique and Lucía do the same thing to Star Girl:

> Me and Chique slapped her around the face, and pulled on her hair, sliced into her with our rings, our nails, ripping her dress, shredding at what was under there, not so much that she needs the doctor, but hard so some blood's spilling on the ground. "Take it! TAKE IT!" I'm screaming while I'm rabbit-punching her in the side and rolling her down and she's trying not to cry, getting all bruised and red looking, her skirt flipping up and her mouth tight the whole time while we shoved her back, and her face curved and twisted into a knot. (49)

Similar to the first scene, two women brutally beat and rape a third. The ripping off of the clothing, the lacerations, and the bleeding are all reminiscent of a violent rape scene. The perpetrators of the violence clearly exert their power over the body and place it in a marginal position, at least temporarily. By committing such acts on each body, it becomes a tabula rasa for mapping new identities; it becomes hardened by the experience and permits a new stage of homosocial bonding between the women to emerge.

In the last "jumping in" ceremony, Chique and Star Girl "jump in" Lucía. The latter relishes in the aggressive body contact she receives from the other two women. She claims to be pleased when they don't hold anything back and give it to her "nice and traditional" (50). The fact that she and the other women derive pleasure from such violent acts can be considered another queer element of these scenes, because violence as a form of sexual fantasy is also a nonheteronormative signifier. Furthermore, after the orgiastic "jumping in," the three young women do the traditional slicing of the hand with a switchblade to become blood sisters: "We took the knife and split the thick part of our hands so that the blood ran down our arms in a long line. Pressed our

hands together so the skin's close and hot and tight, and I felt it all mix in like we was sisters" (50). This final exchange of bodily fluids is the culmination of the rape scenes and clearly demonstrates the queerness of the entire scenario. Here we have three women who violate one another sequentially by giving up their bodies for a limited time, and there exists evidence that they derive pleasure from both performing and being the recipients of these violent acts. Finally, they lacerate their hands and press their open wounds (symbolic of menstruation) together to allow for the exchange of bodily fluids and engage in an orgy of sorts. At the end of the ritual, Lucía remarks, "There, you mine now" (50). Then they are all baptized with new names, giving rise to a social order that is largely modeled after the male-dominated one with which they are most familiar—the Lobos gang.

Comparable scenes that include male-male "jumping in" initiation rituals can be found in other texts and they can be read in a similar fashion. For example, Luís Rodríguez's *Always Running* and Piri Thomas's *Down These Mean Streets.* These texts portray the dynamics of gang culture with a focus on the relationship between men, where violence is used to create docile subjects, which, in effect, constructs queer identities.

The representation of violent acts used to create submissive subjects in cultural texts is merely one aspect of the portrayal of gang culture that has queer implications—another is the economic structure of gangs. As mentioned, gangs depend on the creation and maintenance of docile subjects that conform to the codes of conduct within the gang nation. It is commonly accepted that once you are in a gang, you are in for life, *por vida*. Attempting to leave a gang often results in death or some other form of retribution. Throughout their existence within gang nations, members contribute to the economic demands of the gang in order to sustain or enrich it. Through selling arms or drugs, physically and symbolically acquiring turf, or expanding the gang, the economy of the gang remains salient. This economic structure ultimately depends on its "citizens" and a leader.

For the most part, gangs have a designated leader who makes the most important decisions and who controls all the members and the economy of the gang. Leaders possess the most power in any gang, and there is often a struggle for this and some secondary leadership roles that can be obtained by acquiring money, guns, drugs, or respect—all extensions of the phallus due to their association with power in a patriarchal system. Leaders must wear a hard shell, never showing any sign of weakness and always demonstrating their virility. Showing signs of weakness inevitably leads to his or her demise.

Therefore, having control over and, in essence, possessing other bodies becomes an essential role of the leader of a gang, a role that is typically carried out in a hypermasculine fashion.

Locas gives the reader good insight as to the economic structure of gangs, especially with respect to women's roles. In her analysis of gender roles in gang texts, Monica Brown comes to the conclusion that the women of such texts "are objectified and denied agency, reduced at times to capital to be shared between men, their bodies receptacles of violence, territories upon which the acts of war are played out" (83). She adds, "If Latino men are relegated to second-class citizenship, then Cecilia, Lucía, and Mona, the female protagonists in *Locas* and *Two Badges*, are relegated to third-class citizenship, searching for a way out of the limited gender roles imposed on them by their families, local communities, and the larger culture" (83).

Certainly, females are often used as commodities of exchange in gang economies. However, males are also often reduced to the same objectification—they are possessed and exchanged in a similar fashion. Such dynamics have less to do with gender than they do with who is the leader, the one who controls all other members. Now, as Brown explains, "women are marginalized differently by and within the nation, and even within the gang they have limited access to leadership roles" (84). Nevertheless, women sometimes attain leadership roles and assume positions within a gang where they have authority over others, as is evident in *Locas.* Cecilia and Lucía, after getting tired of being considered "sheep" and being used by the men as receptacles that are only "good for fucking" (31) and squeezing out "little doggies" (40) decide to transform their identities from docile young women to powerful entities that do not only participate fully in a gang but also control other gang members. To do this, they are required to not only gain power (i.e., a phallus) but also to exert it over others, including male gang members.

They begin by taking leadership roles in the gang, which are overwhelmingly associated with assuming masculine roles. For example, when Lucía learns how to handle the gang's books, she claims, "I started walking like a man does, taking them long-legged roomy steps so people start getting out of my way" (39). She claims that she became the "first boss woman in this town" (39). However, in order to attain and maintain the position, Lucía had to adopt a masculine identity, which increases exponentially as she ascends the gang hierarchy. This is just one example of the way the characters in *Locas* do not adhere to normative gender codes and can be considered queer.

In fact, the novel contains several examples of homoerotic relationships and nonnormative gender roles. Manny is Lucía's lover and the leader of the gang. Initially, he controls the economy of the gang, but as Lucía learns more and more about handling the books, she becomes irreplaceable and gains enough authority to dethrone him. Throughout the novel we see how Manny begins to show signs of weakness while Lucía gains strength—evident in the multiple references to Manny getting "soft" (losing his phallus) and Lucía getting "hard" (strengthening her phallus). As Brown suggests, "These references to Lucía's 'hard' heart and Manny's 'softness' with some of his boys highlight a hard/soft binary that operates throughout the book. This hard/soft binary is one means by which gender roles are discursively articulated and, in the case of Lucía, ruptured" (95).

Lucía notices that Manny "has a thing" for one of his male gang members. Whereas this emasculates Manny and diminishes his ability to lead the group and maintain control over it, Lucía's masculinization and her romantic interest in Star Girl solidifies her control over the gang by reinscribing hegemonic masculinity. During a heated confrontation between Manny and Lucía, she attempts to exert her masculinity by challenging Manny's authority. She accuses him of being a "soft-assed man" and explains how she is the one in control of the economic structure of the gang (106). By this time, she is already dressing like the male gang members and, as Manny comments, even talking like a "vato." He attempts to dismiss her affirmation by telling her, "You ain't no vato. That's some twisted shit. Think you gotta cock on you?" (107). Lucía fires back,

> Yah . . . I gotta cock on me now, Manny. I'm the one making the money go round and round. I'm the one making sure we're not getting fucked by these lowlifes and mama's boys you got hanging all over you. You think they love you, but they don't. Especially after you're tripping on Beto. And ain't nobody gonna help you like I can. So think about it hard, honey, cause I'll walk right out of here and leave you all alone. (107)

At this point, Lucía is still trying to figure out how to take advantage of the power she has acquired thus far. She attempts to control Manny and the gang, but she is still somewhat confined to a position of inferiority because of her relationship with Manny. Another possible reading of this scene is that Lucía is actually attempting to harden Manny once again by challenging him, perhaps by being the only person "man enough" to do it. Manny responds to this challenge by

violently abusing her, to remind her that he is biologically a man while she is not. Nevertheless, she contends that after the incident she felt more empowered:

> I only got stronger. I started asking for things, making trouble, getting my own big time started. It wasn't a stretch at all. I was made to be a man, strong and tall and looking out for number one. Got stuck with a pussy, and ain't nothing you can do about it. But you see I'm tougher and meaner than any of these sorry boys. Once I got going, there wasn't nothing that could stand in my way. (109)

By controlling the drug business, Lucía controls not only the economy of the gang but also the social structure and most of the gang members. With respect to her relationship with Manny, she remains in a submissive position to some extent. However, she does learn how to manipulate him and how to use her relationship with him as a means of acquiring more authority. She controls the women in her gang as well as many of the men with whom they make drug deals. She sets the rules for *her* women, rules that stipulate what they can and can't do: "Dealing looks like a party, you got your white magic and the money's flying, all the homies acting like you're the bomb. But my rule number one around here is stay tight. Never dip in the stash, and never fuck a customer" (112).

When she discovers that Star Girl is using some of the cocaine they are selling and that she is about to have sexual intercourse with one of the customers, she interrupts the encounter, threatens the client for making moves on *her* girl, and violently beats Star Girl. Even though it hurts Lucía to "slam" Star Girl, she knows that she must do it to maintain her authority over each of the girls and the entire gang. In fact, after doing this to Star Girl, she accepts that she can have the same authority over men in the gang as well: "After I slammed Girl that day on Alvarado she never sheeped again, and I never saw her with glassy eyes neither. Good thing, too, cause I was just getting warmed up. I'd took on Manny, I'd even yelled down my favorite chica, and after that, facing up to the Lobos got to be as easy as breathing" (115). Not surprisingly, Lucía makes it a point to inform all the Lobos gang members that she will "slam hard" on any of the homeboys who get caught stealing or using the cocaine they are supposed to be selling or who become junkies. The enforcement of her rules and the punishment of those who do not abide by them are actually much stricter than Manny's. She decides to go after one of the homeboys, Bennie, who has become a junkie and who she

knows is stealing cocaine from the gang; for her, this is a sign of weakness. She assigns Manny and another homeboy, Chevy, to do the actual physical work, but she is clearly the one who controls what happens to Bennie. Bennie is summoned to a park at night presumably to receive orders to carry out a job, however, when he arrives, he is obviously high on cocaine. Rather upset, Lucía verbally threatens him, "You there a fucking junkie, homeboy . . . And that's gonna cost you. Guess we got to give you a little lesson, eh?" (119).

Lucía leans against a tree and watches Manny and Chevy violently beat Bennie until he's "crying with his fingers over his eyes, over his mouth, bent over like a wire, like a girl" (120). The scene becomes a rape scene that actually strips a homeboy of his masculinity. The interesting thing about this scene is that the aggressor is actually Lucía, a woman who has ultimately obtained authority over all members of the Lobos gang. In this scene, Manny and Chevy become docile subjects as well; they carry out the orders that she clearly makes. As she watches *her* men abuse Bennie, she gets a powerful rush because she is quite aware that she has finally obtained complete control over the entire gang, including Manny: "But I've got a rush as strong as a river running through me too. The moon's only a thin rip in the sky where the sun's shining through and I feel powerful enough to stamp it out. I could reach up and crush it in my fist, and there wouldn't be nothing left but dust" (120).

Lucía manages to construct a masculine identity that affords her several privileges within the gang: the ability to participate in leadership roles, to control others, and to manage the economic structure of the gang. In order attain such a status, she had to undergo a transformation that centered on her redefining her body in terms of gender inscriptions: learning how to walk, talk, and dress like a man, for example. Then, by assuming leadership roles and further developing a masculine identity, she was able to increase her participation in the infrastructure of the organization—eventually assuming authoritative positions that granted her control over other gang members, the socioeconomic foundation of the gang, and, subsequently, the entire gang itself. As I have shown, the socioeconomic structure of a gang depends on homosocial bonds rooted in hypermasculine identities; what *Locas* makes clear is that this has less to do with a person's sex than it does with her/his gender behavior. Women behaving as men in such a space becomes a means of attaining some semblance of autonomy, respect, capital; although this reinforces hegemonic masculinity at the expense of maintaining an anti-feminine ethos, my intention here is merely to demonstrate how

the reconfiguration of gender norms is linked to the mapping of queer identities.

Queer identities abound in *Locas*. Besides the portrayal of nonnormative gender behavior, the economic structure of the gang depends on docile members that function as pawns sustaining the gang nation and the leader (whether male or female). In this novel, the juxtaposition of nonnormative gender roles with the economic realities of the gang nation presents particularly interesting queer scenarios. In the same way that "jumping in" a gang member can be seen as an act of same-sex rape, controlling the economic structure of a gang requires dominating submissive bodies. The manner in which such relationships have been portrayed in cultural texts has several queer configurations: women controlling men, men being emasculated, homoerotic desire, and unorthodox sexual practices.

The representation of violent acts among gang members in cultural texts is used to construct identities relevant to the role that members assume within the gang nation. These identities contain several queer traits: submissive men, masculine women, homosocial bonds, and same-sex coupling. The relationship between gang members, especially the symbolic rape of initiates in "jumping in" ceremonies, is homoerotic. Gutiérrez-Jones reminds us that rape in institutional settings is precisely a manifestation of the participants' desire for one another:

> Studies of group rapes in institutional settings (fraternities are a key example) have demonstrated that the desire expressed in such acts, from the aggressor's point of view, has little if anything to do with the victim's intentions or reaction. Rather, such attacks present an opportunity for the attackers to codify their relationship among themselves, even their desire for each other. (135)

In his analysis of the film *American Me*, Gutiérrez-Jones focuses on rape and men in the prison system. In the following section, I take another look at the film to demonstrate how the representation of violence in the prison system in cultural texts is also linked to the construction of queer identities.

Rethinking *American Me*: Identity Politics and Rape Culture in Prisons

Like gangs, prisons are largely homosocial environments where external forces influence the codes of conduct and the dynamics of

personal relationships. One of the major differences between these two spaces is that unlike gangs, prisons are virtually completely isolated homosocial environments. I say virtually because despite being contained, prisoners interact and operate outside of the prison system through their contact with the outside world—visits from family members, phone calls, and letters. Also, there is an increasing amount of opposite-sex prison guards who work in these environments. Nevertheless, the majority of the time they spend incarcerated, prisoners are physically isolated with members of the same sex.

Once a subject enters a prison system, the individual is usually forced to join one of the prison gangs in order to benefit from the protection it may offer. These gangs are typically determined by race, previous gang affiliation, or geographic factors. Entering a prison, like joining a gang, requires placing individuals in a docile role, where the state acts as the aggressor. Once an individual enters this controlled space, he/she often vies with other prison members for access to and control of phallic signifiers—money, arms, drugs, and/or respect.

In his eye-opening investigation of the Aryan Brotherhood, deemed the "most murderous prison gang in America," David Grann reveals the manner in which this particular prison gang operates. The testimonies of some of the gang members reveal that respect is one of the most sought-after commodities. Respect is earned by actions, affiliation with a certain group, and the role one assumes in the economic structure of the prison; it is clearly linked to masculinity. Disrespect is not only seen as a threat to masculinity but also serves as justification for committing acts of violence. As one member of the Aryan Brotherhood explains, "We live . . . in a different society than you do. There is justified violence in our society . . . if you disrespect me or one of my friends, I will readily and to the very best of my ability engage you in a full combat mode. That's what I'm about."[13]

Grann explains that prison gangs kill for many reasons (rivalry, racism, open displays of homosexuality, and drug-related activity), but he insists that the primary reason they kill is "to impose a culture of terror that would solidify their power" (158). This culture of terror is based on the ability of a person or a group to control others, through the threat of physical and sexual violence. Michael Thompson, a member of the Aryan Brotherhood, states that he associates killing with sex, "The smell of fresh human blood can be overpowering but killing is like having sex. The first time is not so rewarding, but it gets better and better with practice" (Grann, 160). These acts of violence appear to become second nature to the inmates, primordial. One

inmate described Thompson's propensity for violence in the following manner: "Sometimes he got the urge, you know what I mean? He got the urge" (Grann, 160). The similarities between murder and rape are numerous and they are grounded in issues of power and control. In fact, according to Grann's interview with inmates, the more they rape and murder, the more powerful they feel and the easier it becomes to execute such acts.

Sexual assault among members of the same sex are common in the prison system. Grann surmises that at least twenty percent of inmates have been sexually assaulted. As a virtually isolated homosocial environment, same-sex encounters have been viewed as part of prison culture. However, like the dynamics of same-sex relationships in some cultures, the role one assumes in the encounter—that is, active/passive, penetrator/receiver—is essential to defining a subject's identity. The active person can participate in same-sex acts without compromising his masculinity or heterosexual identity, while the passive person is viewed as effeminate and often marked as being gay.[14] Overall, this has little to do with race or ethnicity. Instead, it is directly related to defined sexual roles, and possibly linked to class status. As Alfredo Mirandé explains, "Working-class white men also sodomize other men without defining themselves as homosexual. The same pattern is repeated daily in American prisons, where the strongest, most violent, and most 'macho' men attack weaker effeminate victims." [15] Therefore, to be in the passive role automatically associates an individual with weakness and femininity and places him/her in a marginal role within the institution while cementing gender and power inequalities between the victim and the rapist. When a person is raped, blame is often placed on the victim by insinuating that the individual was acting outside of acceptable gender or social norms. As Gutiérrez-Jones explains: "Rape is constructed by means of stereotypes emphasizing that violation happens to women who transgress culturally defined gender roles" (113). Similarly, rape is also used as a means to regulate men who violate gender or social codes, especially those who step outside of what Paul Kivel defines as the "Act Like a Man Box." [16]

In a prison system, displaying nonmasculine traits can often result in experiencing acts of violence and other forms of retribution. Even though same-sex relationships take place, they are seen as a necessity purportedly due to the lack of members of the opposite sex. If desire between members of the same sex is made visible, the relationship turns from a necessary component of prison culture to a homosexual relationship that can threaten the patriarchal order the gang members have often worked hard to establish. For example, in his report, Grann

explains how the Aryan Brotherhood murdered one of its fellow gang members because he made the mistake of kissing his lover on the stairs. This public display of affection was a threat to the gang's reputation, even though same-sex relationships are an everyday part of life in prison: "Although some of its members were known to receive sexual favors in return for protection, the gang considered open homosexuality a sign of weakness, a violation of the [Aryan Brotherhood] code" (166).

The codes of conduct described above are also evident in Chicana/o and Latina/o cultural texts that represent prison scenes. One of the most recognized films of this genre is *American Me*—a controversial film about gangs, violence, and life in prison that is based on a true story. In the film, the protagonist/narrator, Santana (Edward James Olmos), tells the story of his life as a gang member and as a prisoner. Through Santana, viewers learn about his childhood, adulthood, prison life, and gang life. We also learn intimate details about codes of behavior in prisons and in prison gangs.

Frederick Luis Aldama, in his essay "Penalizing Chicana/o Bodies in Edward J. Olmos's *American Me*," conducts a queer reading of the film. His analysis of the rape scenes in the film shows how Santana becomes both the "bully/top" by acting as the aggressor/penetrator in some rape scenes, as well as the "sissy/bottom" by becoming the receiver in other rape scenes. As Aldama explains, "The shift between top and bottom should be of little surprise. It's a myth that in same-sex relationship patterns sexual preference and role-playing behavior are etched in stone as a binary oppositional." [17]

Aldama also explains how the economy of the prison system is based on who controls the bodies, which act as receptacles for transferring drugs. The person or group that controls the holes used to transport drugs into the prison using both female and male bodies in the process is the one that controls the economy of the prison. The act of concealing and transporting drugs (or other types of contraband) in prison often requires that a body be penetrated in some fashion, which renders the body to be used in queer ways. Aldama describes one scene in particular where a balloon filled with cocaine flows from the vagina of a woman, through the sewer pipes of the prison, to the anus of a prisoner, and finally to the mouth and nose of other prisoners—the entire process controlled by Santana. As Aldama contends, "Santana participates in the reproduction of a desiring system that marks off the prison as the place inhabited by the fragmented, lacking subject . . . For Santana, controlling the flow of power—shit,

semen, vaginal discharge—is to effect an end: to create a sense of belonging not just in the prison, but in an outside world that alienates" (93). The use of the body as a receptacle for transferring drugs is only one of many uses of the body that shape queer identities.

Here, I look at some key scenes that demonstrate other ways characters are marked with queer traits in the film. For example, the first scene consists of a pitch-black, blank screen with a loud voice-over, which one assumes to be a prison guard commanding new prisoners. This scene takes place before the viewer has even had a chance to see who is being commanded or where the act is taking place, which encourages the viewer to visualize the scenario using the imagination and, in effect, places the viewer as recipient of the commands. The tone of the voice and the use of the plural pronouns give the viewer some insight but do not necessarily identify who the subjects are. After hearing doors close and keys rattle, the prison guard's voice shouts,

> Line up! Single file! On the bench! Let's go! Okay, open your mouth! Stick out your tongue! All right, all right, do your ears, one at a time! Okay, bend your heads over! Shake them out with your fingers! Put your hands above your heads! Hands out in front of you! Over! Move those fingers! Reach down and lift up your nut sack! Drop your nut sack and skin back your dick! Turn around! One foot at a time! Pick it up and wiggle the toes! Other foot! Okay, bend over! Grab your ass! Spread your cheeks and give me two good coughs!

As the prisoners do what they are told—opening orifices, wiggling body parts—they are penetrated by the prison guard's commands. As this scene ends, the viewer sees Santana walking out of the admissions area and into the prison. Beyond functioning as a way to introduce the main character, this scene demonstrates the immediate creation of docile subjects as they enter the prison system. The prisoner must surrender his/her body to the state apparatus, represented by the prison guard's voice. In the process, the individual is dehumanized while his/her body is marked as an asset of the state and stripped of any agency or autonomy. For men, this is clearly a form of emasculation. The scene also reveals how verbal violence functions as a means of controlling bodies by subjecting them to a form of punishment. As Foucault suggests, acts of punishment, regardless of the type, serve as a means of regulating the body:

> But we can surely accept the general proposition that, in our societies, the systems of punishment are to be situated in a certain "political economy"

> of the body: even if they do not make use of violent or bloody punishment, even when they use "lenient" methods involving confinement or correction, it is always the body that is at issue—the body and its forces, their utility and their docility, their distribution and their submission. (25)

The prison guard's commands directed not only at the prisoners in the film but also at the audience as a whole are a reminder that its members, too, do not have complete control over their own bodies. Instead, bodies belong to the state and can be forced into performing acts of submission if they act out of line. The consequences of not following the rules of society are clearly delineated throughout the narrative and serve as a warning to the viewers. Because each prisoner is subjected to a similar act prior to entering the prison system, every member of the system has been reduced to an act of submission. In fact, the incarceration of these bodies depends on the state's ability to maintain such bodies in submissive roles, the state thus acting as the ultimate aggressor. As a response to this form of aggression, emasculated subjects often do whatever is possible to assert and reclaim their masculine identities. This is done by repeating the same acts of aggression on others whom they can control, thereby creating a culture of hypermasculine aggression rooted in phallocentrism. A battle ensues over the claiming of those privileges that one can attain by securing the prized phallus. Gutiérrez-Jones explains how the state and other patriarchal institutions foment a culture of hegemonic masculinity:

> The patriarchal imperatives of both U.S. legal culture and Chicano culture have collaborated in the codification of machismo as a concept around which to ground cultural affiliation. Further, the courts and prisons act as crucial sites for this codification, a process which reached new heights in the late 1960s and early 1970s as new rhetorics of empowerment found patriarchal privilege both inside and outside Chicano communities scrambling to win or secure "entitlements" for males. (124)

Hegemonic masculinity functions as part of a state apparatus that simultaneously imposes a hypermasculine culture and oppresses institutions (or individuals) that threaten it, which creates a unique dynamic between the state and those subjects it is attempting to control. If gangs mimic the codes of the dominant culture, then they too impose a hypermasculine culture through violent aggression and attempt to oppress institutions (or individuals) that threaten their nation (e.g., other gangs and law enforcement). Undoubtedly, violence

breeds violence in such cases. An individual's response to the violence to which he is subjected is often a replication or an exaggerated form of the violence experienced. This phenomenon is evident in the rape scenes in *American Me*, where bodies are continually possessed, disembodied, violently raped, and murdered.

Aldama's analysis of the rape scenes in *American Me* illustrates how Edward James Olmos uses the rape scenes, where sodomy becomes the objective correlative, to create a film that "reproduces the anal encounter as abnormal and perverse—as an act of physical violence that leads to the mass destruction of the heterosexual matrix" (80). Moreover, he claims that acts of rape and sodomy are likened to a colonial encounter: "The film also speaks to the process of internalizing the colonial model of other-controlling and self-releasing in the act of sodomizing the exotic subject/object" (82). According to Aldama, the rape scenes between men (homosexuality) relate sodomy with death and destruction, which stand in direct opposition to heterosexuality—equated to life. Nevertheless, I posit that within the confines of the prison, sodomy and same-sex acts in general are also naturalized and intrinsically linked with homoerotic desire. Sodomy becomes a way of life for these prisoners to the extent that they may not learn or may not *choose* to practice heteronormative behavior in or outside of the prison walls.

Santana begins a life of incarceration as a teenager when he enters juvenile hall. On his first night, he is raped at knife point in the middle of the night by an Anglo juvenile offender. This is the first sexual encounter portrayed in the film that involves the leading character; he is not shown having sexual intercourse with a female until he is released from Folsom State Prison, when he appears to be in his forties. For at least twenty years, Santana has known only life among men and sex between men. Therefore, when he is released and attempts to have a relationship with Julie (Evelina Fernández)—a woman from the barrio where he was raised and where his family resides—he is utterly unsuccessful at performing as a heteronormative male. He does not know how to dance, drive a car, or kiss Julie intimately. She tries to teach him how to behave in the manner she expects a boyfriend to act.[18] However, when they try to have sexual intercourse, he gets overly aggressive and attempts to sodomize her—the only way he knows how to have sex. That this scene is juxtaposed with a prison scene that portrays the rape and murder of "the Italian" (the son of a rival drug lord) by Satana's men (at Santana's request) brings into play an interesting set of dynamics concerning erotic desire. At this stage, Santana is still the leader of the gang and he

gives orders whether in or out of prison. The manner in which the scene of Santana and Julie making love and that of the rape of the Italian by La Eme are interwoven, with the camera jumping back and forth between the two as the sexual/violent tension escalates, demonstrates the driving force behind Santana's erotic desire. Certainly, one can never prove the object of one's desire, making both homosexuality *and* heterosexuality impossible to prove because even though physical evidence might exist regarding a sexual object choice, evidence is typically impossible to attain regarding one's sexual aim. In other words, even though homosexual and heterosexual acts can be proven through physical evidence, homosexual and heterosexual desire cannot. However, in this particular scene, I maintain that the director attempts to give the observer some insight into Santana's thought processes and erotic desire during the actual intercourse. Furthermore, Santana's homoerotic desire is expressed through the juxtaposition of the images of the male-on-male rape scene and his sexual encounter with Julie where he simulates homoerotic acts. The scenes work in tandem to build the homoerotic dimension. As Santana begins kissing Julie, it appears his mind is on the rape that he ordered of the Italian. The closer the gang gets to raping their victim, the more aroused Santana gets. He becomes more and more aggressive with Julie as his sexual experience with Julie reminds him of his sexual experience with men in general (the only form of sex with which he is familiar) and with the rape that is occurring simultaneously. As the gang members violently sodomize their victim, Santana attempts to turn Julie around physically so that he can do the same to her, rejecting her vagina and turning her body and his sexual encounter with it into one that is grounded in his homosexual conditioning. The Italian is violently killed by being sodomized with a jagged knife after he is sodomized with a penis as Julie rejects Santana's attempt to sodomize her. Santana does not reach orgasm and is unable to have sex in the manner in which he is accustomed. I must emphasize that the rape scene of the Italian is highly eroticized and even though their orders are to kill the Italian, the Italian's body is used first to satisfy the erotic desire of the gang, for they all participate in some way with his rape by either tying him down or anally penetrating him first with a penis (an act that cannot take place without being erotically stimulated) and later by penetrating him with the jagged knife (an extension of the phallus). As mentioned earlier, these violent acts of rape are a manifestation of the participants' desire for one another. By engaging in some way with the rape, even if it is solely through observation or, as in the case of Santana, by ordering the murder of

the victim and then fantasizing about it, these men engage in a veritable orgy where there are strict rules for satisfying such desire.[19] I must also point out that violence becomes a necessary component of that desire as portrayed in this film. Obviously, the violent acts of aggression arouse the men and enable them to perform homoerotic acts, which supports the notion that some prisoners associate violence and murder with sex, as mentioned in my discussion of the Aryan Brotherhood. Certainly, this is at the expense of emasculating the victim, converting him to a nonentity, and injuring or murdering the victim. As Gutiérrez-Jones suggests with respect to the Italian, "The rape and subsequent murder of the new internee—he is sodomized with a saw—'feminize' the victim to send out a broader challenge that will resonate with gang competitors who likewise depend on a manipulation of the desire among men" (142). Therefore, homoerotic desire is an element of these violent acts that should not be overlooked, as troubling as it may be to accept. I am by no means suggesting that violence is necessary to carry out homoerotic acts; however, I am trying to show that the representation of rape in prison settings in cultural texts is associated with constructing queer identities where characters are subjected to nonnormative gender and sexual roles.

Not surprisingly, Santana returns to prison, where the rape and murder of male bodies by other male bodies is a way of life. He has since undergone a transformation that enables him to show compassion on some level, and his gang members see it as a sign that he is weakening. He is ultimately stabbed to death in a violent gang-rape fashion by his own homeboys.

As I have shown, the portrayal of prison culture in *American Me* includes the depiction of queer identities. In the film, prisoners are subjected to submissive roles that undermine their autonomy and their masculinity. Individuals are first controlled, possessed, and disembodied by the state. In turn, they attempt to recover their masculinity by creating and engaging in a culture driven by hypermasculine behavior, where rape and violence not only become a part of every day life but also serve as a necessary component of the acting out of homoerotic desire. The film demonstrates the way subjects vie for power via controlling, possessing, and using other bodies, which includes homosexual acts that center on homoerotic desire. These characters are not heteronormative and, therefore, their identities are queer. Although this particular depiction of queer identities is extremely negative, violent, and disturbing, it is one that is commonly reproduced in cultural texts (e.g., the HBO series *Oz*). The portrayal of

such characters can certainly have serious negative consequences regarding the way men in prison and in gangs are perceived. Nevertheless, the fact that several artists and directors have opted to depict some men in this fashion makes these characters necessary subjects to include in an analysis of this nature.

Man(u)fractured Women: Violence and Queer Identities in Chicana Narratives

Females have historically been the victims of systematic violence on multiple levels. An overwhelming majority of such violence has been committed by males who have undeniably been privileged and empowered in patriarchal societies, whereas women and their bodies have tended to be undervalued and sites of abuse. In her study "Re/membering the Body: Latina Testimonies of Social and Family Violence," Yvette Flores-Ortiz argues that women's bodies are the sites where their oppression is recorded, both physically and metaphorically.[20] The effects of such violence are multifaceted, with consequences ranging from lowered self-esteem to rape and death.

For Chicanas and Latinas violence has a lengthy trajectory that is rooted in colonialism and Catholicism—both treat females and their bodies as possessions of the Catholic Church, the colonizer, and, in general, males. As Ana Castillo contends in *Massacre of the Dreamers: Essays on Xicanisma*:

> The Catholic Church has enforced female sexual repression within our culture with a vengeance. Woman is not only man's property through the sanctification of the church, but her children also belong to him and the church. The violence of European colonization and enslavement of primal peoples, always had the blessing of the church, which was and remains a wealthy institution. (128)

Castillo adds that the objectification of females in society "has been the result of man's enforced economic dominance and spiritual repression over humankind" (127), acknowledging the role that economic factors play in placing women in such positions. She insists that all these factors come into play to create a misogynist society where females are victims of violence and reduced to the property of men:

> Hypothesizing such gross possibilities also suggests a heterosexist, ultimately misogynist, mentality, implying that women would want to enforce the same distorted aesthetic values of objectification that they have suffered under patriarchal capitalism. Finally, we must not overlook

> the extent of violence that accompanies woman's reduction to a "sexual play thing." Historically, women have not, as a rule, reduced men to sexual property or otherwise physically abused men. (128)

With respect to rape, Castillo contends that it has more to do with misogyny than sex: "Rape has nothing to do with sex, but the violence is evidence of the misogyny integral to our society" (129). She explains the way women have historically been associated with the body as a perishable object that has no value and that is the property of men (143). Kathleen Barry sees this as a form of slavery, which she deems "female sexual slavery":

> Female sexual slavery is present in ALL situations where women or girls cannot change the conditions of their existence; where regardless of how they got into those conditions, e.g., social pressure, economic hardship, misplaced trust or the longing for affection, they cannot get out; and where they are subject to sexual violence and exploitation.[21]

In 2004, an unnerving article by journalist Peter Landesman in the *New York Times Magazine*, "The Girls Next Door," revealed disturbing details of the undercover world of sex trafficking, involving thousands of immigrant girls and women from around the world, the majority of them from Mexico.[22] These girls and women are enticed by the promise of a job and a better life in the United States, only to have their bodies imprisoned and used by sex-trafficking rings and their leaders to make an unprecedented amount of money. One estimate suggests that there are anywhere from thirty thousand to fifty thousand sex slaves held in captivity against their will in the United States alone at any given time. To hold them in captivity, they are first raped and sexually brutalized as a form of "preparation" and indoctrination into a life of sexual servitude. The victims are sold to transporters, who may continue to exchange them until a buyer assumes possession and rents them out for sex. Their body parts and the sexual acts the clients perform on them are assigned precise dollar amounts. For instance, for $4.50 the client buys the right to remove the slave's bra, for $1.80 they are permitted to engage in "acrobatic positions." Profits are maximized by increasing the demand and the productivity by using the body as many times as possible with as many clients as possible. According to Landesman's investigation, "Working at the brutalizing pace of 20 men per day, a girl could earn her captors as much as $2,000 a week [in Mexico]. In the U.S., that same girl could bring in perhaps $30,000 per week."[23]

If the girl/woman tries to escape, she is severely beaten or killed; she is also subjected to continual psychological and physical abuse to keep her unbalanced and disoriented so that she is more easily controlled. This is only one brutal example of how the female body becomes a commodity of exchange and how females can be disembodied through violence. The girls and women who become victims of the sex traffickers are, for the most part, undocumented immigrants who do not speak English and who have very little recourse for getting out of their situations. These bodies are forced to participate in queer acts; they are not used in a heteronormative fashion or context. Instead, they are separated into pieces that are assigned a monetary value to be exchanged or rented out by their owners.[24] These bodies are also forced into sexual roles to satisfy the multiple forms of erotic desire expressed by their abusers, which become increasingly nonheteronormative and violent. For example, they are forced to play roles, like the therapist's patient, the obedient daughter, or the schoolgirl, often dressed for the part. The roles and sex acts are varied and unorthodox, ranging from S&M to sodomy. And for those who are slaves in the United States, the roles appear to be much more violent. As one victim remarked, "In America we had 'special jobs.' Oral sex, anal sex, often with many men. Sex is now more adventurous, harder" (67). She claimed that men in the United States have become so desensitized to normative sexual behavior that their acts have become much more violent and aggressive. All these acts are queer. Once again, my use of the term *queer* is solely to describe the nonheteronormative social and sexual traits of the perpetrators of violence and their victims: nonconsensual sex, slavery, role-playing, sodomy, and other nonnormative sexual practices.

I use this example to demonstrate an extreme case of how the female body is subjected to violence and forced to perform nonheteronormative acts. Now, I turn to the way violence exacted upon the female body has been portrayed in Chicana/Latina cultural production and the implications that is has on constructing queer identities. There are myriad examples one could use for such an analysis, for violence is and has always been prevalent in Chicana/Latina narratives, especially the rape-as-metaphor construct that is rooted in the La Malinche archetype and colonialism in general. As Herrera-Sobek explains,

> As members of an ethnic minority, as thus doubly marginalized, Chicana authors are vitally concerned with the inferior status they have been relegated. The Chicana writer has therefore taken the

> concept of rape and has successfully elaborated it in her writings as a literary motif in order to engage the reader in a reconstruction of the experience from the victim's perspective and from a feminist point of view. (243)

Rape, and violence in general, have become common and integral themes in Chicana/Latina cultural production. Moreover, Herrera-Sobek suggests that rape is used in Chicana/Latina texts not only to reconstruct the experience and tell the story but also as a critique of a patriarchal society that clearly practices various forms of misogyny (246).

Chicana/Latina cultural production has often included depictions of acts of violence, especially with respect to women's lives and experiences. Recently, a spate of texts have centered on the murder of Mexican women: Lourdes Portillo's documentary *Señorita extraviada* (2001), Alicia Gaspar de Alba's novel *Desert Blood: The Juarez Murders* (2005), and Stella Pope Duarte's novel *If I Die in Juárez* (2008). In creating these texts, these artists—along with other artists such as playwright Rubén Amavizca (*The Women of Juárez*, 2003) and film director/producer Gregory Nava (*Bordertown*, 2006)—have made an attempt to bring to the forefront the issue of the hundreds of raped, murdered, and missing women of Mexico in the maquiladora industry in Ciudad Juárez. These women and their bodies have been subjected to the same sort of objectification and violence that the girls and women who are trafficked do: they first become fractured, disposable women as employees of the maquiladoras that exploit them and then, in several cases, become victims of an undercover murder ring that targets young women with similar physical characteristics.[25] Although there is currently much activism from various groups along the border and in the international community, activist organizations have been unable to stop the murders or to improve working and living conditions for these women/girls. These victims are subjected to extreme forms of rape and physical violence; they are sexually abused, disfigured, and dismembered.[26] In portraying these victims in cultural texts, these artists highlight the injustices that some women/girls face while legitimizing their lives by telling their stories and not allowing them or the situation to be dismissed and forgotten.

I turn now to another form of violence that is prevalent in Chicana/Latina cultural texts: violence in the domestic space. I maintain that the representation of violence and rape in our cultural texts is often linked to the construction of queer identities. In several Chicana and

Latina narratives, women reject men and heteronormative social and sexual behavior after being a victim of rape and violence. These women exclude men from their lives in order to gain control over their own bodies and their own lives. Alta, the leading character of Alma Luz Villanueva's novel *Naked Ladies*, is a good example. She manages to overcome the domestic violence she experiences by first addressing her economic dependence on her husband, Hugh, who frivolously spends the household finances before she can get her hands on the money in order to pay the bills and put food on the table. She begins her quest toward independence by picking up Hugh's check at work on Fridays, before he does.

Although she manages to control some aspect of the household finances, Alta remains confined to her sexual role with Hugh, who is struggling with his gay identity and tries to force Alta into performing nonheteronormative sexual acts, like anal intercourse and fellatio. Her financial dependence on him places her in a submissive position socially and sexually; she is also obligated to perform sexual acts that satisfy his homoerotic desire. In essence, via Hugh's sexual aim, her identity is queered by the imposed masculinization of her body as well as by the acts in which it is forced to engage.

Nevertheless, what the reader witnesses throughout the novel is Alta's transformation. On one particular night, after a family quarrel, Hugh tries to rape her. For the first time, Alta refuses to have sex with him. She responds to his request for her to have oral intercourse in the following manner: "You know, Hugh, if you just want someone to suck you off, why don't you pay someone to do it."[27] Evidence that Alta's financial dependence continues to contribute to her repression is revealed in Hugh's response, which he makes as he attempts to rape her: "I pay you every Friday, remember?" (97). On this occasion, Alta does not submit to Hugh. She hits him in the face and then again in the groin area. Hugh punches her in the face, and then the children interrupt the fight. Alta threatens to kill him if he stays the night in the house and forces him to leave.

In the process of facilitating her autonomy, Alta begins to experiment with her own sexuality. It is the relationship with her husband and the physical, emotional, and psychological violence she experienced in her marriage that motivate her to bond with other women and to explore alternative sexualities. She learns about lesbianism when her friend Katie reveals, while the two are alone in bed, that her first lover was a woman; she then asks Alta if she has ever made love to a woman. Katie teaches Alta about sex between women: "It's like making love to your mother, finally. And it's like making love

to yourself, in a way, discovering the taste and feel of yourself in another woman. The taboo breasts, Mom's nipples" (128). Katie and Alta do not participate fully in sexual intercourse, but Alta is enlightened by her response, and this leads the way to her first homoerotic encounter with her friend Jackie. The experience is Alta's first sexual encounter that excludes a male or any type of masculine role:

> They came in circles of sorrow, in circles of joy—crying, then laughing together. Circles of ecstasy electrified their bodies from head to foot, and they came again: mouth to cunt, tongue to clitoris, soul to soul, woman to woman. Without man. They died, slowly, into swirling pools of utter pleasure. They remembered a woman's selfish, hungry, howling, singing pleasure to be food, to be fed. Without man. They searched for the hot, life-giving, creative, and golden sun. Without man. (157)

This female-centered eroticism not only renders both women completely satisfied but also minimizes the significance of the male phallus by making it virtually obsolete. The result is the construction of the female phallus, which possesses a certain amount of the power that is traditionally and automatically granted solely to men. Judith Butler insists that the lesbian phallus "both recalls and displaces the masculinism by which it is impelled," and simultaneously becomes a female figure of power which emerges from "erotegenic pleasure."[28]

Alta's empowerment during this exploratory stage allows her to assume whatever roles she *chooses*. She begins to demolish the compulsory heterosexual, as well as homosexual, models of sexuality that have been inscribed in her by both a patriarchal society and her husband's homoerotic desire. As a result, she begins to develop her own sexuality, one that no longer maintains her as a "female sexual slave." In her ensuing sexual encounters, gender roles are obfuscated by inverting sexual roles in her relationship with both women and men.

It is in the latter part of the novel that Alta's personal independence and sexual liberation come to fruition. The novel skips ahead approximately five years. By this time Hugh has died of AIDS. Having completed her counseling degree, Alta is teaching at the university. Her complete financial independence and her overall autonomy foster her freedom. She falls in love with a female Asian student, Jade, and a man named Michael at the same time. She maintains both relationships without making a full commitment to either individual. Her

true liberation is manifested in her encounter with both of her lovers simultaneously:

> Michael's lips were on hers, pressing gently. Then Jade was stroking her breasts and moaning, and Michael's tongue was inside her mouth exploring her, and it all felt new, so new, as though she'd never made love before. A small fraction, a very small fraction, of herself began to censor this unbelievable, almost unbearable, pleasure these two people who she loved were giving her. No, it was unbearable, and she felt like thrashing and screaming and rolling into the hot, living fire, but she contained herself, and she simply stopped listening to that small fraction of herself that always said NO. That said, No one loves you and you love no one. (259)

It is evident that by the end of the novel, Alta has gained full control over her body and become very comfortable with nonheteronormative sexual acts. Her queer identity is shaped by her unique erotic interests. It is important to note that Alta does not assume a lesbian, heterosexual, or bisexual identity. I argue that she rejects any standard classification of sexuality. The identity she has developed is uniquely Alta's regardless of what her sexual object choice is at any particular time. It is also evident that Alta's sexual aim has become her own personal satisfaction. Her "sexual orientation" has, in effect, become her sexual *dis*orientation. Alta has managed to circumvent the rigid heterosexual and homosexual (as inscribed by her husband) paradigms of gender and sexuality. Once again, her identity is queer; in this case, however, it is due to her own erotic interests and choices.

As in *Naked Ladies*, most of the women in Ana Castillo's *So Far from God* are the victims of emotional, psychological, verbal, and physical violence. In this novel, the matriarch, Sofía—also known as La Abandonada—has been abandoned by her husband and left alone to raise her four daughters in the small town of Tome, New Mexico. The novel centers on their struggle to survive in a patriarchal, machista, and misogynist society where virtually all women are the victims of multiple forms of violence committed by men.

Sofía and her daughters do not follow the gender norms prescribed by either Anglo culture or Chicano/Latino culture. Not one of the daughters gets married, has children, and lives a heteronormative lifestyle. Instead, they all develop highly queer identities. For example, La Loca Santa, the youngest daughter, earns her name when she returns from the dead and develops mystical characteristics. She is repulsed by

the smell of humans, prefers the company of animals, levitates, has powerful visions, heals the wounded, and becomes the only daughter who never leaves home. In her conversation with Father Jerome, Sofía tells him, "God gave me four daughters . . . and you would have thought that by now I would be a content grandmother, sitting back and letting my daughters care for me, bringing me nothing but their babies on my lap! But no, not my hijitas! I had to produce the kind of species that flies!"[29] By daughters that "fly," she refers to the resurrection of La Loca, a dream that another daughter (Caridad) has about flying and being chased by the devil, and the fact that Esperanza, her eldest daughter (a journalist), flies to the Persian Gulf on an assignment and disappears. Daughters that "fly" could also very well be interpreted as daughters who are queer. They all diverge from the norms associated with being a woman in a traditional family structure. Not one has a traditional marriage or family and each is subjected to acts of violence. Sofía's four daughters end up dying before their mother does, however, they also acquire out-of-this-world mystical or saintly features that make their queer status highly revered. In this way, Sofía, who manages to become the mayor of Tome, becomes the president of Mothers Of Martyrs And Saints (M.O.M.A.S.). Although each of the female characters in the novel is in her own way queer, it suffices to focus on one of the daughters, Caridad.

In the beginning, Caridad is an extremely social, beautiful, and lively woman. She marries her high school sweetheart, Memo, but he cheats on her less than two weeks after their marriage and he maintains a relationship with an ex-girlfriend for almost a year. Caridad does get pregnant by him, but La Loca assists her in carrying out at least three abortions. Memo decides to join the marines and leaves Caridad. She then begins having multiple sexual encounters with many men, determined not to fall in love again with anyone. This is all in and of itself queer: the abortions, the love triangle, and the promiscuity phase. However, on one particular night, Caridad comes home "as mangled as a stray cat having been left for dead by the side of the road" (32). Sofía was informed that "her daughter's nipples had been bitten off. She had also been scourged with something, branded like cattle. Worst of all, a tracheotomy was performed because she had also been stabbed in the throat" (33).

Caridad becomes a phantasm of sorts: deformed, unable to talk, practically floating around the house. To add insult to injury, she is completely disillusioned and devastated that her attackers were never found and that the assault was basically dismissed by the police. The incident itself and the lack of interest in her case exhibited by the

male-dominated police department lead to Caridad's dramatic transformation, one that is possible thanks to La Loca.

La Loca miraculously restores Caridad's natural beauty and makes her whole again. Despite looking like her original self, she is not the same. She enters another dimension that is devoid of men and that allows her to explore alternative relationships that are now centered on females. In fact, her first intimate relationship after the mauling is with a mare named Corazón. After developing a loving relationship, they move out of her mother's house together, living alone as companions: "Corazón had become Caridad's only companion" (44). The horse and Caridad form an intimate bond with each other and they become inseparable. When Caridad returns to her work as a nurse's aide at the hospital (so that she can afford to feed herself and Corazón), the mare attempts to follow her. One evening, Corazón follows Caridad and is killed by the sheriff's deputy and his partner, who claimed she had broken her hoof trying to cross a cattle guard and that they felt they had no other choice. Again, Caridad's love life is destroyed by men, violently.

After the death of the mare, Caridad becomes infatuated with a woman—someone she sees on an outing who happens to be sitting on a wall. Initially, the woman is referred to as Woman-on-the-wall until Caridad discovers her real name, Esmeralda. When Caridad first sees the indigenous-looking woman, she does not understand her bodily response and her subsequent obsession with her. Even though she recognizes that she is very attracted to Esmeralda, thinks she is "the most beautiful woman she had ever seen," and claims that "she could not bear the thought of living without that woman" (79), Caridad's naïveté with respect to same-sex relationships and, evidently, some form of internalized homophobia, force her to retreat and hide in a cave for a year instead of acting on her desire. Caridad may also fear that if she allows herself to fall in love again, the object of her affection will once again be taken away from her.

While cloistered in the cave—away from men for a prolonged period of time—Caridad develops supernatural powers. When she is discovered a year later, men try to carry her away and take her home, but she transforms her body into lead, overpowering the men and forcing them to leave her alone. She never allows her body to become the possession of men again. The news of her supernatural powers spreads and she becomes a saint of sorts; she is compared to the "ghost of Lozen, Warm Springs Apache mystic woman warrior, sister of the great chief Victorio who had vowed 'to make war against the white man forever' " (88).

One day, Esmeralda happens upon Caridad, removes her from the cave, bathes her, and reintegrates her into modern civilization. Caridad further develops her supernatural powers. She becomes a *curandera* and a clairvoyant, and then she dedicates herself to helping women discover the true nature of the men in their lives, fomenting more female-centered homosocial bonds. For example, when one woman asks her about her husband's fidelity, she places his underwear under her pillow and concentrates on him for three days and nights. On the fourth night she sees the husband in a dream, "sneaking through the bedroom window of his neighbor at night" (118). In her essay "Forms of Chicana Feminist Resistance: Hybrid Spirituality in Ana Castillo's *So Far from God*," Theresa Delgadillo claims that Caridad's transformation from a victim of violence to someone who resists the oppression that maintains women in marginal roles demonstrates that "both men and women can alter the underlying reasons for violence against women." [30]

In this novel, all the men are perpetrators of violence. They are the principal source of the aggression and oppression experienced by the women. One good example is Francisco el Penitente, a religious fanatic who falls in love with Caridad. Initially, he considers Caridad a chaste woman, especially after she spent the year isolated in the cave. However, when unsuccessful at establishing an intimate relationship with Caridad, he maintains a vigil over Caridad's trailer, basically stalking her daily. One day, he discovers that Caridad has some sort of a relationship/friendship with two women, María and Esmeralda. As he finds out more about the women through Doña Felicia, the neighbor, he concludes that the two women are lesbians. Even though the term *lesbian* is not used throughout the novel, the author gives many of the women a number of traits associated with a lesbian identity, and, as Adrienne Rich would suggest, the bonds that form between the women certainly fall somewhere along a lesbian continuum. Francisco becomes jealous of the relationship Caridad has with these women and begins stalking them as well. The bond between Caridad and Esmeralda grows stronger, but their ability to have a relationship becomes impossible due to several factors: internalized homophobia, María (Esmeralda's jealous lover), and Francisco, who continues to stalk them. One day, Caridad and Esmeralda drive to a place called Sky City. Once again, Francisco follows them. At Sky City, Caridad and Esmeralda reach some sort of an epiphany regarding their relationship and their feelings for one another; knowing the barriers that exist for establishing a same-sex relationship, they escape from an unjust society by running and jumping off of a high mesa

and committing suicide while holding hands, very much in a Thelma and Louise fashion. The women's bodies are never discovered, but the narrative suggests that they live happily ever after in another dimension:

> But much to all of their surprise, there were no morbid remains of splintered bodies tossed to the ground, down, down, like bad pottery or glass or old bread. There weren't even whole bodies lying peaceful. There was nothing.
>
> Just the spirit deity Tsichtinako calling loudly with a voice like wind, guiding the two women back, not out toward the sun's rays or up to the clouds but down, deep within the soft, moist dark earth where Esmeralda and Caridad would be safe and live forever. (211)

The suicide of Esmeralda and Caridad is the only way they can live their lives together, as female lovers. In this manner, they are able to escape homophobia, misogyny, and patriarchy. They manage to subvert these elements of oppression by taking control of their bodies through desperate and violent means. By destroying their physical bodies, which are constantly threatened, controlled, and abused by men, the women take possession of their spirits and they are able to create a female-centered or lesbian relationship in another dimension. Another possible reading of the suicide is offered by Delgadillo: "Caridad and Esmeralda's leap from the top of the mesa at Acoma poignantly illustrates the idea that humans are of nature, rather than above nature" (900). She adds, "At first, this scene might appear to minimize the demise of two women who have been stalked by an obviously disturbed man. The text conveys, however, the intertwining relationships between human and natural worlds in its vision of a world beneath ours" (901). This scene can thus be considered the birth of a loving, women-centered relationship devoid of the threat posed by the men present in the novel.

As a victim of male violence, Caridad, like Alta in *Naked Ladies* and other women in both novels, is forced to reconfigure her traditional notions of love and sexual relationships. In part as a response to the oppression and violence they experience under a patriarchal society, these women form homosocial bonds with other women at the exclusion of men. These bonds allow them to regain control of their lives, shifting them from a state of being fractured and objectified, to one where they are whole, human, and autonomous, and where female-centered desire takes precedence. These women, both as victims of violence and after their subsequent transformations, have queer identities.

The former relegates their bodies to nonnormative social and sexual behavior dictated by the perpetrator of violence, while the latter leads the way to exploring nonnormative social and sexual behavior that centers on their own desire at the exclusion of men's desire and actions. The female characters in these novels demonstrate the way depictions of violence in cultural texts might be associated with constructing queer identities. In both cases, after experiencing acts of rape and violence exacted by men, the women engage in nonheteronormative relationships through their own free will.

CONCLUSION: THE REPRESENTATION OF VIOLENCE AND QUEER IDENTITIES

Violence has become a common theme in Chicana/o and Latina/o cultural production. In an attempt to understand the representations of violence in gang culture, prison culture, and the domestic arena, I have shown how violence shapes queer identities in cultural texts. My analysis of violence in these three areas demonstrates how the body is initially converted to a docile one and assigned a submissive role. On occasion, the subject attempts to regain power or agency by acquiring phallic traits (power, money, drugs, respect), and it typically does so at the expense of relegating others to the same inferior, submissive state to which it has been subjected, as seen in my analysis of gang and prison culture in Chicana/o and Latina/o cultural texts. Moreover, as the victim of violence, characters are subjected to multiple nonnormative social and sexual acts that map them with queer configurations. Additionally, I have shown how characters that have been forcibly queered through violence may choose to develop queer identities after experiencing such violence. In each of these areas, violence or rape, whether literal or metaphorical, is used in an attempt to control others for the personal desire and/or economic gain of either the perpetrator or the representative patriarchal order. As seen in my examination of various cultural texts, Chicana/o and Latina/o protagonists subjected to violence and rape are queer in multiple ways. In this analysis, I was interested specifically in the role that violence and rape play in shaping queer identities. Therefore, where violent acts are represented in Chicana/o and Latina/o cultural texts, queer identities may also be present. Once again, naming something queer is not intended to be associated with any particular value; instead, it can be used to examine a wide range of complex social and sexual behaviors that digress from heteronormativity and shape identities.

Notes

Introduction

1. As quoted by Michael Musto in his "La Dolce Musto" column of *The Village Voice*, June 8, 2004.
2. Alexander Doty, *Flaming Classics: Queering the Film Canon* (New York: Routledge, 2000), 8.
3. David William Foster, *El ambiente nuestro: Chicano/Latino Homoerotic Writing* (Tempe, AZ: Bilingual Press/Editorial Bilingüe, 2006), 7.
4. Eve Kosofsky Sedgwick, *Tendencies* (Durham, NC: Duke University Press, 1993), xii.
5. Alexander Doty, *Making Things Perfectly Queer: Interpreting Mass Culture* (Minneapolis: University of Minnesota Press, 1993), 12 (italics mine).
6. Doty, *Flaming Classics*, 4.
7. Gloria Anzaldúa, *Borderlands/La Frontera: The New Mestiza* (San Francisco, CA: Aunt Lute Books: 1987), 79.

1. Queer Machos: Gender, Sexuality, Beauty, and Chicano/Latino Men

1. Ilán Stavans, "The Latin Phallus," in *Muy Macho: Latino Men Confront Their Manhood*, ed. Ray González (New York: Doubleday, 1996), 156.
2. J.F. Cross and J. Cross, "Age, Sex, Race, and the Perception of Facial Beauty," *Developmental Psychology* 5, no. 3 (1971): 433–39; D.M. Jones and K. Hill, "Criteria of Facial Attractiveness in Five Populations," *Human Nature* 4, no. 3 (1993): 271–96 ; V.S. Johnston and M. Franklin, "Is Beauty in the Eye of the Beholder?" *Ethology and Sociobiology* 14, no. 3 (1993): 183–99.
3. Lesley Higgins, *The Modernist Cult of Ugliness* (New York: Palgrave Macmillan, 2002), 24.
4. David William Foster, *El ambiente nuestro: Chicano/Latino Homoerotic Writing* (Tempe: Bilingual Press/Editorial Bilingüe, 2006), 8.
5. Alfredo Mirandé, *Hombres y machos: Masculinity and Latino Culture* (Boulder, CO: Westview Press, 1998), 66.
6. Jaime Manrique, *Eminent Maricones: Arenas, Lorca, Puig, and Me* (Madison: University of Wisconsin Press, 1999), 112.

7. José Piedra, "Nationalizing Sissies," in *¿Entiendes?: Queer Readings, Hispanic Writings*, ed. Emilie L. Bergmann and Paul Julian Smith (Durham, NC: Duke University Press, 1995), 375.
8. Michael P. Levine, *Gay Macho: The Life and Death of the Homosexual Clone* (New York: New York University Press, 1998); Michelangelo Signorile, *Life Outside: The Signorile Report on Gay Men: Sex, Drugs, Muscles, and the Passages of Life* (New York: HarperPerennial, 1997).
9. Susan Bordo, "Beauty (Re)Discovers the Male Body," in *Beauty Matters*, ed. Peg Zeglin Brand (Bloomington: Indiana University Press, 2000), 122.
10. Mick LaSalle, *Dangerous Men: Pre-Code Hollywood and the Birth of the Modern Man* (New York: St. Martin's Press, 2002); André Soares, *Beyond Paradise: The Life of Ramon Novarro* (New York: St. Martin's Press, 2002).
11. Levine, *Gay Macho*, 29.
12. Signorile, *Life Outside*, xix.
13. Although Rechy's father was of Scottish descent, both his parents were born in Mexico.
14. For an analysis of the way John Rechy and the protagonists of several of his novels are one and the same, see Daniel Enrique Pérez, "Masculinity (Re)Defined: Masculinity, Internalized Homophobia, and the Gay Macho Clone in the Works of John Rechy," in *Beginning a New Millennium of Chicana and Chicano Scholarship*, ed. Jaime H. García (Berkeley: Inkworks Press, 2006), 241–55. An extended version of the research is available as an M.A. thesis under the same title at Arizona State University (2000).
15. The term *mano* is short for *hermano*, meaning "brother." It is used primarily among Chicano/Latino men to greet one another informally while highlighting their kinship.
16. Judith Butler, *Bodies That Matter: On the Discursive Limits of "Sex"* (New York: Routledge, 1993), 170.
17. Pérez, "Masculinity (Re)Defined," 241–55.
18. For an analysis of the role masculinity plays in the legal profession, see Jennifer Pierce, "Rambo Litigators: Emotional Labor in a Male-Dominated Occupation," in *Gender and Work in Today's World: A Reader*, ed. Nancy E. Sacks and Catherine Marrone (Boulder, CO: Westview Press, 2004), 65–86.
19. Foster, *El ambiente nuestro*, 81.
20. He makes similar moves throughout the series.
21. Tomás Almaguer, "Chicano Men: A Cartography of Homosexual Identity and Behavior," *Differences* 3, no. 2 (1993): 78.
22. Luis Alfaro, "Cuerpo Politizado," in *Uncontrollable Bodies: Testimonies of Identity and Culture*, ed. Rodney Sappington and Tyler Stallings (Seattle: Bay Press, 1994), 219.
23. Foster, *El ambiente nuestro*, 153.

24. Guillermo Reyes, *Deporting the Divas*, *Gestos: Teoría y práctica del teatro hispánico* 27 (1999): 115.
25. Ibid., 116.
26. Butler, *Bodies That Matter*, 170.
27. Jeanne Carstensen, "Alex Donis, Visual Artist: A Kiss Is Not a Kiss," *The Gate* (1997), http://sfgate.com/eguide/profile/arc97/1031donis-profile.shtml.
28. Ibid.
29. Richard T. Rodríguez, "Queering the Homeboy Aesthetic," *Aztlán* 31, no. 2 (2006): 127.
30. A combination of reggae, Latin American, and hip-hop musical styles that has become popular in the United States and abroad.
31. Obregón is a common last name, the name of a former general and president of Mexico, Álvaro Obregón, and a city in northern Mexico.
32. Especially their plays *A Bowl of Beings, The Mission*, and *Radio Mambo.*
33. Especially his performance pieces *Mambo Mouth*, *Spic-O-Rama*, *Freak*, and *Sexaholix.*
34. Especially his pieces "El mandilón," "El valiente," and "Toma tiempo."

2. (Re)Examining the Latin Lover: Screening Chicano/Latino Sexualities

1. As quoted in Victoria Thomas's, *Hollywood's Latin Lovers: Latino, Italian and French Men Who Make the Screen Smolder* (Santa Monica, CA: Angel City Press, 1998), 34.
2. Although Valentino and Novarro are often considered the first Latin lovers in film, Antonio Moreno made his debut in 1912, thereby predating the two. See Thomas, *Hollywood's Latin Lovers*, 37. I must also note that the Latin lover has roots in the infamous Don Juan character, which can be traced all the way back to seventeenth-century Spain; the Italian counterparts are Romeo and Casanova.
3. Ibid., 9.
4. Susan Bordo, "Beauty (Re)Discovers the Male Body," in *Beauty Matters*, ed. Peg Zeglin Brand (Bloomington: Indiana University Press, 2000), 122–23.
5. John Leguizamo, *Mambo Mouth*, directed by Thomas Schlamme (New York: Island Visual Arts, 1992).
6. The expression "lavender marriage" came into use during the 1920s when Hollywood began imposing morality contracts. It refers to marriages of convenience orchestrated to protect an actor's reputation and career. The legendary William Hames is largely associated with the proliferation of lavender marriages after his career was destroyed for trying to live openly as a gay man; Rock Hudson is perhaps one of the most cited examples of a gay male actor who participated in a lavender marriage.

7. In his biography, Arnaz quotes Ball as saying: "*Too Many Girls* was not only the title of your first show, it is the story of your life" (*A Book* [New York: William Morrow, 1976], 93).
8. In its original form, Lucille Ball and Desi Arnaz were to play themselves—two successful and busy artists trying to make their marriage work. In an effort to make a show with which more people could identify, they created the second format, which ended up working successfully. See Arnaz, *A Book*, 199.
9. Alexander Doty, *Making Things Perfectly Queer: Interpreting Mass Culture* (Minneapolis: University of Minnesota Press, 1993), 45–48.
10. "Carlos Slam," *Mind of Mencia*, Comedy Central, season 3, episode. no. 304. First aired April 15, 2007.
11. Ibid.
12. The Latin lover's body and looks have been used in this way for almost a century in U.S. popular culture. López's identity as a sex object is not much different from that of Ramón Novarro, with the exception that López's look has become more mainstream than ethnic. He is not viewed as being exotic, but as the purveyor of a beauty standard for all men.
13. Bryan Alexander, "Mario Lopez: No More Going Shirtless," *People* online (September 15, 2008), http://www.people.com/people/article/0,,20225738,00.html. This statement created a mini scandal that was labeled Chesthairgate. Pictures surfaced of him with chest hair. Why was this a scandal? Well, just a few weeks earlier when asked in *People* if he "manscaped" (shaved parts of his body), he responded, "Not at all. That's the Latin Indian blood in me. My dad has a hairy chest, but I don't" (Antoinette Coulton and Monica Rizzo, "Mario Lopez Bares All!" *People* 69, no. 25 [June 30, 2008], 62).
14. López was asked to reprise his role as Dr. Mike Hamoui in *Nip/Tuck*. Although they will probably not repeat his famous shower scene, his body will inevitably be on erotic display in some way.
15. Coulton and Rizzo, "Mario Lopez Bares All!" 60.
16. For an analysis of the gay macho clone, see Michael P. Levine, *Gay Macho: The Life and Death of the Homosexual Clone* (New York: New York University Press, 1998); Michelangelo Signorile, *Life Outside: The Signorile Report on Gay Men: Sex, Drugs, Muscles, and the Passages of Life* (New York: HarperPerennial, 1997).
17. Notice the erasure of his Latino identity. Once again the Latin lover becomes countryless. My best guess is that the producers assigned him Middle Eastern markings in order to make his character more believable. Who ever heard of a Latino doctor, right?
18. This role reversal is especially interesting if one considers that Ramón Novarro's leading role in the original *Ben-Hur* (1925) was replaced by Charlton Heston in 1959.
19. Coulton and Rizzo, "Mario Lopez Bares All!" 57.
20. Ibid., 68–69.

3. (Re)Reading the Chicano Literary Canon

1. José Antonio Villarreal, *Pocho* (New York: Anchor Books, 1989), 95.
2. Alexander Doty, *Flaming Classics: Queering the Film Canon* (New York: Routledge, 2000), 2.
3. Ibid, 3.
4. See Timothy S. Sedore's interview with the author: "'Everything I Wrote Was Truth': An Interview with José Antonio Villarreal," *Northwest Review* 39, no. 1 (2001): 77–89.
5. Eve Kosofsky Sedwick, *Between Men: English Literature and Male Homosocial Desire* (New York: Columbia University Press, 1985).
6. Only Richard's parents are listed above Joe Pete, and his parents' beautiful nature is accompanied by the caveat "in another time" whereas Joe Pete's is not.
7. Although the two classmates are referred to as "queer as hell" (177), I use the term *gay* to describe them here because they live as openly gay men, closely aligned with David William Foster's definition.
8. He calls college a "waste of time" and says he is going to own a chain of grocery stores. Villarreal, *Pocho*, 110.
9. I am calling the sexual encounters involving the use of Zelda's body an *orgy* because it involves the participation of multiple members of the gang, either through voyeurism or through sharing Zelda's body. Others might use the term *gang bang*, which also requires the participation of multiple members; a circle jerk can certainly also be considered an orgy.
10. Gayle Rubin, "The Traffic in Women: Notes on the 'Political Economy' of Sex," in *The Second Wave: A Reader in Feminist Theory*, ed. Linda Nicholson (New York: Routledge, 1997), 27–62.
11. See René Girard, *Deceit, Desire, and the Novel: Self and the Other in Literary Structure* (Baltimore: Johns Hopkins Press, 1965), 1–52.
12. Tomás Rivera, *... y no se lo tragó la tierra/... And the Earth Did Not Devour Him* (Houston, TX: Arte Público Press, 1992), 100.
13. Ibid., 114. There is an interesting parallel here with Richard Rubio's assertion that the priest to whom he confessed his masturbatory acts was deriving pleasure from listening to Richard describe them. Ironically, these narratives are located on the same page number of the respective novels. See José Antonio Villarreal, *Pocho* (New York: Anchor Books, 1989), 114.
14. Rudolfo A. Anaya, *Bless Me, Ultima* (Berkeley: Tonatiuh International, 1972), 212.
15. Gloria Anzaldúa, *Borderlands/La frontera: The New Mestiza* (San Francisco, CA: Aunt Lute Books, 1987).
16. Montye P. Fuse, "Culture, Tradition, Family: Gender Roles in Rudolfo Anaya's *Bless Me, Ultima* (1972)," in *Women and Literature: Reading through the Lens of Gender*, ed. Jerilyn Fisher and Ellen S. Silber (Westport, CT: Greenwood Press, 2003).

17. Juan Bruce-Novoa, "Homosexuality and the Chicano Novel," in *European Perspectives on Hispanic Literature of the United States*, ed. Genevieve Fabre (Houston: Arte Público Press, 1988), 105
18. Karl J. Reinhardt, "The Image of Gays in Chicano Prose Fictions," in *Explorations in Ethnic Studies* 4, no. 2 (1981): 41–55.

4. La Movie Rara: Viewing Queer Chicana/o and Latina/o Identities

1. Gary D. Keller, "The Image of the Chicano in Mexican, United States, and Chicano Cinema: An Overview," in *Chicano Cinema: Research, Reviews, and Resources* (Binghamton, NY: Bilingual Review Press, 1985).
2. Charles Ramírez Berg, *Latino Images in Film: Stereotypes, Subversion, Resistance* (Austin: University of Texas Press, 2002).
3. David R. Maciel and Susan Racho, "'Yo soy chicano': The Turbulent and Heroic Life of Chicanas/os in Cinema and Television," in *Chicano Renaissance: Contemporary Cultural Trends*, ed. David R. Maciel, Isidro D. Ortiz, and María Herrera-Sobek (Tucson: University of Arizona Press, 2000), 104.
4. Data from Premiere Weekend Club, available at http://www.premiereweekend.org.
5. Alexander Doty, *Making Things Perfectly Queer: Interpreting Mass Culture* (Minneapolis: University of Minnesota Press, 1993), 12 (italics mine).
6. For the most part, different actors play character roles that correspond to unique stages in the lives of the characters.
7. Dennis West, "Filming the Chicano Family Saga," *Cineaste* 21, no. 4 (1995): 26.
8. The term was used primarily from the 1930s through the 1950s to refer to Mexican American youth who rejected mainstream culture and created their own style of dress and speech—largely associated with zoot suits and the use of Caló.
9. Carl Gutiérrez-Jones, *Rethinking the Borderlands: Between Chicano Culture and Legal Discourse* (Berkeley: University of California Press, 1995), 135.
10. Modern usage of the term in the United States is associated with Mexican American youth with a unique subculture that might include lowriders, hip-hop, or homeboy attire; it was appropriated in the 1960s and has been used since—in a derogatory sense by some and as a symbol of pride by others.
11. Her overweight body can also be considered a site for mapping queer identities. See my analysis of *Real Women Have Curves* in chapter 4.
12. Although larger than life to many while alive, Selena became a household name and a popular icon in the United States and abroad only after her highly publicized death.

13. Carlos E. Cortés, "Chicanas in Film: History of an Image," in *Chicano Cinema: Research, Reviews, and Resources*, ed. Gary D. Keller (Binghamton, NY: Bilingual Review Press, 1985).
14. Rosa Linda Fregoso, *The Bronze Screen: Chicana and Chicano Film Culture* (Minneapolis: University of Minnesota Press, 1993), 93.
15. Gloria Anzaldúa, *Borderlands/La frontera: The New Mestiza* (San Francisco: Aunt Lute Books, 1987), 79.
16. José E. Limón, "Selena: Sexuality, Performance, and the Problematic of Hegemony," in *Reflexiones 1997: New Directions in Mexican American Studies*, ed. Neil Foley (Austin: University of Texas Press, 1997), 2.
17. Deborah Parédez, "Remembering Selena, Re-membering *Latinidad*," *Theatre Journal* 54, no. 1 (2002): 63–84.
18. Richard Dyer, "In Defense of Disco," in *Out in Culture: Gay, Lesbian, and Queer Essays on Popular Culture*, ed. Corey K. Creekmur and Alexander Doty (Durham, NC: Duke University Press, 1995), 410.
19. Marianne Thesander, *The Feminine Ideal* (London: Reaktion Books, 1997), 210.
20. One sign of this is that she has stopped using her jacket over her bustier in her performances.
21. Adrienne Rich, "Compulsory Heterosexuality and Lesbian Existence," in *The Lesbian and Gay Studies Reader*, ed. Henry Abelove, Michèle Aina Barale, and David M. Halperin (New York: Routledge, 1993), 192.
22. América Ferrera also stars in the popular television series *Ugly Betty*, where a similar critique of female beauty standards takes place. The show is replete with queer cultural signifiers.
23. In another scene, she jokingly tells her English instructor, Mr. Guzmán (George López), "I don't lie on applications, except about my weight."
24. Susan Bordo, *Unbearable Weight: Feminism, Western Culture, and the Body* (Berkeley: University of California Press, 1993), 143.
25. Josefina López, "Playwright's Notes," in *Real Women Have Curves* (Woodstock, IL: Dramatic Publishing Company, 1996), 6.
26. Margo Milleret, "Girls Growing Up, Cultural Norms Breaking Down in Two Plays by Josefina López," *Gestos: Revista de teoría y práctica de teatro hispánico* 13, no. 26 (1998): 119.
27. María P. Figueroa, "Resisting 'Beauty' and *Real Women Have Curves*," in *Velvet Barrios: Popular Culture and Chicana/o Sexualities*, ed. Alicia Gaspar de Alba (New York: Palgrave Macmillan, 2003), 275.
28. Naomi Wolf, *The Beauty Myth: How Images of Beauty Are Used against Women* (Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press, 1992), 7.

5. Rape, Violence, and Chicana/o and Latina/o Identities

1. Cherríe Moraga, *Giving Up the Ghost; A Stage Play in Three Portraits* [1986], in *Literatura chicana 1965–1995: An Anthology in Spanish,*

English, and Caló, ed. Manuel de Jesús Hernández-Gutiérrez and David William Foster (New York: Garland Publishing, 1997), 320.

2. Michel Foucault, *Discipline and Punish: The Birth of the Prison* (New York: Vintage, 1995), 138.
3. Elaine Marks and Isabelle de Courtivron, eds., *New French Feminisms* (New York: Schocken Books, 1981), 194.
4. For photos, see http://antiwar.com/news/?articleid=2444.
5. Carl Gutiérrez-Jones, *Rethinking the Borderlands: Between Chicano Culture and Legal Discourse* (Berkeley: University of California Press, 1995), 110.
6. María Herrera-Sobek, "The Politics of Rape: Sexual Transgression in Chicana Fiction," in *Chicana Creativity and Criticism: New Frontiers in American Literature*, ed. María Herrera-Sobek and Helena María Viramontes (Albuquerque: University of New Mexico Press, 1996), 254.
7. Monica Brown, *Gang Nation: Delinquent Citizens in Puerto Rican, Chicano, and Chicana Narratives* (Minneapolis: University of Minneapolis Press, 2002), xvi.
8. Eve Kosofsky Sedgwick, *Between Men: English Literature and Male Homosocial Desire* (New York: Columbia University Press, 1985).
9. Other ways include committing criminal acts, such as stealing, or committing acts of violence against others to demonstrate one's allegiance to the gang. Forcing female initiates to engage in sexual intercourse with select male members is another practice that is sometimes used.
10. Typically, the males "jump in" the males while the females "jump in" the females.
11. Yxta Maya Murray, *Locas* (New York: Grove Press, 1997), 49.
12. Considering these individuals have already been rejected from the dominant culture, they are often willing to do whatever it takes to be accepted into another, especially one that is modeled after the dominant culture.
13. David Grann, "The Brand: How the Aryan Brotherhood Became the Most Murderous Gang in America," *New Yorker*, February 16, 2004, 157.
14. Tomás Almaguer, "Chicano Men: A Cartography of Homosexual Identity and Behavior," *Differences* 3, no. 2 (1991): 75–100.
15. Alfredo Mirandé, *Hombres y machos: Masculinity and Latino Culture* (Boulder, CO: Westview Press, 1997), 138.
16. Paul Kivel, *Boys Will Be Men: Raising Our Sons for Courage, Caring and Community* (Gabriola Island, Canada: New Society Publishers, 1999), 12.
17. Frederick Luis Aldama, "Penalizing Chicano/a Bodies in Edward J. Olmos's *American Me*," in *Decolonial Voices: Chicana and Chicano Cultural Studies in the 21st Century*, ed. Arturo Aldama and Naomi H. Quiñónez (Bloomington: Indiana University Press, 2002), 87.
18. In one particular scene, she gives Santana driving lessons in her car so that he can assume that expected male role—once again, to no avail.

19. Santana knows exactly how the rape will be carried out and that the victim will be sodomized; his gang is also all too willing to carry out his orders in a fashion with which they are quite familiar. There is a minimal amount of communication that actually takes place because they are already conditioned to carry out requests for murder in this manner.
20. Yvette Flores-Ortiz, "Re/membering the Body: Latina Testimonies of Social and Family Violence," in *Violence and the Body: Race, Gender, and the State*, ed. Arturo Aldama (Bloomington: Indiana University Press, 2003), 345–59.
21. Kathleen Barry, Charlotte Bunch, and Shirley Castley, eds., *International Feminisms: Networking against Female Sexual Slavery* (New York: International Women's Tribune Center, 1984), 33.
22. Young boys are also mentioned as victims, however, the article focuses on the plight of females.
23. Peter Landesman, "The Girls Next Door," *New York Times Magazine*, January 25, 2005, 37.
24. Although some women conspire to traffic and enslave other women, the perpetrators of these acts are primarily men.
25. They are generally slender, young, and have long, dark hair.
26. Some of the murdered bodies that have been discovered show signs that they were used for some sort of satanic rituals, while others have been found dismembered with clothing items that presumably belong to other missing women/girls.
27. Alma Luz Villanueva, *Naked Ladies* (Tempe, AZ: Bilingual Press/ Editorial Bilingüe, 1994), 97.
28. Judith Butler, *Bodies That Matter: On the Discursive Limits of "Sex"* (New York: Routledge, 1993), 89.
29. Ana Castillo, *So Far from God* (New York: Plume, 1994), 84.
30. Theresa Delgadillo, "Forms of Chicana Feminist Resistance: Hybrid Spirituality in Ana Castillo's *So Far from God*," *Modern Fiction Studies* 44, no. 4 (1998): 907.

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